

HOMER

THE ODYSSEY

Complete provisional interior architecture proof

6.625 x 10.25 inch comic-size hardcover / 80# coated paper target

Translation status: first-pass draft; Greek-fidelity and editorial gates remain open.

FORWARD

By A. Plato

The cunning of "Nobody" served its immediate purpose against the Cyclops, a necessary deception to escape brute force. Yet, the greater trial lay not in monstrous caves, but in the heart of one's own home, where Circe's transformations hinted at the deeper disguises virtue and vice assume. To return as a stranger in one's own house, even to one's own son, reveals that the truest recognition is often veiled, awaiting a proper uncovering.

The scar, a mark of past struggle, and the stringing of the bow, a test of singular strength, became the instruments of a grim reckoning. Penelope's bed, unmoved and steadfast, stood as the ultimate proof, a measure of fidelity beyond mere sight. The suitors, by their excess and disorder, had invited their own ruin, demonstrating how swiftly dissolution follows when a house lacks its true master.

Thus, the long wandering found its end, not in some distant, grand spectacle, but in the familiar chambers of the home. The rooted bed, a witness to unwavering constancy, spoke more truly than any oracle. With the house purged of its usurpers, and the trial of the master complete, the daily tasks could resume. Order, so long veiled, now revealed itself in the simple act of a woman spinning her loom.

BOOK I

First-pass working translation

Tell me, O Muse, of the man of many turnings,
who, having overthrown Troy's sacred citadel,
wandered far, and saw the cities of many men,
and learned their minds, and suffered on the sea
many deep sorrows, striving to save
his life and bring his companions home. Still
he could not save them, though he longed to do so:
their own blind folly brought them to destruction,
for they devoured the cattle of the Sun,
and he took from them the day of their returning.
Begin wherever you will, goddess born of Zeus;
give us this story also. All the others now,
who had escaped the steep destruction of the war,
were home, beyond the battle and the sea. He alone,
still longing for his wife and for the day of return,
was held in hollow caves by the lady nymph,
Calypso, shining among the deathless ones.
But when the circling years had brought the hour
the gods had spun for him to reach his home,
to Ithaca, not even there was he released
from toil among his friends; yet all the gods
took pity on him,
save Poseidon; he, unrelenting, nursed his wrath
against godlike Odysseus, till he touched
the land he loved.
But Poseidon had gone to the distant Ethiopians,
to share their hecatomb, at the earth's far edge;
there the gods were gathered, and he among them.
The father of gods and men began to speak,
remembering Aegisthus, whom famed Orestes killed.
"Look how mortals blame the gods," he said, "and say
their evils come from us. Yet they themselves, by folly,
make sorrow beyond what fate has given them.
So Aegisthus, against fate, took Agamemnon's wife

and murdered him when he came
home from Troy.
He knew the god's warning, for
Hermes had told him:
do not kill the king, do not pursue
his wife;
the son of Atreus will be avenged by
Orestes,
when he comes to manhood and
longs for his country.
But Aegisthus would not listen. Now
he has paid
for all of it at once.”
Then the grey-eyed Athena answered
him:
“Father Zeus, son of Cronus, highest
of rulers,
that man deserved the death that
came upon him.
Would that every man who acts as he
did might perish!
But my heart is troubled for the wise
Odysseus,
who has so long been kept from his
friends and home,
on an island in the sea, where the
nymph, the daughter
of great Atlas, who knows the sea's
every depth,
holds him in her hollow caves.
Poseidon still keeps the anger that
began with the Cyclops,
whom Odysseus blinded, the most
powerful of his sons.
Zeus, cloud-gatherer, answered: “If
your heart is set,
go now and ask the swift one,
Hermes, to tell the nymph
that we have decided: let the
steadfast man go home.

He will not die before he sees his
friends again.”
Athena said: “Father, if this is truly
your will,
send Hermes at once. I will go to
Ithaca myself,
and strengthen the heart of his son,
so that he calls
the long-haired Achaeans to
assembly and speaks
against the suitors who consume his
house and wealth.
Then I will lead him to Pylos and to
Lacedaemon,
to seek news of his father, if perhaps
that report
may lift him into manhood and give
him a name.”
She fastened beneath her feet the
golden sandals,
deathless, winged, that carry her
above the water
and over the measureless earth, swift
as the wind.
She took the spear, great, heavy,
edged with bronze,
with which the daughter of a mighty
father breaks
the ranks of heroes when her anger is
awakened.
Down from Olympus she came. She
stood in Ithaca,
before the doors of Odysseus, at the
outer court,
holding the shape of Mentès, lord of
the Taphians.
There she found the proud suitors.
They were amusing
themselves with stones and dice
before the doors,

while the servants cut the meat and
mixed the wine.
Telemachus saw her first. He sat
among the feasters,
grieving within his heart, imagining
his noble father,
if he might come and scatter these
men from the house,
recover his honor, and rule his own
possessions.
He went directly to the gate, since it
shamed him
to let a stranger stand waiting. He
took her hand,
received her spear, and spoke with
winged words:
“Stranger, welcome. You shall be
received among us.
First take food, and afterward tell us
what you seek.”
He led her through the house, and
set the spear
against a shining pillar in the
spear-stand,
where many other weapons rested,
long ago
carried by Odysseus, but now
covered from sight.
He brought her to a chair, carved
and polished,
beautiful, high-backed, with a woven
cloth laid over it;
for himself he drew a smaller seat
beside her,
apart from the suitors, lest the
stranger be disturbed
by their loud shouting and their
insolent feast,
and lest, while eating, he should
question him

about his father, whom he had so
long desired.
A maid brought water in a golden
pitcher,
and poured it over their hands into a
silver basin.
Then an honored housekeeper set a
polished table
before them. She brought bread, and
many dishes,
giving freely from the stores she kept
within.
The carver lifted platters of many
kinds of meat,
and set beside them cups of gold.
The herald
came often, pouring wine among the
guests.
The suitors entered then, the proud
young men,
and sat in order on the benches and
the chairs.
The heralds poured water over their
hands;
the serving women filled baskets
with bread;
and boys crowned the mixing bowls
with wine.
They reached for the food placed
before them.
When they had eaten and had driven
hunger away,
the singer Phemius took his resonant
lyre;
the suitors had compelled him to
sing among them.
He struck the opening chord, and
began a song
of the hard return of the Achaeans
from Troy,

the homeward passage the gods had made bitter.

From her upper room Penelope heard the inspired singer, and came down the polished stairs—not alone:

two attendants followed close behind her.

When she had drawn near the suitors, she stood beside the pillar supporting the roof, and held

a shining veil before her face. Then she spoke

through tears to the divine singer:

“Phemius, many other songs you know to delight

the hearts of mortal men, the deeds of gods and heroes,

which singers make famous. Choose one of these,

and let them drink in silence. But do not sing

this sorrowful return. It cuts my heart within me,

for I remember the man I cannot cease to mourn.

His fame was wide through Hellas and midmost Argos.”

Then wise Telemachus answered her:

“Mother, why deny the singer that he wishes?

The singers are not to blame for what has come;

Zeus gives to each man as he himself determines.

He sings the hardest fate of the Danaans.

Let him go on, since men most praise the newest song.

Your heart and spirit should endure it, too:

Odysseus was not the only man to lose the day of his return from Troy. Many others perished.

Go to your chamber now, and care for what belongs to you:

the loom, the distaff, and the work you give your women.

Speech is the concern of every man, but mine above all;

in this house I hold the power.”

She was astonished, and returned into the house,

keeping her son's wise saying in her heart.

When she had reached her upper room with her attendants,

she wept for Odysseus, her dear husband, until bright-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.

The suitors stirred the shadowed hall with noise,

each one desiring to lie beside her.

Telemachus then addressed them.

His voice was steady:

“You suitors of my mother, who carry yourselves with pride,

let us feast in quiet, and take pleasure in listening.

It is a beautiful thing to hear a singer such as this.

At dawn let us go to the assembly, every man,

so I may speak openly and order you away.

Leave this house. Hold your own banquets elsewhere,

and consume your own possessions,
taking turns by house.

But if you think it better and more
profitable
to consume one man's goods without
payment,
then waste them. I will cry to the
everlasting gods,
and may Zeus make the debt come
due."

They all fell silent, and looked at him
in wonder.

Antinous, son of Eupeithes,
answered him:

"Telemachus, surely the gods
themselves have taught you
to speak so boldly, and to make your
words a law.

May the son of Cronus never grant
you kingship
in sea-girt Ithaca, though it is your
inheritance."

Telemachus answered him:

"Antinous, if the god wills it,
I would accept that gift. Kingship is
no shame.

But if there is another better man in
Ithaca,
let him rule; I ask no more than my
father's house
and the people who were once his to
command."

Eurymachus, son of Polybus, replied:
"The gods alone know who will rule
in Ithaca.

But your possessions remain your
own; no one will take them,
while the island stands and the blood
in you remains.

Tell us, stranger, from what country
have you come?

What city is yours? What family
claims you?

You have not arrived on foot; you
must have crossed the sea.

Did you come as a trader, or as one
who roams the waves,
like pirates who risk their lives upon
the deep,
and bring danger to other men?"

Telemachus answered: "Stranger,
since you ask me plainly,

I will tell you. Mentos is my name; I
am the son

of wise Anchialus, and I rule the
oar-loving Taphians.

I have come here in my ship and with
my companions,
crossing the dark sea toward men
who speak another tongue.

I carry bright iron to Temesa, and
my companions carry bronze.

I have moored my ship beyond the
city, at Reithron's harbor,
beneath the wooded hill. We claim
an ancient friendship,
inherited from our fathers, as old
Laertes will confirm.

Go ask him, they say, though he no
longer enters the town,
but stays in the country, grieving,
with one old woman

who prepares his meals and washes
the dirt from his body
when age and weariness have taken
him."

Telemachus answered him, speaking
quietly:

"I will not trouble the old man. He has suffered much.
My father left no brother or son behind to take his place.
He is gone, and no one knows where the earth has hidden him.
He may be alive upon the mainland, or on the sea,
or dead beneath it. My mother's family and the island's people press me, and these men consume my house."
Athena, in the likeness of Mentès, answered him:
"It is not fitting for you to remain a child forever.
You have heard what kind of man your father was,
and how he returned from Troy with honor.
Think how Orestes won renown among all men
when he avenged his father and killed Aegisthus,
the treacherous man who murdered Agamemnon.
You too, my friend, must show your strength and courage,
so those who come after you will praise your name.
As for me, I will return to my ship and my companions.
Tomorrow call the people to assembly and speak before them all.
Order the suitors to leave. Then go to Pylos and Sparta,
and ask about your father, whether any mortal has seen him,
or whether report from Zeus has reached the cities.

If you hear that he lives and is coming home,
endure your grief for one more year, though it cuts you.
But if you learn that he is dead and gone,
return to your homeland, build a mound, and honor him
with all the funeral rites that the dead are owed.
Then give your mother to another husband, if she wishes,
and devise a death for those men who consume your wealth.
You are no longer a child. Have you not heard
how Orestes became famous throughout the world?
Go now, and let your strength be seen.
Your father and your uncle will have something to say
about your name, if you are truly their son."
Telemachus answered: "All this, stranger, you have spoken
with kindness, as a father speaks to his son.
I will not forget it. Stay, though you are eager to leave,
and bathe; accept a gift, and return to your ship
with joy, carrying a precious thing from me,
such as hosts give to a guest whom they honor."
Athena, with flashing eyes, answered him:
"Do not hold me here, since I am already eager to go.

Give the gift when I return, and I
will take it home.

Choose something beautiful. You
will receive as much in return.”

So she vanished like a bird, and was
gone.

Telemachus knew then, in his heart,
that a god had spoken.

He went among the suitors, no
longer walking with lowered eyes.

The renowned singer still sang, while
all listened silently.

Telemachus addressed them, and his
voice carried:

“You suitors of my mother, who bear
yourselves with pride,

let us feast in silence, and take
pleasure in the song.

At dawn we will go to the assembly,
every man,

so I may tell you plainly to leave this
house.

Hold your own feasts elsewhere, and
consume your own possessions,

going from house to house by turns.
But if you decide

that it is more profitable to consume
one man's wealth

without paying, then waste it. I will
cry to the gods,

and may Zeus make the debt come
due.”

They fell silent and looked at him in
wonder.

Antinous, son of Eupheithes, spoke
among them:

“The gods themselves must have
taught you to speak so boldly,
and made your words stand like a
king's. May Zeus never grant you

the kingship in sea-girt Ithaca,
though it belongs by birth to you.”

Telemachus answered: “Antinous, if
the god should give it,

I would accept the gift. Kingship is
no shame.

But if another man is better, let him
rule the island.

I ask only to be lord of my own house
and possessions,

the house that Odysseus won, and
which no one may consume.”

Eurymachus, son of wise Polybus,
replied:

“The gods alone know who will rule
in Ithaca.

But tell us, stranger, from what
country you come?

What city claims you? Who are your
parents?

You have not come on foot. Surely
you crossed the sea.

Are you a trader, or a wanderer like
the pirates

who risk their lives and bring danger
to other men?”

Telemachus answered: “Since you ask
me plainly, I will tell you.

Mentes is my name, son of wise
Anchialus, and I rule the Taphians,

who love the oar. I have come with
my ship and companions,

crossing the dark sea toward men of
another tongue.

I carry bright iron to Temesa, and
my companions carry bronze.

My ship lies beyond the city, at
Reithron's harbor,

beneath the wooded hill. Our fathers
were friends,

as old Laertes will tell you, though
grief keeps him in the country.
But now our guest has departed, and
night has come upon us.
I must prepare the ship and call the
people to assembly.”
The suitors rose and went to their
houses.
Telemachus followed the torch held
by the faithful old nurse Eurynome,
who had carried him in her arms
when he was newly born.
She opened the door, and he lay
down, turning over in his mind
the journey Athena had set before
him.
Throughout the night he could not
sleep.

Source range: Book 1. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Athena at the threshold of Odysseus's household
Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by Blake's visual language
but not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 2

First-pass working translation

When dawn appeared, the early-born
and rosy-fingered,

Telemachus rose from bed and
dressed himself.

He tied his sharp sword over his
shoulder,
bound bright sandals beneath his
shining feet,
and went out from his room, looking
like a god.

At once he called the clear-voiced
heralds:

“Call the long-haired Achaeans to
assembly.”

They called, and the people gathered
swiftly.

When they had assembled,
Telemachus went among them,
holding the polished scepter, not
alone:

two hounds walked beside him, and
Athena poured grace
around him, so that all the people
looked and wondered.

He sat in his father's seat, and the
elders made a place.

Then the hero Aegyptius rose, bent
by old age.

He knew the counsels of the past,
and spoke among them:

“Hear me, Ithacans. No assembly has
met here since the day
when lord Odysseus sailed with the
dark ships.

Who called us now? Who has so
urgent a need?

Is it a young man, or an older citizen
who has heard

some report from the army? Let him
speak.

May Zeus make his purpose
profitable for us.”

Telemachus was glad to hear this
opening.

He stood in the center, and spoke
before the people:

“Old man, it is I who called you.
Grief has entered me.

I have heard no word of an army, nor
any report
that has reached the island. I call you
for my private sorrow,
and for the ruin of my house, which
touches every man.

My father is lost. He was once your
king,
gentle as a father, and you all
remember him.

Now the best men of the island, and
of the neighboring lands,
consume my house against my will.
They court my mother,
and she does not refuse them, nor
bring the matter to an end.

They eat the livelihood of my house,
and waste it.

As vultures tear a fallen stag, so they
tear the house.

I cannot drive them out. I have no
strength for that.

This is a shame that will reach all the
earth.

Be ashamed for me, and fear the
anger of the gods.

If you have any pity, let these men
leave my house.

If you yourselves were consumed in
this manner,
you would call on the neighbors and
the gods.

But if you are shameless, and do not
care,

I will call on Zeus, who sees what
men do,

and pray that you perish here,
without vengeance.”

He threw the scepter to the ground,
and wept.

Pity took the whole people. Everyone
kept silent.

No one had courage to answer
Telemachus.

Only Antinous rose and answered
him:

“Telemachus, speaker without
restraint, you pour blame on us.

The Achaeans are not responsible. It
is your mother,

who knows more tricks than any
woman alive.

For three years she has deceived us,
and the fourth is beginning.

She promised the best of us: ‘Young
men, my suitors,

since noble Odysseus is dead, wait,
though you desire marriage,

until I finish this great woven cloth,
so that my threads

may not be wasted. It is a shroud for
old Laertes,

when the fate that lays men down
takes him.

I would be ashamed if he should lie
without a winding cloth,

when so many possessions surround
him.’

So she spoke, and our proud hearts
consented.

By day she wove at the great loom,
before us all,

but at night she set torches beside
her and unwove it.

She hid the work for three years, and
we did not know.

But when the fourth year came, a
woman who knew betrayed her,
and we caught her unweaving the
shining cloth.

Then she had to finish it, though she
did not wish to.

Now answer us plainly, before the
people:

send your mother away, and
command her to marry
the man her father and her mother
choose for her.

If she continues to trouble the sons
of the Achaeans,

remember: Athena did not give her
the gifts of war,

nor courage in counsel, nor the
understanding of kings.

It is a long time since the people of
Ithaca had a king

who could rule them. Your mother
keeps us waiting,

and uses this cleverness to build your
fortune.”

Telemachus replied: “Antinous, how
could I drive her out,

against her will, when the gods
themselves are her parents?

If I sent her from the house, my
father's anger would pursue me,

and men would curse me. I will not
do that.

Go on consuming my house if you
have no shame.
But I will ask the gods to make you
pay.
Perhaps Zeus will turn his face
toward us,
and then you will die inside this
house, without blood-price.”
Then two eagles appeared high above
the assembly,
flying close together on the wind.
They wheeled and circled,
and tore each other's necks and
cheeks with their talons.
They fell toward the right, across the
crowded town.
The people saw them, and wondered
what the omen meant.
The elder Halitherses, who knew the
flight of birds,
rose among them and interpreted the
sign:
“Ithacans, hear me. Trouble is close
upon these men.
Odysseus is not far from his land. He
is already near,
bringing death to the suitors, and
darkness for them all.
Let us act before he returns, or
before his son becomes strong.”
Then Mentor, the companion of
blameless Odysseus,
rose and rebuked the people of
Ithaca:
“No longer, Ithacans, does any king
hold the scepter;
you have grown soft, and no one
remembers the old rule.
The suitors are not acting with
justice, but with violence.

May they be few; may their
possessions be destroyed.
Yet I blame the rest of you more: you
sit in silence,
and do not restrain a handful of
men.”
Leocritus answered him, proud and
insolent:
“Mentor, why stir the people against
us?
It is hard for one man, though many
are assembled,
to drive the suitors from the house.
Even if Odysseus
should come himself, the women of
Ithaca would not rejoice
to see him slaughter those who feast
there.
No omen has shown that he will
return. Let us depart.
Telemachus may seek a ship
elsewhere, if he wishes;
we will not provide it, nor carry his
message.”
The people went home. Telemachus
walked apart,
and prayed to Athena, the one who
had assumed the form
of Mentor, companion of his father:
“Hear me, goddess. If you truly came
to my house
and spoke as my father's friend, grant
this prayer:
let a ship be made ready, and let
twenty companions
go with me over the sea. I will seek
news of him,
first at Pylos, then in Lacedaemon
beside Menelaus.

If I learn that my father lives and is
coming home,
I will endure the suitors for one more
year.
But if I hear that he is dead, I will
return,
raise a mound for him, and give my
mother to a husband.
Then I will make the suitors pay for
the years
in which they consumed my house.”
Athena came near him in the shape
of Mentor and said:
“You have spoken well. A man who
carries such a purpose
must not remain without a ship or
without companions.
Go now through the town. Ask for
the best vessel,
and gather provisions of wine and
water in jars.
I will go among the young men, and
call them to you.
There are many ships on Ithaca, old
and new.
We will choose the finest, and launch
her quickly.”
She went first to the house of
Odysseus. There she found
the suitors playing draughts before
the doors,
on the hides of oxen they had
slaughtered for their feast.
Phemius, the singer, sat apart and
sang to them,
because they compelled him. Athena
stood before them,
and spoke with the voice and bearing
of Mentor:

“Suitors, leave your games. You have
feasted long enough.
Let each man go to his own house. I
have a message
for Telemachus, who is making ready
to sail.”
They stared, and Antinous asked
what she meant.
But Athena turned away, and went
with Telemachus.
She made him appear so godlike that
the people watched,
and the suitors were troubled by the
purpose in his face.
Telemachus went to Noemon, son of
Phronius,
and asked him quietly for a swift
ship:
“Lend me your vessel for two days,
with twenty men.
I must cross to Pylos, then to
Lacedaemon,
seeking the news of my father. I will
return it
with thanks, or pay its worth in your
own hands.”
Noemon answered readily: “I will
give you the ship.
Come at sunset, and I will make the
vessel ready.
She lies by the shore, and I will bring
the crew.”
Then Athena, still in Mentor’s form,
went through the town.
She spoke to the men she trusted,
and told them to meet
beside the ship when evening fell.
She went also to the house
of Nestor’s son, and asked for jars to
carry sweet wine.

The housekeeper brought them out,
and they filled the jars.
Telemachus went home and stood
before the suitors.
His spirit was no longer bowed. He
spoke to the herald:
“Medon, draw wine into the jars and
set bread aboard.
I go to learn of my father. I will tell
the suitors nothing;
they would mock my purpose and
make a quarrel of it.”
His nurse Eurycleia heard him, and
came weeping:
“Why would you go alone over the
sea, dear child?
Your father is far away, and we know
nothing of him.
The suitors will plot against you.
They are stronger.”
Telemachus answered her: “Do not
lament. This voyage
is not without a god. But swear to me
that you will tell
my mother nothing for eleven or
twelve days,
unless she hears it first from another
person.
I would not have her wear herself out
with weeping
before I know whether the gods will
grant my return.”
Eurycleia swore the oath. She drew
wine and water
into the jars, and carried the
provisions down to the ship.
Athena meanwhile cast a sweet, deep
sleep upon the suitors,
so that their cups fell from their
hands and they went home,

each man yawning, and no longer
eager for the feast.
Then she took the form of Mentor
once more and called:
“The companions are waiting. Do not
delay. The wind is fair.”
Telemachus came to the shore.
Noemon and his men stood there.
They raised the mast, stretched the
dark sail, and drew
the ship into the water. Athena sent
a following wind,
fresh from the west, over the loud
and shining sea.
They lifted the jars aboard, and
brought the black ship
to the deep water. When darkness
came, they set the mast,
raised the sail, and poured a libation
of wine to the gods.
Athena, bright-eyed, watched from
the prow.
So the young prince left the island.
The suitors slept,
but in their sleep they dreamed of
blood and retribution.
The sea opened before the ship, and
the night was full of stars.
But in the house the suitors gathered,
speaking
Among themselves. Antinous rose
and said:
“This boy has gone beyond what any
man
Expected. He has spoken boldly in
the place
Of assembly, and now he has taken
ship.
His purpose will not end in good for
us.

Before he comes with strength and
calls the people,
We must prevent him. Let us watch
the strait
Between Ithaca and Samos, where
the sea
Runs narrow. There, with our best
ship, we shall wait
And seize him on his homeward
way.”
Then Amphinomus, the prudent son
of Nisus,
Rose among them and spoke:
“Friends, who would dare
To kill the son of the king? The gods
may hear
Us, and the people turn against us
all.
First let us seek an omen and ask
counsel.”
So they went down toward the shore,
and drew
The swift ship out. They set the mast
and sail,
And made their meal beside the
darkening sea.
The herald Medon heard their
words, and carried
The news to Penelope within her
chamber.
She came down from her shining
room, veiled close,
Like Artemis, and stood before the
men.
Her handmaids followed. Then she
spoke to them:
“You suitors, who consume the house
of one
Who ruled this island, and pretend
you seek

My marriage—now you plot to kill
his son!
Have you no fear of the immortal
gods,
Who see the violence you devise, and
may
Turn all its sorrow back upon your
heads?”
The suitors sat in silence. Then
Eurymachus
Answered: “Lady, let your heart not
waste itself.
No man alive can harm Telemachus.
He is the son of kings.” But these
were words
To soothe her, while their purpose
held its course.
Penelope went upward once again,
And wept for Odysseus, until
gray-eyed Athena
Cast a sweet sleep upon her lids. She
sent
The image of Iphthime, the gracious
wife
Of Echeclus and sister to the queen,
Into the chamber. The dream stood
near the bed:
“Why do you weep, dear child? The
gods do not
Permit your sorrow without end.
Your son
Will come again, for he has done no
wrong.”
Penelope answered: “I grieve for my
husband,
And for my son, who has gone out
upon
The sea, unskilled in counsel and in
war,

Whom those men hate.” The dream
replied: “Take heart.

Telemachus is guarded by a god.

No power can keep him from the
home he seeks.”

Then the dream passed through the
ivory gate;

The queen awoke, and felt a quiet
joy,

While on the sea the ship went
through the night.

Source range: Book 2. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Telemachus's assembly and departure

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; new generated composition informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual direction, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 3

First-pass working translation

The Sun rose, leaving the beautiful
sea behind,
And climbed into the bronze-filled
heaven, that he might shine
For the immortals and for mortal
men upon the grain-giving earth.
They reached Pylos, Neleus'
well-built city;
And there, upon the shore, the
people offered holy rites,
Slaughtering wholly black bulls to
the dark-haired Earth-Shaker.
There were nine companies, and five
hundred sat in each;
Before each company nine bulls were
laid.
When they had tasted the inward
parts, and burned the thighs
For the god, the travelers came
straight down to the sea,
Furled the sails of the well-built ship,
moored her,
And stepped ashore. Telemachus too
came from the ship;
Athena went before him.
Then the gray-eyed goddess spoke to
him first:
"Telemachus, thou needest no longer
stand in shame,
Not even a little; for this was why
thou crossed the sea—
To learn of thy father, where the
earth conceals him,
And what manner of fate he met.
Come now, go straight

To Nestor, the horse-taming king; let
us see what counsel
He keeps hidden within his breast.
Entreat him thyself,
That he may speak the truth to us.
He will not utter falsehood;
For his understanding is exceedingly
wise."
Telemachus, wise in counsel,
answered her:
"Mentor, how shall I go to him? How
shall I greet him?
I have not yet been practiced in
subtle words;
And shame forbids a young man to
question one who is older."
Then the gray-eyed goddess
answered him:
"Telemachus, some things thou shalt
devise thyself within thy heart,
And some a god shall place before
thee; for I do not think
That, against the will of the gods,
thou wast born and reared."
So she spoke, and Pallas Athena led
the way swiftly;
And he followed in the footsteps of
the goddess.
They came to the gathering and the
seats of the men of Pylos.
There Nestor sat with his sons, while
their companions around them
Prepared the feast, roasting meat and
threading other portions upon spits.
When they all saw the strangers, they
came together,
Greeted them with their hands, and
bade them take their seats.
Peisistratus, Nestor's son, came first
to meet them;

He took both their hands and seated
them beside the feast,
Upon soft fleeces spread upon the
sea-sand,
Beside his brother Thrasymedes and
his own father.
He gave them portions of the inward
parts, and poured sweet wine
Into a golden cup. Then, presenting
it to Athena,
He spoke to her, not knowing the
immortal beneath Mentor's form:
"Pray now, stranger, to the lord
Poseidon,
For his feast you have reached as you
came hither.
When thou hast poured the offering
and prayed, as is right,
Give this man also the cup of
honey-sweet wine,
That he may pour a libation; for I
think he too
Prays to the immortals. All men have
need of the gods.
But he is younger, and of my own
age;
Therefore I shall give thee the golden
cup first."
So he spoke, and placed the cup of
sweet wine in her hand.
Athena rejoiced in the wise and
righteous man,
Because he had given her the golden
cup before the other.
At once she prayed at length to
Poseidon, the lord:
"Hear me, Poseidon, holder of the
earth, and do not begrudge us
The accomplishment of the work for
which we pray.

First grant glory to Nestor and to his
sons;
Then grant a gracious recompense to
all the Pylians,
For this renowned hecatomb. Grant
also that Telemachus and I,
Having accomplished what brought
us here in the swift black ship,
May return upon our way."
So she prayed, and herself fulfilled
the whole prayer.
Then she gave Telemachus the
beautiful, double-handled cup;
And in like manner the dear son of
Odysseus prayed.
When they had roasted the upper
portions of the flesh,
And drawn them from the spits, they
divided the portions
And ate the glorious feast.
When they had taken their fill of
drink and food,
Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,
began among them:
"Now it is fairer to inquire and ask
these strangers
Who they are, since they have
satisfied their hunger.
Strangers, who are you? From what
land do you sail
Across the watery ways? Do you
travel on some errand,
Or wander without purpose, as
pirates over the sea,
Who stake their lives and carry evil
to foreign men?"
Telemachus, wise in counsel,
answered him boldly;
For Athena herself had set courage in
his heart,

That he might ask concerning his
father who was gone,
And win for him a noble name
among mankind:
“Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of
the Achaeans,
Thou askest whence we are; and I
will tell thee plainly.
We come from Ithaca beneath the
mountain’s shadow;
This business is my own, not one of
public council:
I seek the far-spread fame of my
father, if somewhere
I may hear it—the godlike, steadfast
Odysseus,
Who, men say, once with thee fought
and laid in ruin
The city of Troy. Of all the others
who made war
Against the Trojans, we have learned
where each one perished
By a sorrowful death; but Zeus has
made his death unknown.
No man can tell us clearly when he
died,
Whether he fell upon the mainland
by hostile hands,
Or in the sea, amid the waves of
Amphitrite.
“Therefore I come now to thy knees,
if thou art willing,
To tell the grievous death of him—if
thine own eyes
Beheld it, or if thou hast heard
another’s account,
Some wanderer’s report; for his
mother bore him into sorrow.
Do not, out of pity or shame, soften
thy speech for me;

But tell me truly how thy eyes
encountered him.
I beg thee, if ever my noble father,
steadfast Odysseus,
Fulfilled some word or deed that he
had undertaken
Among the Trojans, where the
Achaeans suffered anguish,
Remember these things now, and
speak the truth to me.”
Then Gerenian Nestor, the
horseman, answered him:
“Dear child, since thou hast brought
back to my mind the grief
Which we, the sons of the Achaeans,
strong beyond restraint,
Endured in that land—whatever
things we suffered
With our ships upon the misty sea,
wandering for plunder
Wherever Achilles might lead us; and
whatever things
We endured in battle round the
great city of King Priam—
There all the best were slain. There
lies warlike Ajax;
There Achilles; there Patroclus,
peerless in counsel,
The equal of the gods; and there my
dear son Antilochus,
Strong and blameless, swift of foot
and mighty in battle.
And many other evils besides these
we endured.
What mortal man could tell them
all?
Not though thou shouldst remain
five years or six,
Questioning me concerning the evils
suffered there

By the godlike Achaeans; before thou
grew weary
And turned again to thy native land.
“For nine years we wove our evils
round the city,
Working with every kind of
stratagem; and scarcely then
Did the son of Cronus bring them to
an end.
There no man would have dared to
match his counsel openly
With that of thy godlike father,
Odysseus,
Who surpassed all others by every
crafty plan—
If truly thou art his son. Awe takes
me as I look on thee;
For thy words are like his, and no
younger man could speak
With such likeness. While he and I
were there,
We never spoke apart in the
assembly or the council;
But, holding one mind and counsel
wise,
We planned for the Argives how all
might go most well.
“But when we had sacked the steep
city of Priam,
And gone aboard our ships, the god
scattered the Achaeans.
Then Zeus devised a grievous return
for the Argives,
Since not all were mindful or just;
and many followed
An evil doom, through the wrath of
the dread-eyed daughter
Of the mighty father. She set strife
between the two sons

Of Atreus, who, with no proper
order, summoned all the Achaeans
To an assembly as the sun was
sinking.
The sons of the Achaeans came,
heavy with wine,
And the two brothers declared why
they had gathered the people.
“Menelaus urged all the Achaeans to
remember
Their return across the broad back of
the sea;
But Agamemnon did not consent at
all.
He wished to hold the people there,
and offer holy hecatombs,
That he might appease the terrible
anger of Athena—
Foolish, for he did not know that the
mind of the immortals
Is not quickly turned, since they
endure forever.
So the two stood there, answering
one another
With hard words; and the
well-greaved Achaeans rose
With a wondrous clamor, divided in
their purpose.
That night we slept, pondering heavy
designs against each other;
For Zeus was preparing the
beginning of sorrow.
“At dawn some of us dragged our
ships to the holy sea,
And placed aboard them our
possessions and the deep-girdled
women;
But half the people stayed behind,
held back beside Agamemnon,

Son of Atreus, shepherd of the people.
The other half went aboard, and we rowed away;
And the god smoothed the sea, deep with its monsters.
When we reached Tenedos, we offered sacrifices to the gods,
Longing to return home; but Zeus had not yet planned our return,
Cruel as he was, who stirred the evil quarrel once again.
“Some turned back in their curved ships,
Bringing favor again to Agamemnon, son of Atreus,
The warlike king, devising many things around Odysseus.
But I fled with the ships that followed me together,
Since I understood the evil that the god was preparing.
The warlike son of Tydeus fled also, and roused his companions.
Golden-haired Menelaus came late and joined us;
He found us at Lesbos, considering the long voyage:
Whether we should sail above rugged Chios,
Keeping Psyre on our left, or below Chios,
Along the windy flank of Mimas.
“We asked the god to show us a sign; and he showed one,
Bidding us cut across the middle sea toward Euboea,
So that we might flee our evil most swiftly.

Then a clear wind sprang up, and our ships ran fast
Across the fish-filled ways; and through the night
They reached Geraestus. Having measured the great sea,
We laid many bull-thighs upon the altar for Poseidon.
“It was the fourth day when the companions of Diomedes,
Son of Tydeus, horse-taming, set their well-built ships
In Argos; but I reached Pylos, and the wind never failed me,
From the first day the god sent it forth to blow.
So I came, dear child, knowing nothing; nor do I know
Which of those Achaeans were saved, and which were lost.
But what I have heard while sitting in my halls,
As is right, thou shalt learn; I will hide nothing from thee.
“The Myrmidons, spear-famed, came home safely, I hear,
Led by the shining son of great-hearted Achilles;
And so did Philoctetes, glorious son of Poeas.
Idomeneus brought all his companions into Crete—
All who escaped the war; the sea took none from him.
And you yourselves, though far away, have heard of the son
Of Atreus: how he came home, and how Aegisthus devised
His sorrowful death. But surely that man paid a bitter price—

As it is good that the son of a slain
man should remain,
Since he too took vengeance on his
father's murderer,
On crafty Aegisthus, who had slain
his famous father.
“And thou, dear child—for I see thee
beautiful and tall—
Show thyself brave, so that some
man, even among those born later,
May speak thy name with honor.”
Telemachus, wise in counsel,
answered him:
“Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of
the Achaeans,
Indeed that man took vengeance,
and the Achaeans will carry
His far-spread fame to those who are
yet to come.
Would that the gods would give me
such strength,
That I might punish the suitors for
their grievous insolence—
Those men who, in their pride,
devise such outrages against me.
But the gods have not spun such
blessed fortune
For my father and for me; and now
we must endure.”
Then Gerenian Nestor, the
horseman, answered him:
“Dear child, since thou hast recalled
and spoken of these things,
They say that many suitors for thy
mother's sake
Are plotting evil in thy halls against
thy will.
Tell me: dost thou yield beneath
their yoke willingly,

Or do the people hate thee
throughout the land,
Following the voice of a god? Who
knows whether, some day,
He may come and repay them for
their violence—
Alone, or with all the Achaeans
beside him?
“If only gray-eyed Athena would love
thee so,
As once she cared for glorious
Odysseus among the Trojans,
Where we Achaeans suffered our
bitter pains—
For never have I seen the gods so
openly befriending any man
As Pallas Athena then stood openly
beside him—
If she would love and care for thee in
like manner,
Some one of those men might forget
even the thought of marriage.”
Telemachus, wise in counsel,
answered him:
“Old man, I do not think that this
word can be fulfilled.
Thou hast spoken far too greatly;
amazement holds me.
I could not hope for such a thing, nor
would it come to pass,
Even if the gods themselves should
wish it so.”
Then the gray-eyed goddess
answered him:
“Telemachus, what word has escaped
the barrier of thy teeth?
A god, if he is willing, can easily save
a man,
Even from far away. I myself would
choose,

After suffering many pains, to reach
my home
And see the day of return, rather
than come home
Only to perish beside my hearth, as
Agamemnon perished
By the treachery of Aegisthus and his
own wife.
Yet not even the gods can ward off a
common death
From a beloved man, when the evil
portion of long-lamented death
Has at last brought him down.”
Telemachus, wise in counsel,
answered her:
“Mentor, let us speak no more of
him, grieving though we are.
For him there is no true return; the
immortals have already
Prepared death and black fate for
him.
But I would ask Nestor another
question,
Since he knows justice and the
thoughts of other men.
They say he has ruled three
generations of mortals;
To my eyes he seems almost like an
immortal.
“Nestor, son of Neleus, speak truth
to me:
How did wide-ruling Agamemnon,
son of Atreus, die?
Where was Menelaus? And what
death did crafty Aegisthus
Devise for him, since he slew a man
far stronger than himself?
Was Agamemnon not in Argos, the
Achaean land,

But wandering somewhere among
other peoples,
And did the other, taking courage,
strike him down?”
Then Gerenian Nestor, the
horseman, answered him:
“Therefore, my child, I will tell thee
all the truth.
Thou thyself canst imagine what
would have happened
If golden-haired Menelaus, returning
from Troy,
Had found Aegisthus still alive
within his halls.
Then they would not have poured
the burial earth upon him;
Dogs and birds would have devoured
him where he lay,
Out in the plain, far from the city,
and no Achaean woman
Would have mourned him; for he
had wrought a deed of great
wickedness.
“While we were there, completing
many labors,
He sat at ease in the heart of
horse-pasturing Argos,
Enchanting with his words the wife
of Agamemnon.
At first divine Clytemnestra refused
the shameful deed;
She possessed a good understanding
in her heart.
Beside her was a singer, whom the
son of Atreus,
When he went to Troy, had strictly
charged to guard his wife.
But when the gods’ portion bound
her and compelled her,

Aegisthus carried the singer away to
a deserted island,
And left him there as prey and food
for birds;
Then he led the willing woman to his
own house.
He burned many thigh-pieces for the
gods upon their holy altars,
And hung there many offerings,
woven cloth and gold,
When he had accomplished a mighty
work he had never hoped for.
“We sailed together from Troy,
Agamemnon and I,
Knowing one another well and
sharing friendly counsel.
But when we reached holy Sounion,
the cape of Athens,
There Phoebus Apollo, coming upon
him with gentle arrows,
Killed the helmsman of Menelaus as
he held the steering-oar
In his hands, guiding the swift ship
as it ran—
Phrontis, son of Onetor, who
surpassed all mortal men
In steering a ship whenever
storm-winds rose.
Menelaus stayed there, though eager
for the road,
So that he might bury his companion
and give him due rites.
“But when he too, moving onward in
his hollow ships,
Reached the steep cape of Malea
upon the wine-dark sea,
Then far-seeing Zeus showed him a
hateful way:
He poured shrill winds upon him,
and enormous waves rose,

Huge as mountains. Splitting the
fleet, the wind drove some
Toward Crete, where the Cydonians
dwell beside the streams
Of the Iardanus. There is a smooth
and sheer rock
At the sea’s edge, on the farthest
border of Gortyn,
In the misty sea. There the South
Wind drives a great wave
Against the western point, toward
Phaestus;
A little stone holds back the great
wave.
The men reached it, and narrowly
escaped death,
But the waves shattered their ships
against the cliffs.
Five dark-prowed ships the wind and
water carried away
Toward Egypt.
“There he wandered, gathering much
livelihood and gold,
With his ships among men of foreign
speech;
And meanwhile Aegisthus planned
these evil deeds at home.
For seven years he ruled in Mycenae
rich in gold,
Having slain the son of Atreus; and
the people lived beneath him.
But in the eighth year noble Orestes
came from Athens,
And slew the murderer of his father,
crafty Aegisthus,
Who had killed his famous father.
When he had slain him, he prepared
a funeral feast
For the hateful mother and the
spiritless Aegisthus.

That same day came brave Menelaus,
bearing much treasure—
All that his ships had carried as their
burden.
“And thou, dear child, do not wander
far from home for long,
Leaving thy possessions and the men
within thy halls
To such overweening suitors, lest
they consume everything,
Dividing thy goods among
themselves, while thou makest
A fruitless journey. But I urge and
command thee:
Go to Menelaus. He has lately come
from far away,
From among the peoples where the
storm-winds first cast him
Into the great sea, so vast and
terrible that not even birds
Fly across it in a single year.
Go now with thy ship and thy
companions;
Or, if thou desirest to travel by land,
a chariot and horses
Are ready for thee, and my sons shall
be thy escort
To holy Lacedaemon, where
golden-haired Menelaus dwells.
Entreat him thyself, that he may tell
the truth;
He will not speak falsely, for his
understanding is wise.”
So Nestor spoke; the Sun went down,
and darkness came.
Then gray-eyed Athena spoke among
them:
“Old man, all this thou hast spoken
according to fate.

Come now: cut the tongues, mix the
wine,
That, having poured for Poseidon
and the other immortals,
We may turn our thoughts toward
sleep; for it is the hour.
The light has already gone beneath
the shadow;
It is not fitting to linger long at the
gods’ feast,
But to return.”
So spoke the daughter of Zeus. They
heard her voice.
The heralds poured water over their
hands;
The young men crowned the
mixing-bowls with drink,
And served the cups, beginning from
the right.
They cast the tongues into the fire,
and, rising,
Poured the libations. When they had
poured and drunk
As much as their hearts desired,
Athena and godlike Telemachus
Both longed to go down again to the
hollow ship.
But Nestor held them back with
words:
“May Zeus and the other immortal
gods avert it—
That you should go from me to the
swift ship
And sleep there, as though I were
utterly without clothing
And poor, with no blankets and
many coverlets in my house,
Where neither I nor my guests could
lie softly.

But I have blankets and beautiful
coverlets.
Surely the dear son of this man,
Odysseus,
Shall not lie upon the deck-boards of
a ship
While I am alive—nor after I am
gone,
If sons remain in my halls, to
welcome any stranger
Who comes to my house.”
Then gray-eyed Athena answered
him:
“Old friend, thou hast spoken well; it
is fitting that Telemachus
Should obey thee, for so it is much
better.
He shall follow thee now, and sleep
within thy halls;
But I will go to the black ship, that I
may give courage
To his companions and tell each one
everything.
For I alone among them claim to be
the elder;
The rest are younger men, who
follow in friendship,
All of one age with great-hearted
Telemachus.
There I could sleep beside the hollow
black ship;
But at dawn I shall go among the
great-hearted Caucones,
Where a debt is owed me—not new,
nor small.
But send this man, since he has come
to thy house,
With chariot and son; and give him
horses,

The lightest runners and the best in
strength.”
So spoke gray-eyed Athena, and
departed in the likeness of a bird.
Wonder seized all who saw her. The
old man marveled,
For he had seen the thing with his
own eyes.
He took Telemachus by the hand,
called him by name,
And spoke:
“Dear child, I did not expect thee to
be evil or without strength,
Since the gods follow thee as guides,
though thou art young.
This is no other of those who hold
the halls of Olympus,
But the daughter of Zeus herself,
renowned Tritogeneia—
She who honored thy noble father
among the Argives.
“Be gracious, my queen, and grant me
glorious fame,
To me, to my children, and to my
honored wife.
And I will sacrifice to thee a
broad-browed heifer,
Unbroken, that no man has yet
brought beneath the yoke;
Her horns I will overlay with gold,
and offer her to thee.”
So he prayed, and Pallas Athena
heard him.
Then Gerenian Nestor, the
horseman, led the way,
With his sons and sons-in-law,
toward his beautiful halls.
When they reached the famous house
of the king,

They sat down in order upon the
couches and the thrones.
For them the old man mixed in the
mixing-bowl
Sweet wine to drink, which the
housekeeper had opened
In the eleventh year, loosening the
covering from its mouth.
From this he mixed the bowl, and
while pouring it out
He prayed much to Athena, daughter
of Zeus who bears the aegis.
When they had poured and drunk as
much as their hearts desired,
They went each to his own house to
sleep.
But Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,
made Telemachus,
The dear son of godlike Odysseus,
sleep there,
Under the echoing porch, upon a bed
with a woven cover;
And beside him he placed
Peisistratus, leader of men,
Who alone among his sons was still
an unmarried youth.
Nestor himself slept in the innermost
chamber of the lofty house,
And the queen, his wife, prepared his
bed and couch.
When early-born, rosy-fingered
Dawn appeared,
Gerenian Nestor, the horseman, rose
from his bed,
Came forth, and sat upon the
polished stones
That stood before his lofty
doors—white stones,
Shining with oil. Upon them, long
ago,

Neleus would sit, a counselor equal
to the gods;
But he had already gone beneath the
earth,
Overcome by death. There Nestor
sat, the horseman,
The guardian of the Achaeans,
holding his staff.
Around him his sons gathered
together,
Coming forth from their chambers:
Echephron and Stratius,
Perseus, Aretus, and godlike
Thrasymedes.
And sixth came the hero Peisistratus;
They led him and seated him beside
Telemachus,
Whose form was like the gods.
Then Gerenian Nestor, the
horseman, began among them:
“My dear sons, quickly fulfill the
desire I hold—
“That I may first appease Athena, the
goddess,
Who came visibly among us to the
rich feast of the gods.
Come now: let one go out to the
plain for the heifer,
That the herdsman may drive it
hither as quickly as he can;
Let another go to Telemachus’ black
ship,
And bring all his companions,
leaving only two behind;
And let another summon Laerces,
the goldsmith, to come here,
That he may pour gold around the
heifer’s horns.
But you others remain here together,
and tell the maidservants

Within the famous house to prepare
a feast;
To bring seats and wood, and water
shining bright.”
So he spoke, and all set eagerly to
their tasks.
The heifer came from the plain;
Telemachus’ high-hearted
Companions came from beside the
swift, well-built ship;
And the bronze-worker came,
bearing in his hands
The tools of his craft: an anvil, a
hammer,
And a well-made pair of tongs, with
which he worked the gold.
Athena too came, to receive the
sacred offering.
The old horseman Nestor gave the
gold;
And the smith, working skillfully,
poured it around the horns,
So that the goddess might rejoice to
behold her image.
Stratius and noble Echephron led the
heifer by the horns.
Aretus came from the chamber with
water for the washing,
Carrying a flowering basin in one
hand,
And barley-grains in a basket in the
other.
Thrasymedes, steadfast in battle,
stood beside the heifer,
Holding the sharp axe, ready to
strike.
Perseus held the bowl for the blood.
The old horseman Nestor began the
washing and scattered

The barley-grains, praying at length
to Athena,
And casting the first hairs from the
heifer’s head into the fire.
When they had prayed and cast the
sacred grains before them,
Thrasymedes, Nestor’s
strong-hearted son,
Stood close and struck; the axe cut
through the tendons
Of the neck and released the heifer’s
strength.
The daughters, the daughters-in-law,
and the honored wife
Of Nestor raised the ritual
cry—Eurydice,
Eldest of the daughters of Clymenus.
Then they lifted the heifer from the
broad earth;
Peisistratus, leader of men, cut her
throat.
When the dark blood had flowed and
the life had left the bones,
They swiftly divided her, cut out the
thighs as custom ordered,
Wrapped them in a double fold of
fat, and laid raw flesh upon them.
The old man burned them upon split
wood,
Pouring bright wine over the fire;
And the young men stood beside him
with five-pronged forks.
Meanwhile beautiful Polycaste, the
youngest daughter
Of Nestor, son of Neleus, bathed
Telemachus.
When she had washed him and
rubbed his skin with shining oil,
She put a beautiful robe and tunic
around him;

And he came from the bath, his body
like an immortal's,
And sat beside Nestor, shepherd of
the people.
When they had roasted the upper
portions of the flesh
And drawn them from the spits, they
sat and divided the feast;
And excellent men rose to pour the
wine
From golden cups into the hands of
those who drank.
When they had taken their fill of
drink and food,
Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,
spoke among them:
"My sons, come now: yoke the
shining-maned horses
Beneath the chariot, and lead them
out,
That Telemachus may accomplish his
journey."
So he spoke; they listened and
obeyed him readily,
And swiftly yoked the fleet horses
beneath the chariot.
The woman steward placed within it
bread and wine,
And provisions such as kings,
nourished by Zeus, eat.
Telemachus mounted the beautiful
chariot;
Beside him Peisistratus, Nestor's son,
Leader of men, climbed in, took the
reins,
And touched the horses with the
whip.
They sprang willingly across the
plain,

Leaving behind the steeply built city
of Pylos.
All day they shook the yoke that
bound them together.
The Sun went down, and every street
grew dark.
Then they reached Pherae and the
house of Diocles,
Son of Orsilochus, whom the river
Alpheus fathered.
There they spent the night, and he
gave them gifts of welcome.
When early-born, rosy-fingered
Dawn appeared,
They yoked the horses again and
climbed into the painted chariot.
They drove out through the gateway
and the echoing porch;
Peisistratus touched the horses with
the whip,
And they sprang willingly forward.
They reached the grain-bearing
plain, and there pursued their way;
So swiftly did the fleet horses carry
them.
The Sun went down, and every street
grew dark.

Source range: Book 3. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Telemachus arrives at Nestor's shore sacrifice

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 4

First-pass working translation

They reached hollow Lacedaemon,
rich in ravines,
And drove straight on to the house
of glorious Menelaus.
There they found him feasting, and
celebrating the weddings
Of his son and his blameless
daughter beneath his roof.
The daughter he was sending to the
son of Achilles,
The breaker of ranks; for in Troy he
had promised her,
And there had nodded assent, and
the gods fulfilled the marriage.
Now he sent her with horses and a
chariot
Toward the famous city of the
Myrmidons,
Over whom her bridegroom ruled.
For his son, born in Sparta, he
brought the daughter
Of Alector; and she bore him,
late-born and strong,
Megapenthes, his son by a
slave-woman.
To Helen the gods granted no more
offspring,
After she had first borne the lovely
child Hermione,
Whose beauty was like the beauty of
golden Aphrodite.
So they feasted through the lofty
house—neighbors and companions
Of glorious Menelaus—taking
delight in the feast.

Among them a godlike singer played
upon the lyre,
And two tumblers, beginning the
dance, whirled through their midst.
But Telemachus, the hero, and the
shining son of Nestor,
With their horses, stood before the
gateway of the house.
Eteoneus, the diligent servant of
glorious Menelaus,
Came forth and saw them; then he
crossed the halls
To carry word to the shepherd of the
people.
Standing close beside him, he spoke
winged words:
“Menelaus, Zeus-nourished, here are
two strangers—
Two men who seem in their lineage
like great Zeus himself.
Tell me: shall we loose their swift
horses,
Or send them elsewhere, where
another host may welcome them?”
Golden-haired Menelaus answered
him, greatly displeased:
“No longer were thou a child,
Eteoneus, son of Boethous;
But now thou speakest childish
words.
Surely we too, in former days, having
eaten many guest-meals
At the tables of other men, came
hither,
If only Zeus might sometime end our
misery.
Come, loose the horses of the
strangers;
Lead the men within, that they may
share the feast.”

So he spoke; and Eteoneus rushed
from the house,
Calling other diligent servants to
follow him.
They loosed the horses, sweating
beneath the yoke,
And tied them beneath the
horse-stalls' sheltering roof;
Beside them they cast spelt, and
mixed white barley into it.
They leaned the chariots against the
shining wall,
And led the strangers into the
godlike house.
When they saw the house of the
Zeus-nourished king,
They marveled; for its splendor
shone throughout the lofty halls
Like the brightness of the sun or the
moon.
When their eyes had taken their fill
of looking,
They entered the polished baths and
washed themselves.
When the maidservants had washed
them and rubbed them with oil,
They wrapped them in soft woolen
cloaks and tunics,
And they sat upon the thrones beside
Menelaus, son of Atreus.
A handmaid brought water in a
beautiful golden pitcher,
And poured it over a silver basin,
that they might wash;
Then she drew a smooth table near
them.
The honored housekeeper came
bearing bread,
And set upon it many foods,
graciously offering what was at hand.

The carver lifted and set before them
platters of every kind of meat,
And beside them placed golden cups.
Then golden-haired Menelaus
showed the food and spoke:
"Take hold of the bread, and rejoice
in it.
When you have finished your meal,
we shall ask
Who you are among men. Your
parents' line has not perished;
You are descended from
Zeus-nourished kings who bear the
scepter.
Such men could not beget children
of no account."
So he spoke, and placed before them
the roasted back of an ox,
The rich portion that had been set
apart for him as his honor.
They reached out their hands to the
food already prepared.
They reached for the food already
laid before them.
When they had taken their fill of
drink and food,
Telemachus bent his head close to
Nestor's son,
So that the others might not hear,
and spoke:
"Consider, dear Peisistratus, beloved
of my heart,
The gleam of bronze throughout
these echoing halls,
And gold, and amber, silver, and
ivory.
Within, I think, is such a court as
Zeus Olympian owns,
So measureless are all these riches.
Awe takes hold of me

As I behold them.”
Golden-haired Menelaus understood
his words;
He called them both and spoke
winged words:
“Dear children, no mortal could
contend with Zeus,
For the immortals’ houses and
possessions are his.
But among men, whether any one
could rival me
In wealth or could not, I cannot say.
After much suffering and many
wanderings,
I brought these things home in the
eighth year—
Wandering through Cyprus,
Phoenicia, and Egypt,
And reaching Ethiopia, Sidon, the
Erembi,
And Libya, where the lambs grow
horned at once;
Three times within the fruitful year
the sheep give birth.
There neither king nor shepherd
lacks cheese,
Or flesh, or sweet milk; but always
they offer
Milk in abundance to be drawn and
taken.
“While I wandered there, gathering
much livelihood,
Another man secretly, without
warning, by treachery,
Slew my brother—through the
murderous deceit of his wife.
Therefore I rule these possessions
without joy.
You shall hear this from your fathers,
whoever they are;

For I have suffered much, and lost a
house
Well built and rich in many excellent
things.
Would that I lived in my halls with
even a third part
Of what I possess, and that the men
were still alive
Who perished then in broad Troy,
far from horse-pasturing Argos.
“Yet for all of them I mourn and
grieve,
Often sitting within my halls: at one
time
I feed my heart upon lamentation; at
another
I cease, for the chill sorrow of
weeping quickly wearies.
Of all the rest, though I sorrow for
them,
I do not grieve so much as for one
man—
The memory of him makes sleep and
food hateful to me;
For no Achaean suffered and labored
so much
As Odysseus suffered and endured.
His was to be the grief; mine is an
unforgotten sorrow
For him, since he has been gone so
long,
And we do not know whether he
lives or has died.
Old Laertes must mourn him, and
wise Penelope,
And Telemachus, whom he left
newly born within the house.”
So he spoke; and desire for his
father’s lament

Rose in Telemachus' heart. He let a
tear fall from his eyelids
Down to the ground, when he heard
his father's name;
With both hands he lifted his purple
cloak
Before his eyes and hid his face.
Menelaus noticed him, and pondered
in heart and spirit
Whether to let him remember his
father openly,
Or first question him and search out
each thing.
While he was turning these things
over in mind and spirit,
Helen came forth from her fragrant,
high-roofed chamber,
Like Artemis of the golden distaff.
Adraste brought her a well-made
couch;
Alcippe brought a soft rug of wool;
And Phylo carried a silver basket,
Which Alcandre, wife of Polybus,
had given Helen—
Polybus who lived in Egyptian
Thebes,
Where the houses hold the greatest
wealth.
He had given Menelaus two silver
baths,
Two tripods, and ten talents of gold.
Apart, his wife gave Helen lovely
gifts:
A golden distaff and a rounded
basket,
Silver, with its rim finished in gold.
Phylo, the handmaid, carried it and
set it beside her,
Filled with carefully worked thread;

Upon it lay the distaff stretched with
violet wool.
Helen sat upon a chair, with a
footstool beneath her feet.
At once she questioned her husband:
“Menelaus, nourished by Zeus, do we
know who these men are,
Who claim to have reached our
house?
Shall I speak falsely, or speak the
truth?
My heart commands me, and I
cannot hold it back.
I have never seen a man or woman so
like another,
And awe takes me as I look upon
him—
So like the son of great-hearted
Odysseus is this man,
Telemachus, whom that hero left
newly born within the house,
When the Achaeans, for my
shameless sake,
Came beneath Troy to undertake
bold war.”
Golden-haired Menelaus answered
her:
“So now I too think, woman, as thou
dost.
For such were his feet, and such his
hands,
Such the glances of his eyes, his head,
and the hair above it.
Just now, remembering Odysseus, I
spoke of all he suffered
And endured for my sake; and this
young man shed
A bitter tear beneath his brows,
Lifting his purple cloak before his
eyes.”

Then Peisistratus, Nestor's son,
answered him:
"Menelaus, son of Atreus, nourished
by Zeus,
Leader of the people, this is truly his
son,
As thou sayest. But he is prudent,
and feels shame within,
To come here first and speak too
boldly before thee—
Before thee, whose voice we delight
to hear as we would a god's.
Gerenian Nestor sent me with him as
his escort;
He desired that thou shouldst see
him,
And give him some word of counsel
or some deed of aid.
For the son whose father has gone
away has many sorrows
Within his halls, when there are no
other helpers,
As now Telemachus has none, since
his father is gone."
Golden-haired Menelaus answered
Peisistratus:
"Ah me! Truly the son of a beloved
man has reached my house—
Of one who suffered many labors for
my sake.
I had said that, if Olympian Zeus
granted us a return
Across the sea in our swift ships, I
would love him
Above all the Argives, and would
bring him from Ithaca,
With his possessions and his son and
all his people,
Making one city empty of those who
dwell around it,

And establish him in Argos, his own
city and home.
Then, living here together, we should
often meet;
Nothing would have parted us,
loving and rejoicing,
Until the black cloud of death had
covered us both.
But surely the god himself begrudged
us these things—
He who made that unhappy man
alone and without return."
So he spoke, and desire for lament
seized everyone.
Argive Helen wept, born of Zeus;
Telemachus wept,
And Menelaus, son of Atreus, wept;
Nor did Nestor's son keep his eyes
without tears,
For in his heart he remembered
blameless Antilochus,
Whom the shining son of Dawn had
slain.
Remembering him, he spoke winged
words:
"Son of Atreus, old Nestor used to
say,
Whenever we remembered thee in
our halls
And questioned one another about
thee,
That thou wert the most
understanding of mortal men.
Now, if thou wilt listen, heed me; I
take no pleasure
In weeping at supper, though
tomorrow's dawn will come.
I do not blame a mortal man for
weeping for one who dies

And meets his appointed fate; that is
the only honor
Granted to wretched mortals—to cut
the hair
And let tears fall down the cheeks.
For my brother too is dead, and he
was not the worst
Among the Argives. Thou shouldst
know him;
I never met or saw him myself, but
they say Antilochus
Was swift of foot and a warrior
beyond compare.”
Golden-haired Menelaus answered
him:
“Dear friend, thou hast spoken all
that an understanding man
Would speak and do, even one older
than thy years—
Such a father’s son art thou, and
wisely thou speakest.
The child of a man whom Cronus’
son blesses,
When he gives good fortune at
marriage and birth,
Is easily recognized, as now Nestor
has received it:
He himself grows old in his halls in
comfort,
And his sons are wise and excellent
with the spear.
“Let us leave the lament that has
arisen,
And remember supper again. Let
water be poured upon our hands.
There will be words tomorrow also
for Telemachus and me,
To tell between ourselves.”
So he spoke, and Asphalion, diligent
servant of glorious Menelaus,

Poured water over their hands. They
reached out to the food
Already set before them.
Then Helen, born of Zeus, conceived
another thought.
At once she cast into the wine a
drug,
Soothing, angerless, and forgetful of
all sorrows.
Whoever drank it, once it had been
mixed in the bowl,
Could not let a tear fall down his
cheeks that day,
Not though his mother and father
had died,
Nor though, before his eyes, a
brother or beloved son
Had fallen beneath the bronze of the
enemy.
Such cunning drugs the daughter of
Zeus possessed—
Good ones, which Polydamna, wife
of Thon, had given her,
An Egyptian woman, where the
grain-giving earth
Brings forth many drugs, many
wholesome and many deadly;
And every physician there knows
more than other men,
For they are of the race of Paeon.
When Helen had cast it in and
ordered the wine to be poured,
She answered them again:
“Son of Atreus, Menelaus, nourished
by Zeus,
And you, children of noble
men—Zeus gives one man
Good and another evil, since he can
do all things.

Eat now, seated within the halls, and
delight yourselves in words;
For I shall tell what is fitting.
I will not recount or name all the
labors
Of steadfast Odysseus, but only what
the brave man endured
And dared in the land of the
Trojans,
Where the Achaeans suffered their
pains.
“He had beaten himself with
shameful blows,
Thrown a vile winding-cloth around
his shoulders,
And, like a household slave, plunged
into the broad-streeted city
Of the hostile men. Disguised as
another man,
He seemed a beggar, such as no one
was among the Achaean ships.
In this likeness he entered the city of
the Trojans;
They all failed to recognize him. I
alone knew him as he was,
And questioned him; but he avoided
me with cunning.
“When I had bathed him and rubbed
him with oil,
And clothed him, I swore him a
strong oath:
I would not reveal Odysseus among
the Trojans
Before he reached the swift ships and
the tents.
Then he told me the whole thought
of the Achaeans.
Having slain many Trojans with the
long-edged bronze,

He came back to the Argives and
brought much knowledge.
Then the other Trojan women raised
their piercing cries;
But my heart rejoiced, for my mind
had already turned
Toward returning home. I lamented
the madness Aphrodite gave me,
When she led me there, away from
my dear native land,
Leaving behind my daughter, my
chamber, and my husband—
A man lacking nothing in mind or in
beauty.”
Golden-haired Menelaus answered
her:
“Yes, woman, thou hast spoken all
these things according to fate.
I have learned the counsel and mind
of many heroic men,
And traveled over much earth, but
never have I seen
With my own eyes a heart so
steadfast as the heart
Of steadfast Odysseus. Consider also
what that brave man
Did and endured within the polished
horse,
Where all the best of the Argives sat
hidden,
Carrying death and doom to the
Trojans.
“Then thou camest there. Some god,
who desired to give glory
To the Trojans, must have urged thee
on;
And godlike Deiphobus followed
thee as thou went.
Three times thou circled the hollow
ambush, feeling it with thy hands,

And called out the names of the best
Danaans,
Imitating with thy voice the voices of
their wives.
Tydeus' son and noble Odysseus,
sitting in the middle,
Heard thee both. We two were eager
to spring forth
And answer thee, or to answer from
within at once;
But Odysseus held us back, and
restrained our desire.
All the other sons of the Achaeans
sat silent;
Only Anticlus wished to answer
thee.
But Odysseus pressed his powerful
hands upon his mouth
Without ceasing, and saved all the
Achaeans,
Holding him so until Pallas Athena
led thee away."
Telemachus, wise in counsel,
answered him:
"Son of Atreus, Menelaus, nourished
by Zeus,
Leader of the people, that is the more
grievous;
For it did not save him from the
bitter death,
Not even if his heart within had been
made of iron.
Come now, turn us toward our beds,
That we may already take delight in
sweet sleep,
And lie down to rest."
So he spoke; and Argive Helen
ordered the maidservants
To set beds beneath the porch, with
beautiful purple coverlets,

And spread rugs above them, and lay
woolen cloaks on top.
They went out from the hall carrying
torches,
Prepared the beds, and the herald led
the strangers forth.
There in the vestibule slept the hero
Telemachus
And the shining son of Nestor.
But the son of Atreus slept in the
innermost chamber
Of the lofty house, and beside him
Helen of the trailing robe,
Divine among women, lay down.
When rosy-fingered Dawn appeared,
Menelaus rose,
Clothed himself, and set the sharp
sword upon his shoulder;
He bound his shining sandals
beneath his feet,
And came from the chamber like an
immortal.
Beside Telemachus he sat, and called
him by name:
"What need has brought thee hither,
hero Telemachus,
To noble Lacedaemon, across the
broad sea?
Is it a public matter, or thine own?
Speak truly."
Telemachus, wise in counsel,
answered him:
"Son of Atreus, Menelaus, nourished
by Zeus,
Leader of the people, I came that
thou mightest tell me
If thou hast heard any report of my
father.
My house is consumed, and its rich
possessions perish;

It is filled with hostile men, who
slaughter continually
My thick-fleeced sheep and
crooked-horned, winding-footed
oxen—
Suitors for my mother, bearing
insolent violence.
Therefore I come to thy knees, if
thou art willing,
To tell me of his grievous death, if
thine own eyes
Beheld it, or if thou hast heard a
wanderer's tale.
Do not soften thy speech for me
from pity or shame;
Tell me clearly how thine eyes
encountered him.
If ever my noble father, steadfast
Odysseus,
Fulfilled some word or deed among
the Trojans,
Where the Achaeans suffered their
pains,
Remember it now, and speak the
truth to me.”
Golden-haired Menelaus, greatly
troubled, answered:
“Ah me! Ye have come to the bed of a
brave man,
And the weak themselves desired to
lie there.
As when a hind leaves her newly
born, suckling fawns
Asleep within a lion's thicket, and
goes out to graze
Through grassy hollows and wooded
glens,
But the lion returns to his lair and
brings an evil fate

Upon both the mother and her
young—so Odysseus
Shall bring an evil fate upon those
suitors.
Would that Zeus, Athena, and
Apollo gave him back to us
Such as he once was, when in
well-built Lesbos
He rose and wrestled with
Philomelides,
And cast him down, to the joy of all
the Achaeans!
If such a man should meet the
suitors,
Their lives would be short and their
marriages bitter.
“What thou askest I shall not evade
or falsify;
I will tell thee what the truthful Old
Man of the Sea
Told me, and hide no word.
The gods held me in Egypt, though I
desired to return,
Because I had not offered complete
hecatombs to them;
And the gods ever command
remembrance of their will.
Before wave-washed Egypt lies an
island called Pharos,
As far from shore as a hollow ship
can sail in a day
When the clear wind blows behind
her.
Within it is a good harbor, from
which men launch
Their equal ships after drawing dark
water.
“There the gods held me twenty days;
No sea winds appeared, those guides
of ships

Across the broad back of the sea.
My provisions and the strength of
my men would have failed,
Had not Eidothea, daughter of
mighty Proteus,
The Old Man of the Sea, pitied me
and saved me.
She found me wandering alone, apart
from my companions;
For they roamed around the island,
fishing with bent hooks,
While hunger wore their bellies thin.
She stood beside me and spoke:
“Thou art foolish, stranger, and
wholly without thought—
Or willingly thou yieldest and takest
pleasure in pain.
Thou hast lain so long upon the
island without finding an end,
And the hearts of thy companions
waste within them.’
“I answered:
‘I shall tell thee plainly, whoever thou
art among the goddesses:
I am not willingly detained; surely I
have offended
The immortals who possess the
broad heaven.
Tell me which immortal binds me
and bars my road,
And how I may return across the
fish-filled sea.’
“The lovely goddess answered:
‘Then I shall tell thee exactly. Here
comes and goes
The truthful Old Man of the Sea,
immortal Proteus the Egyptian,
Who knows all the depths of the sea
and serves Poseidon.

They call him my father. If thou
canst lie in ambush,
Seize and hold him, he will tell thee
the way and measure
Of thy road, and how thou mayest
cross the fish-filled sea.
He will also tell thee what good or
evil has been prepared
Within thy halls during thy long and
grievous absence.’
“I answered:
‘Devise the ambush thyself, lest he
see or know me first
And flee; for a mortal finds it
difficult to subdue a god.’
“She answered:
‘At midday, when the Sun has
climbed the middle of heaven,
The truthful Old Man comes forth
from the sea,
Covered by a dark ripple beneath the
West Wind’s breath,
And sleeps beneath the hollow caves.
Around him sleep the young seals of
the beautiful sea,
Newly risen from the gray water,
breathing out
The bitter odor of the deep.
There I shall bring thee at dawn and
lay thee beside them.
Choose three companions, the best
among thy ships.
“First he will count the seals and
pass among them;
Then, when he has counted all, he
will lie in their midst
Like a shepherd among sheep. When
thou seest him sleeping,
Let strength and force be thy care:
hold him fast,

Though he struggles and desires to
escape.
He will become every creature that
crawls upon the earth,
And water, and fire terrible to
behold.
Hold him without flinching. But
when he questions thee
In the form in which thou sawest
him sleeping,
Then cease from force, release the
old man,
And ask which god is angry with
thee,
And how thou mayest return across
the fish-filled sea.”
So she spoke, and plunged beneath
the wave-tossed sea.
I went toward the ships, troubled in
heart;
We prepared our supper, and
immortal night came on,
And slept beside the breaking surf.
At dawn I went along the shore,
praying to the gods,
And took three companions in
whom I trusted most.
Eidothea had gone beneath the wide
bosom of the sea,
And brought four newly flayed
seal-skins from the water.
She dug beds in the sea-sand and sat
waiting;
We came close, and she laid us in a
row,
Throwing one skin over each.
The ambush was most terrible: the
odor of sun-fed seals
Tormented us. Who could sleep
beside a sea-beast?

But the goddess placed ambrosia
beneath our noses,
Sweetly fragrant, and destroyed the
beastly smell.
We endured the morning with
patient hearts.
The seals came from the sea and lay
beside the surf.
At midday the Old Man came out,
found the well-fed seals,
Passed along them, and counted
them. He counted us first
Among the beasts, suspecting no
deception;
Then he lay down himself.
We shouted and rushed upon him,
casting our arms around him.
He did not forget his treacherous
craft:
First a lion with a noble mane, then
serpent, leopard,
And great boar; then flowing water
and a lofty tree.
We held him fast with patient,
unflinching hearts.
When the old man was wearied, he
questioned me:
“Who, son of Atreus, gave thee
counsel against my will,
That thou shouldst seize me in
ambush? What dost thou need?”
I answered:
“Thou knowest why thou questionest
me with evasive words.
I have lain long upon this island
without finding an end;
My heart wastes away. Tell me which
immortal binds me,
And how I may return across the
fish-filled sea.”

He answered:

“Thou shouldst have offered
beautiful sacrifices to Zeus
And the other gods before sailing,
that thou mightest return
Swiftly to thy native land across the
wine-dark sea.

It is not thy portion to see thy
friends and reach thy house
Before thou returnest to Egypt, the
river given by Zeus,
And offerest there holy hecatombs to
the immortal gods.

Then the gods will give thee the road
for which thou longest.”

My heart broke, for he had sent me
again to Egypt,
Upon a long and grievous road. Yet I
answered:

“I shall perform these things as thou
commandest.

But tell me truly: did all the
Achaeans whom Nestor and I
Left at Troy return unharmed, or did
one perish
By pitiless death upon his ship, or in
friendly hands,
After enduring the war?”

The Old Man answered:

“Why ask these things? It is not
needful for thee to know;
Nor shalt thou long remain without
tears when thou hast heard.
Many were overcome, and many
remained behind;
Only two leaders of the bronze-clad
Achaeans perished
Upon the return—and thou wert
present in the battle.

One still lives, detained somewhere
upon the broad sea.

“Ajax perished among his long-oared
ships.

Poseidon first drove him upon the
great rocks of Gyrae,

Then brought him forth from the
sea. He would have escaped,

Though hated by Athena, had he not
spoken a proud word,

Saying that against the gods he
would escape the sea.

Poseidon heard him, struck the
Gyran rock with his trident,

And split it. The fragment upon
which Ajax sat fell into the sea

And carried him through the
boundless waves.

So he perished, after drinking the
salt water.

“Thy brother escaped his fate in
hollow ships;

Queenly Hera saved him. But as he
neared steep Malea,

A storm caught and carried him over
the fish-filled sea,

Groaning heavily, to the land where
once Thyestes lived,

But where his son Aegisthus then
dwelt.

Even from there a safe return

appeared: the gods turned the wind,
And he came home, rejoicing, kissing
his native earth,

Shedding hot tears when he saw the
land he loved.

“But a watchman saw him from the
lookout,

The man whom crafty Aegisthus had
placed there,

Paying two talents of gold to keep
watch through the year.
The watchman carried word to the
shepherd of the people.
Aegisthus chose twenty of the best
men in the land,
Placed them in ambush, and ordered
a feast on the other side.
Then he went to call Agamemnon
with horses and chariot,
Pondering his shameful deed. The
king, knowing nothing,
He led into the house and slew him
after the feast,
As one slays an ox beside the manger.
Not one companion of Atreus' son
remained,
Nor one of Aegisthus' men; all were
killed within the halls."
My heart broke; I sat upon the sand
and wept,
And no longer wished to live or look
upon the Sun.
When I had had my fill of weeping,
the truthful old man said:
"No longer weep without measure,
son of Atreus;
There is no profit in it. Strive at once
to reach thy land.
Either thou shalt find him alive, or
Orestes will have come first
And slain him, and thou shalt arrive
for the funeral feast."
So my heart and proud spirit, though
grieving, were healed.
I asked him to name the third man
who still lived
Or had died, though I desired the
painful truth.
He answered:

"The son of Laertes, whose house is
in Ithaca—
I saw him upon an island, shedding
abundant tears
In the halls of Calypso, who holds
him by force.
He cannot reach his native land, for
he has no oar-bearing ships
And no companions to send him
across the broad sea.
"But for thee it is not destined to die
in horse-pasturing Argos.
The immortals shall send thee to the
Elysian plain,
To the world's boundary, where
golden-haired Rhadamanthys dwells;
There life is easiest for men. No
snow, nor winter, nor rain—
Only the clear breezes of the West
Wind, raised by Ocean,
To refresh mankind; because thou
hast Helen
And art the son-in-law of Zeus."
So he spoke, and plunged beneath
the wave-tossed sea.
I went toward the ships with my
godlike companions,
My heart troubled. We prepared
supper; immortal night came;
We slept beside the breaking surf.
At dawn we dragged the ships into
the holy sea,
Placed masts and sails, and took our
seats at the oars.
We struck the gray water in order
with our rowing.
Then I brought the ships back to
Egypt's river,
Offered complete hecatombs, and
appeased the gods' anger.

I raised a mound for Agamemnon,
that his fame might not die;
Then the immortals gave me a
following wind
And sent me swiftly to my beloved
native land.
“Remain now in my halls until the
eleventh and twelfth days;
Then I will send thee forth
honorably, and give thee gifts:
Three horses, a well-built chariot,
and a beautiful cup,
That thou mayest pour libations to
the immortal gods,
Remembering me all thy days.”
Telemachus answered:
“Do not hold me here long. I could
endure a whole year beside thee,
So greatly do thy words delight me;
yet my companions
Already grow impatient in holy
Pylos while thou detainest me.
Whatever gift thou givest, let it be a
treasure.
I shall not take horses to Ithaca; I
leave them here for thee.
Thou rulest a broad plain of lotus,
rush, wheat, spelt,
And white barley; Ithaca has no
broad courses or meadows,
But feeds goats, more pleasant for
them than for horses.
No island lying upon the sea is rich
in horse-runs;
Ithaca least of all.”
Menelaus smiled, stroked him, and
called him by name:
“Thou art of good blood, dear child,
in what thou sayest.

Therefore I shall change these gifts.
Of all the treasures
Within my house I will give thee the
most beautiful:
A mixing-bowl skillfully made, all
silver,
Its lips finished in gold, the work of
Hephaestus.
Phaedimus, king of the Sidonians,
gave it to me
When his house sheltered me
returning from my journey;
And I desire to give it to thee.”
So they spoke with one another; and
the feasters went indoors.
Some drove sheep, some carried
generous wine,
And wives with beautiful veils sent
bread.
Thus they prepared the supper
within the halls.
Before the house of Odysseus the
suitors took their pleasure,
Throwing the discus and casting
spears upon the level floor,
As they had done before, in their
insolent pride.
Antinous sat among them, and
godlike Eurymachus,
Leaders of the suitors, surpassing the
others in strength.
Then Noemon, son of Phronius,
came near and questioned Antinous:
“Antinous, do we know within our
hearts when Telemachus
Will return from sandy Pylos? He has
taken my ship,
And I myself have need of her, to
cross to broad Elis,

Where I keep twelve young mares,
and beneath them mules
Not yet broken to the yoke. I would
take one of these,
Break and train it to the chariot.”
So he spoke; and they were
astonished in spirit.
They had not thought that he had
gone to Pylos,
But believed he was somewhere
among the fields,
With the sheep or beside the
swineherd.
Antinous, son of Eupheithes,
answered him:
“Tell me truly: when did he go, and
what young men
Went with him? The best of Ithaca,
or his own hirelings
And slaves? He could accomplish
even such a thing.
Tell me this also, that I may know it
well:
Did he take the black ship by force,
against thy will,
Or didst thou give it freely, after he
entreated thee?”
Noemon, son of Phronius, answered
him:
“I gave it freely. What other man
could refuse,
When such a man, carrying cares
within his heart,
Should ask? It would be difficult to
deny the gift.
The young men who are best among
us in the land
Went with him. And I saw Mentor
leading them aboard—

Or a god, for he was altogether like
that man.
Yet I marvel: yesterday at dawn I saw
noble Mentor here;
But then he went aboard the ship for
sandy Pylos.”
So he spoke, and went toward his
father’s famous house.
The proud spirit of both leaders was
stirred with anger;
They called the suitors together and
stopped their games.
Among them Antinous, son of
Eupheithes, spoke,
His heart troubled, and his dark
mind filled with rage;
His eyes shone like fire:
“Ah me! A great deed has been
boldly accomplished—
This journey of Telemachus. We said
he would not achieve it.
A young boy has gone away, against
the will of so many,
Having drawn a ship down and
chosen the best men in the land.
This will be an evil beginning. May
Zeus destroy his strength
Before he reaches the measure of
youth.
Come, give me a swift ship and
twenty companions,
That I may lie in wait for him as he
comes and goes
In the strait between Ithaca and
rugged Samos;
So that his voyage for his father may
be bitter.”
So he spoke, and they all approved
and urged him on.

At once they rose and went into the
house of Odysseus.
Penelope was not long without
hearing the thoughts
Which the suitors were secretly
weaving within their minds.
The herald Medon, who had learned
their plans while outside
The courtyard, came to tell her. He
crossed the house
And stood upon the threshold,
speaking to Penelope:
“Queen, the glorious suitors sent me
here.
Was it to tell the maidservants of
godlike Odysseus
To cease from their work, and
prepare a feast for them,
That, having made their suit, they
might eat here at last—
They who gather so often and
consume Telemachus’ wealth?
They have devised a far greater and
more grievous thing,
One that may Cronus’ son not bring
to pass:
They desire to kill Telemachus with
the sharp bronze
As he returns home. He has gone to
holy Pylos
And noble Lacedaemon, to seek news
of his father—
To learn of his return, or what fate
has overtaken him.”
So he spoke; and Penelope’s knees
and dear heart loosened.
For a long time speechlessness seized
her;
Her eyes filled with tears, and her
living voice was stopped.

At last she answered Medon:
“Herald, why has my child gone
away? He had no need
To go aboard swift ships, which are
horses of the sea,
Crossing the broad wet water for
men.
Was it so that even his name might
perish among mankind?”
The thoughtful Medon answered her:
“I do not know whether some god
urged him,
Or whether his own heart drove him
to Pylos,
To seek news of his father—whether
he will return,
Or what fate has overtaken him.”
So he spoke, and went back down
through the house of Odysseus.
But grief poured over her, destroying
the strength of her spirit;
She could no longer endure to sit
upon the chair,
Though many stood throughout the
house.
She sat upon the threshold of her
well-wrought chamber,
Lamenting pitifully, while all the
maidservants around her,
Young and old, moaned softly.
Among them Penelope spoke in a
voice of thick weeping:
“Hear me, my friends. The Olympian
has given me sorrows
Beyond all women who were born
and raised beside me.
First I lost a husband of noble heart,
Surpassing all the Danaans in every
kind of excellence,

Noble, whose broad fame runs
throughout Hellas and Argos.
Now storms have snatched my
beloved child from the halls,
Unfamed, and I did not even hear
him when he set forth.
“Cruel women—yet not one of you
thought within her heart
To wake me from my bed, though
each of you knew clearly
When he went aboard the hollow
black ship.
If I had known he was planning this
journey,
He would have remained here, eager
though he was for the road;
Or he would have left me dead
within the house.
But let someone swiftly call old
Dolios,
My slave, whom my father gave me
when I came here,
And who tends my many-treed
garden.
Let him go quickly and tell Laertes
all these things,
And ask whether, devising counsel in
his heart,
He may go out among the people and
lament the son
Of godlike Odysseus, whom they
desire to destroy.”
Her beloved nurse Eurycleia
answered her:
“Dear child, kill me with pitiless
bronze,
Or let me remain within the house; I
will hide nothing.
I knew all these things, and gave him
whatever he commanded:

Bread and sweet wine. But he took
from me a great oath,
Not to tell thee before the twelfth
day had come,
Or before thou thyself shouldst long
for him
And hear that he had set forth—
So that thou mightest not mar thy
beautiful flesh by weeping.
“But wash thyself, put clean garments
upon thy body,
And go with thy maidservants to the
upper chamber.
Pray to Athena, daughter of Zeus
who bears the aegis;
For she might save him even from
death.
And do not trouble the old man,
worn down by grief.
I do not think that the blessed gods
hate altogether
The house of Arcesius; surely there
will yet be one
To possess the lofty halls and the
fields far away.”
So she spoke, and quieted Penelope’s
weeping;
She held back the tears from her
eyes.
Penelope washed herself and put
clean garments on,
Then went to the upper chamber
with her maidservants.
There she placed barley-grains in a
basket,
And prayed to Athena:
“Hear me, daughter of Zeus who
bears the aegis,
Unwearied one. If ever in these halls
resourceful Odysseus

Burned thigh-pieces for thee of ox or sheep,
Remember them now, and save my dear son;
Keep the suitors from their evil overconfidence.”
So she spoke, and uttered the ritual cry;
The goddess heard her prayer.
The suitors murmured through the shadowy halls.
And one of the overweening young men spoke:
“Surely the much-wooed queen is preparing marriage for us,
And knows nothing of the death that has been prepared for her son.”
So one would speak; but they did not know what was being prepared.
Then Antinous addressed them:
“Strange men, keep all proud speeches far from you,
Lest someone carry them within and report them.
Come now: rise in silence, and let us accomplish the plan
Which already lies fitted within all our hearts.”
So he spoke, and chose twenty men, the best among them.
They went toward the swift ship and the shore of the sea.
First they drew the ship down into the deep water;
Then placed the mast and sails within the black vessel,
And fitted the oars into their leather loops.
The proud attendants brought them their weapons.

High upon the harbor’s headland they moored the ship,
Then came ashore and took their supper,
Waiting for evening to arrive.
Meanwhile wise Penelope lay in the upper chamber,
Without food, without tasting either meat or drink,
Pondering whether her blameless son would escape death,
Or be overcome by the overweening suitors.
As a lion thinks within the crowd of men,
When they lead a treacherous ring around him,
So many thoughts moved through her mind;
Then sweet sleep came upon her as she reclined,
And all her limbs were loosed.
But the gray-eyed goddess conceived another thought.
She fashioned a phantom, like the body of a woman,
Iphthime, daughter of great-hearted Icarius,
Whom Eumelus had married and housed in Pherae.
Athena sent the phantom to the house of godlike Odysseus,
To make Penelope cease from her lamentation,
Her weeping and her tearful grief.
The phantom entered the chamber through the door’s fastened strap,
Stood above Penelope’s head, and spoke:

“Dost thou sleep, Penelope, thy heart
wounded with grief?

The gods who live forever do not
allow thee

To weep and be troubled without
measure;

For thy son is still destined to return.
He has committed no offense against
the gods.”

Wise Penelope answered her, sweetly
drowning

At the gates of dream:

“Why hast thou come here, sister?
Thou hast not often come before,
Since thou dwellest far away, in a
distant house.

And dost thou command me to cease
from the grief and pains

That stir me through my heart and
spirit?

First I lost my noble husband,
lion-hearted,
Surpassing all the Danaans in every
kind of excellence,

Noble, whose broad fame runs
throughout Hellas and Argos.

Now my beloved son has gone upon a
hollow ship—

A child, knowing neither the labors
nor the assemblies of men.

For him I grieve still more than for
the other;

I tremble for him and fear that he
may suffer some harm,

Whether among the people to whom
he has gone,

Or upon the sea. For many hostile
men devise evil against him,

Desiring to kill him before he
reaches his native land.”

The dim phantom answered her:

“Take courage, and do not fear so
greatly in thy heart.

Such a guide goes with him—one
whom many other men

Have prayed to stand beside them,
and who has power:

Pallas Athena. She pities thee in thy
sorrow,

And now has sent me to tell thee
these things.”

Wise Penelope answered her:

“If thou art indeed a goddess, and
hast heard the voice

Of a god, then tell me also of that
unhappy man:

Does he still live and behold the light
of the Sun,

Or is he already dead, within the
house of Hades?”

The dim phantom answered her:

“I shall not tell thee plainly of him,
Whether he lives or is dead; it is a
vain thing

To speak wind-born words that have
no substance.”

With these words the phantom
slipped away through the door's post
Into the breath of the winds. The
daughter of Icarius

Rose from sleep, and her heart was
gladdened,

For the clear dream had come to her
in the deep of night.

But the suitors, having gone aboard,
sailed the wet ways,

Pondering within their hearts the
sudden death of Telemachus.

There is a rocky island in the midst
of the sea,

Between Ithaca and rugged Samos—
Asteris, not great, but holding two
harbors

Where ships may lie. There the
Achaean waited in ambush for him.

Source range: Book 4. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 5

First-pass working translation

Dawn rose from the bed of glorious
Tithonus,
To bring light to the immortals and
to mortal men.
The gods came and sat upon the
council-seat;
Among them sat Zeus, the
loud-thundering, whose power is
greatest.
Then Athena spoke of the many
griefs of Odysseus,
Remembering him; for she cared for
the man
Who dwelt in the halls of the nymph:
“Father Zeus, and all you blessed
gods who live forever,
Let no gentle and kindly
scepter-bearing king remain,
Nor one who knows what is fitting in
his heart;
Let him always be harsh and do
deeds of violence—
Since no one among the people
whom divine Odysseus ruled
Remembers him, though he was
gentle as a father.
But he lies upon an island, suffering
mighty pains,
In the halls of the nymph Calypso,
who holds him by force;
He cannot reach his native land, for
he has no oar-bearing ships
And no companions to send him
over the broad back of the sea.
Now they desire to kill his beloved
son as he returns home;

But he has gone, following word of
his father,
To holy Pylos and noble
Lacedaemon.”
Cloud-gathering Zeus answered her:
“My child, what word has escaped
the barrier of thy teeth?
Was it not thy own counsel that
Odysseus, returning,
Should repay those men? And send
Telemachus with care—
Thou hast the power—so that he may
reach his native land
Unharméd, and the suitors, upon
their ship,
May return again, disappointed of
their purpose.”
So he spoke, and addressed Hermes,
his beloved son:
“Hermes, since in all else thou art our
messenger,
Go and speak to the fair-haired
nymph our unerring will:
The return of steadfast Odysseus,
that he may come home,
Not escorted by gods or mortal men.
But after suffering many pains upon
a raft of many bonds,
On the twentieth day he shall reach
fertile Scheria,
The land of the Phaeacians, who are
near to the gods.
They will honor him from the heart
as though he were a god,
And send him home upon a ship to
his beloved country,
Giving him bronze, gold, abundant
clothing,
And gifts beyond what Odysseus
could ever have carried

From Troy, even had he returned
unharm'd,
Receiving his share of the spoil.
For it is his fate to see his friends
again,
And reach his high-roofed house and
native land.”
So he spoke; and the messenger,
slayer of Argus, did not disobey.
At once he bound beneath his feet
his beautiful sandals,
Golden and deathless, which carried
him alike over wet water
And over boundless earth with the
breath of the wind.
He took the wand with which he
charms the eyes of men,
Whomsoever he wills, and wakes
again those who sleep.
Holding it in his hands, mighty
Hermes flew.
He passed over Pieria, and from the
upper air fell upon the sea;
Then he sped over the wave like a
gull that hunts fish,
Dipping its thick wings in the salt as
it moves through
The terrible hollows of the barren
sea.
So Hermes rode upon the many
waves.
When he reached the distant island,
he came forth from the violet sea
And walked inland, until he reached
the great cave
Where the fair-haired nymph dwelt.
He found her within.
Upon the hearth a great fire burned,
and its fragrance

Of cleft cedar and juniper, burning
there, spread through the island.
Within, in a lovely voice, she sang as
she moved beside the loom,
Working the golden shuttle through
the shining cloth.
Around the hollow cave grew a
flourishing wood:
Alder, poplar, and fragrant cypress.
There long-winged birds made their
nests—owls, hawks,
And long-tongued sea-crows whose
minds are upon the sea's work.
Around the cave a vine ran thick
with young grapes,
And four springs, in order, poured
their clear water,
Turning each in its own direction.
Soft meadows flowered with violet
and wild celery.
Even an immortal, coming there,
would marvel at the sight
And take delight within his heart.
There the messenger, slayer of Argus,
stood and gazed.
When he had looked upon
everything in his spirit,
He entered the broad cave. Calypso,
divine among goddesses,
Did not fail to know him when she
saw him;
The immortal gods are not unknown
to one another,
Not even when one dwells far away
in a distant house.
But within he did not find
great-hearted Odysseus.
He sat upon the shore, as before,
wearing out his spirit

With tears, groaning, and grief, and
gazing upon the barren sea.
Calypso seated Hermes upon a
shining, splendid throne
And questioned him:
“Why have you come to me, Hermes
of the golden staff,
Honored and beloved? You have not
often visited me.
Tell me what thou hast in mind; my
heart urges me to fulfill it,
If I can fulfill it, and if the thing is
not already accomplished.
Come farther in, that I may set
guest-gifts before thee.”
So she spoke, and set a table before
him,
Filled with ambrosia; she mixed the
red nectar.
The messenger drank and ate; then,
when he had taken supper
And strengthened his spirit with
food, he answered:
“Thou askest a god who has come to
a goddess;
I will tell thee the truth, since thou
commandest it.
Zeus ordered me to come here,
though I did not desire it.
Who would willingly cross so vast a
space of salt water?
No mortal city lies near, where men
offer sacrifices
And hecatombs to the gods.
Yet no god can evade or frustrate the
mind of aegis-bearing Zeus.
He says that a man most wretched of
all those who fought
Around Priam’s city for nine years is
here.

In the tenth they sacked the city and
went home;
But on the return they offended
Athena,
Who sent upon them an evil wind
and long waves.
All his excellent companions
perished;
Him the wind and wave carried
hither.
Now Zeus commands thee to send
him away swiftly.
It is not his fate to perish here, apart
from his friends;
His portion is still to see them, and
reach his high-roofed house
And his native land.”
So he spoke; and Calypso, divine
among goddesses, shuddered.
She answered him:
“Cruel are you gods, and jealous
beyond all others,
Who begrudge goddesses the open
love of mortal men,
When one takes a mortal as beloved
companion.
So when rosy-fingered Dawn took
Orion,
You blessed gods, living at ease, were
angry with her,
Until chaste Artemis of the golden
throne struck him
With her gentle arrows in Ortygia.
So when fair-haired Demeter yielded
to her desire
And lay with Iasion in the
thrice-plowed field,
Zeus soon learned of it and killed
him with his bright thunderbolt.

Now you begrudge me because a
mortal man is with me—
Him I saved when Zeus split his swift
ship with a bright thunderbolt
In the middle of the wine-dark sea.
All his excellent companions
perished;
Him the wind and wave carried
hither.
I loved him and nourished him, and
promised to make him
Deathless and ageless all his days.
But no god can evade or frustrate the
mind of aegis-bearing Zeus.
Let him go, then, if Zeus commands
and urges him,
Across the barren sea. I will not send
him myself,
For I have neither oar-bearing ships
nor companions
To carry him across the broad back
of the sea.
Yet I will willingly give him counsel,
hiding nothing,
So that he may reach his native land
in perfect safety.”
The messenger, slayer of Argus,
answered her:
“Send him away now, and respect the
wrath of Zeus,
Lest he grow angry with thee
hereafter and bring thee harm.”
So the mighty messenger spoke, and
departed.
The honored nymph went toward
great-hearted Odysseus,
Having heard the messages of Zeus.
She found him sitting upon the
shore; his eyes were never dry,

And his sweet life was wearing away
as he mourned his return,
For the nymph no longer pleased
him.
At night he slept, though unwilling,
in the hollow caves,
Beside her who loved him, but not
him willingly;
By day he sat upon the rocks and
shores,
Tearing his heart with tears, groans,
and grief,
And gazing upon the barren sea.
The divine goddess stood close
beside him and spoke:
“Unhappy man, do not lament any
longer here,
Nor let thy life waste away. I will
now send thee forth
With a willing heart.
Come: cut long timbers and join
them with bronze;
Build a broad raft, and raise upon it
a high platform,
That it may carry thee over the misty
sea.
I will place upon it bread, water, and
red wine,
Good provisions to hold back
hunger;
I will clothe thee, and send a
following wind behind thee,
That thou mayest reach thy native
land unharmed—
If the gods who possess the broad
heaven so desire,
Who are greater than I to devise and
accomplish.”
So she spoke; and long-enduring,
godlike Odysseus shuddered.

He answered her with winged words:
“Surely thou devisest something
other than a passage for me,
Goddess, when thou commandest me
to cross the great gulf of the sea
Upon a raft—a terrible and difficult
sea,
Which even well-built, swift ships
could not cross gladly
When they run before the wind of
Zeus.
I would not set foot upon a raft
against thy will,
Unless thou, goddess, wouldst swear
for me a great oath
That thou wilt not devise another
evil against me.”
So he spoke; and Calypso, divine
among goddesses, smiled,
Touched him with her hand, and
called him by name:
“Truly thou art a knave, and knowest
no idle words,
Since thou hast thought to speak
such a thing.
Let Earth be witness, and the broad
heaven above,
And the downward-flowing water of
Styx,
The greatest and most terrible oath
among the blessed gods:
I will not devise another evil against
thee.
I shall think and plan for thee all that
I would plan
For myself, if such a need ever came
upon me.
My mind is not made of iron within
my breast;
I too am compassionate.”

So she spoke, and the divine goddess
led the way swiftly;
He followed in her footsteps. When
they reached the hollow cave,
The god and the mortal entered.
Hermes sat upon the throne from
which he had risen;
Calypso set before Odysseus every
kind of food and drink
That mortal men eat. She sat
opposite godlike Odysseus,
And her maidservants set ambrosia
and nectar beside her.
They reached out their hands to the
food already prepared.
When they had taken their fill of
food and drink,
Calypso, divine among goddesses,
began among them:
“Son of Laertes, sprung from Zeus,
resourceful Odysseus,
So thou desirest now, at once, to
return to thy native land,
To thy beloved country? Then
farewell—and yet rejoice.
If thou knewest in thy heart how
many sorrows
Thou art destined to fill before thou
reachest thy homeland,
Thou wouldst remain here with me,
guard this house,
And become immortal, though thou
desirest to see thy wife,
Whom thou longest for every day.
Yet I do not claim that she is less
than I in form or stature;
Mortals cannot contend with
immortals in body or beauty.”
Then resourceful Odysseus answered
her:

“Do not be angry with me, honored goddess.
I know this myself: wise Penelope is less to look upon
Than thou in form and stature, since she is mortal
And thou art deathless and unaging.
Yet even so I desire and long every day
To return home and see the day of my return.
If one of the gods should shatter me upon the wine-dark sea,
I shall endure it, keeping my patient heart within me;
For I have already suffered much and endured much,
Upon the waves and in war. Let this be added to those.”
So he spoke. The Sun went down, and darkness came.
They went into the innermost chamber of the hollow cave
And took their pleasure together, remaining beside one another.
When early-born, rosy-fingered Dawn appeared,
Odysseus put on his cloak and tunic;
The nymph clothed herself in a great, shining white robe,
Light and graceful, and set a beautiful golden girdle
Around her waist, and a veil upon her head.
Then she devised the departure of great-hearted Odysseus.
She gave him a great axe, fitted to his hands,
Bronze, sharp on both sides, with a beautiful olive handle

Well joined to it; then she gave him a polished adze.
She led the way to the farthest edge of the island,
Where tall trees grew—alder, poplar, and pine
That rose to heaven—dry long ago and seasoned,
Light to float upon the sea.
When she had shown him where the tall trees grew,
The divine goddess returned to her house;
But Odysseus cut the timber, and his work went swiftly.
He felled twenty trees in all, trimmed them with bronze,
Smoothed them skillfully, and brought them true to the line.
Meanwhile Calypso brought the augers;
He bored every timber and fitted them one to another,
And fastened the raft with bolts and joints.
As a man who knows the craft of shipbuilding
Spreads the floor of a broad merchant vessel,
So wide did Odysseus make his broad raft.
He set up the ribs, joining them with close-set supports,
And finished it with long side-planks.
Within he raised a mast and yardarm fitted to it,
And made a steering-oar, that he might guide his course.

He fenced it all around with woven
willow branches,
To be a defense against the waves,
and heaped upon it
Much brushwood for protection.
Meanwhile the divine goddess
brought cloth
For him to make sails; and he
skillfully made those too.
He fastened sheets, ropes, and braces
within them,
And with levers dragged the raft
down to the holy sea.
On the fourth day all the work was
completed.
On the fifth Calypso, divine among
goddesses,
Sent him away, after bathing him
and clothing him in fragrant
raiment.
Within the raft she placed one skin
of dark wine,
And another, a great skin, filled with
water;
And in a leather bag she set many
pleasant provisions.
She sent behind him a wind, gentle
and free from harm.
Glad in the wind, noble Odysseus
spread the sail;
Then he sat at the steering-oar and
guided the raft with skill.
Sleep did not fall upon his eyes as he
watched the Pleiades,
And Boötes, which sinks late, and
the Bear—
The Wagon, as men call it—which
turns in place
And watches Orion, alone of the
stars denied

The baths of Ocean. Calypso had
commanded him
To hold it on his left as he crossed
the sea.
For seventeen days he sailed upon
the sea;
On the eighteenth the shadowed
mountains appeared before him,
The mountains of the land of the
Phaeacians,
Where the shore lay nearest him.
They looked like a shield
Lying upon the misty sea.
But the mighty Earth-Shaker,
returning from the Ethiopians,
Saw him from far away, from the
Solyman mountains—
For he was sailing upon the sea—and
grew more angry in heart.
Shaking his head, he spoke within his
spirit:
“Look now: the gods have changed
their counsel concerning Odysseus,
While I was among the Ethiopians.
He is near the land
Of the Phaeacians, where fate
appoints him to escape
The great boundary of misery that
has overtaken him.
Yet I think I shall give him his full
measure of suffering.”
So he spoke; he gathered the clouds,
and troubled the sea,
Taking his trident in his hands. He
roused every storm-wind
Of every kind, and covered earth and
sea together
With clouds; and night sprang up
from heaven.

Eurus and Notus fell upon the sea
together,
And the stormy West Wind, and the
clear-born North Wind,
Rolling a great wave before them.
Then the knees of Odysseus were
loosed, and his heart failed.
Troubled, he spoke to his
great-hearted spirit:
“Woe is me—what misery is left for
me?
I fear the goddess told me everything
truly,
When she said that, before I reached
my native land,
I should fill up my measure of
sorrows.
Now all her words are fulfilled.
With what clouds Zeus crowns the
broad heaven!
He has troubled the sea, and the
storms of every wind
Rush upon me. Now sudden death
stands near.
“Thrice and four times blessed were
the Danaans
Who died in broad Troy, bringing
honor to the sons of Atreus.
Would that I had died and met my
fate on that day
When many bronze spears of the
Trojans were hurled against me,
Around the body of Peleus’ dead son.
Then I would have received the rites
of burial,
And the Achaeans would have made
my fame great.
But now it is fated that I be taken by
a pitiless death
In the deep.”

As he spoke, a great wave rushed
upon him from above,
Terrible, and whirled the raft
around.
He fell far from the raft, and let the
steering-oar
Go from his hands. The tempest of
mingled winds
Broke the mast in the middle;
Far away the sail and yardarm fell
into the sea.
For a long time the wave held him
beneath,
And he could not quickly rise
beneath the assault
Of the great wave; his garments
weighed him down,
The garments divine Calypso had
given him.
Late he came again to the surface and
spat the bitter salt water
From his mouth; it poured in streams
from his head.
Though exhausted, he did not forget
the raft;
He swam through the waves, reached
it, and sat in its middle,
Avoiding the end of death.
The great wave carried it here and
there along the current.
As when the autumn North Wind
carries thistle-down
Across the plain, and the dense burrs
cling to one another,
So the winds carried the raft across
the sea,
Now South Wind thrusting it before
the North Wind,
Now East giving way, that West
Wind might pursue.

Then the daughter of Cadmus saw
him, beautiful-ankled Ino,
Called Leucothea, who once had
been a mortal woman
With a human voice, but now, in the
sea's wide spaces,
Had received the honor of the gods.
She pitied wandering Odysseus in his
grief;
And, like a sea-gull, she rose from
the water,
Settled upon the many-bound raft,
and spoke:
So she spoke, and gave him the
immortal veil;
Then, like a sea-gull, plunged again
into the wave,
And the black water covered her.
Long-enduring, noble Odysseus
pondered within himself,
And troubled, spoke to his
great-hearted spirit:
"Woe is me—what if some immortal
is weaving deceit again,
When she commands me to leave the
raft?
I will not yet obey, since with my
own eyes I have seen
The land where she said I should find
escape.
This seems to me the better course:
While the timbers remain joined in
their fastenings,
I will stay here and endure my pains;
But when the wave has shaken the
raft apart,
I will swim. There is no better plan
to consider."
While he thought these things in
heart and spirit,

Poseidon, Earth-Shaker, raised a
great wave against him,
Terrible and hard to bear, roofed
over like a mountain,
And drove it upon him. As a fierce
wind scatters
A heap of dry straw, tossing it this
way and that,
So the long timbers scattered from
the raft.
But Odysseus stepped upon one
beam,
As a rider drives a horse, and
stripped away
The garments Calypso, divine among
goddesses, had given him.
At once he stretched the veil beneath
his breast,
And threw himself face-first into the
sea,
Spreading his hands and eager to
swim.
The mighty Earth-Shaker saw him,
shook his head,
And spoke within his spirit:
"There—after suffering many evils,
wander upon the sea
Until thou minglest with those men
whom the gods cherish.
Even so, I do not think thou wilt
complain of hardship."
So he spoke, and lashed his
long-maned horses;
He reached Aegae, where his famous
halls are built.
But Athena, daughter of Zeus,
conceived another thought.
She bound the roads of all the other
winds,

Commanding them all to cease and
rest;
And raised the swift North Wind,
breaking the waves before him,
Until godlike Odysseus should
mingle with the Phaeacians,
Who love the oar, and escape death
and the fates.
There, for two nights and two days,
he was driven
Upon the swelling wave, while his
heart often foresaw death.
But when fair-haired Dawn
completed the third day,
The wind ceased, and a calm fell
upon the sea.
Then, lifted high upon a great wave,
He looked sharply forward and saw
the land close at hand.
As children rejoice when a father,
lying sick,
Has long endured great pain, wasting
away beneath
The hateful visitation of a god, and
the gods release him
From his evil—so welcome seemed
the land and forest
To Odysseus. He swam on, eager to
set foot upon the earth.
But when he was as near as a man's
shout may carry,
He heard a great roar against the
cliffs of the sea.
The mighty wave bellowed terribly
against the dry land,
And all the shore was wrapped in the
foam of the sea.
There were no harbors for ships, no
inlets;

Only projecting shores, rocks, and
reefs.
Then the knees of Odysseus were
loosed and his heart failed.
Troubled, he spoke to his
great-hearted spirit:
“Woe is me! Zeus has granted me the
unexpected sight of land,
And I have crossed this great gulf of
water;
Yet nowhere appears a landing from
the gray sea.
Outside are sharp rocks, around me
the wave roars,
And the smooth rock rises from the
sea;
The water is deep, and I cannot
stand upon both feet
And escape the evil.
If I go ashore, a great wave may seize
me
And cast me upon the rock; my
effort will be fruitless.
If I swim farther along, seeking some
shelving shore
Or a harbor of the sea, I fear the
storm will seize me again,
Carry me groaning over the
fish-filled sea,
Or some great sea-beast a god may
send against me—
One of the many that famous
Amphitrite nourishes.
I know how the renowned
Earth-Shaker bears me ill.”
While thus he pondered, a mighty
wave
Bore him against the rugged shore,
where rocks

Lay naked to the sea. His hands he
caught
Upon a stone, and held it, as the
wave
Went roaring back; but then the
returning surge
Came on, and tore the flesh from
both his hands,
As when a polyp, from his rocky
cleft,
Is dragged away, and all its little
stones
Cling to its suckers. Then the bitter
wave
Covered him; and beneath it he had
died,
Though Pallas had not given him
wise resolve.
He swam beyond the breakers,
searching still
For some low shore, some haven
from the sea,
And reached the mouth of a
clear-flowing stream.
There was the place most sheltered
from the wind,
And smooth; and, knowing in his
heart the god,
He prayed: "Hear me, lord, whoever
thou art!
I come to thee a suppliant, fleeing
here
From out the sea. The deathless gods
themselves
Hold in respect the man who
wanders thus,
As I, a suppliant, reach thy pleasant
stream.
Have pity, lord, and let me kneel
before thee."

So prayed he; and the river stayed its
flow,
And checked the wave, and made a
calm before
His feet, and saved him gently at the
mouth.
Then from his mouth and nostrils he
poured out
The briny water, breathless, spent of
speech;
But when his breath returned, and
strength came back,
He loosed the veil that Ino had
bestowed,
And cast it in the river's salty stream.
The wave bore it again toward the
deep sea,
And Ino caught it in her deathless
hands.
Then, from the river's bank, he crept
away,
And crouched among the reeds, and
kissed the earth,
The giver of the harvest. For a while
He questioned in his heart what end
to choose:
To lie beside the stream through the
cold night,
Where dew would fall, and frost, and
the sharp wind
Rise from the water; or to climb the
wood,
And seek the shadowed groves upon
the height,
Yet risk the beasts that haunt the
mountain there.
At last the counsel of his heart
prevailed:
He entered in among the trees, and
found,

Near to the water, two close-growing
shrubs,
One olive wild, one olive cultivated.
Their interwoven branches kept the
wind
From entering, and the sun's bright
arrows too,
And kept the rain from passing
through their leaves;
So thickly had they grown together
there.
Beneath them he made wide a bed of
leaves,
Enough for two or three men in
winter's cold,
Though bitter winds might blow.
When he had lain
Among them, heaped the leaves
above his limbs,
He seemed as is a burning ember,
hidden deep
Beneath the black ash at the edge of a
field,
Where there is no near neighbor to
preserve
The seed of fire, and keep it from
going out.
So covered in the leaves Odysseus
lay;
And Pallas poured a sleep upon his
eyes,
That she might end the weariness
and grief
That had pursued him over the sea.

Source range: Book 5. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Odysseus clings to the broken raft in the storm

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 6

First-pass working translation

While great Odysseus slept beneath
the leaves,
By weariness and sorrow overcome,
Athena went among the Phaeacians,
To their wide land and city. Once
they dwelt
In spacious Hypereia, close beside
The overbearing Cyclopes, a race
More strong than they, and
grievously oppressed them.
Godlike Nausithous raised them
from that place,
And led them far away to Scheria,
Set off from other men who eat the
grain.
He ringed the city with a wall, built
homes,
And made the temples of the
deathless gods.
But now he had gone down to Hades'
house.
Alcinous ruled, whom the gods had
endowed
With wisdom. To his shining house
Athena came,
And, pondering the homeward
voyage of the lord
Odysseus, stood beside Nausicaa's
bed.
She took the form of Dymas'
daughter, fair
And dear to the princess, of the same
age,
And breathed beside her, speaking in
her dream:

“Nausicaa, why has your mother
borne you so,
To leave your woven garments
unprepared?
Your wedding day is near; and you
should wear
Beautiful raiment, as should those
who come
To lead you to your husband. These
are things
That bring a name and honor among
men.
At dawn ask your dear father for a
wagon,
High-built, with wheels, to carry
cloaks and robes
For washing in the river. Your own
father,
When he sits in the council, must be
dressed
In clean attire; and five dear brothers
live
Within the house, who go to dance,
yet leave
These matters to your thought.”
So spoke the bright-eyed goddess,
and returned
To high Olympus. When the
morning came,
Nausicaa rose and marveled at her
dream.
She went to where her father and
mother sat,
And spoke, though shame held back
the word of marriage:
“Dear father, would you have a
wagon made,
With lofty wheels? I have my
garments lying

Unwashed within the house, and I
must go
To wash them. You, who sit among
the chiefs,
Should wear clean clothing. Five dear
sons are here,
Two newly wed, three still
unmarried; yet
They leave the dancing-floor and
heed no robe.
All this is mine to think of.”
She spoke; and he, who understood
her thought,
Answered: “My child, I will not keep
the wagon
Or mules from you. Let the young
men prepare it.”
They yoked the mules. Her mother
brought from home
The garments, folded in a polished
chest,
And loaded food and sweet red wine;
her father
Filled a skin with water. At dawn she
climbed
The wagon, with her maidens, and
drove down
Toward the river, where the
washing-place was deep.
They reached the lovely stream,
where basins lay
That never failed to cleanse the
darkest stain.
They loosed the mules, and let them
crop the grass
Beside the river’s honeyed water.
Then
They carried out the robes, and
stamped them clean

Within the dark water, pressing
them beneath
The stones, and spread them in the
hollow shore
To dry beneath the sun. When they
had bathed
And rubbed their limbs with shining
olive oil,
They ate beside the river, then began
To play at ball, their white arms
flashing. Fair
Nausicaa led them, as Artemis,
The archer, goes among the
mountain nymphs,
Her mind delighted by the boar and
stag;
The nymphs rejoice, and Leto’s
daughter laughs,
Her head and shoulders rising over
all.
So Nausicaa shone among the maids.
But when she cast the ball beyond
the line,
It fell into the river’s dark current;
The maidens cried aloud. Their cry
awoke
The long-enduring man, who sat
within
His leaves and wondered what land
held him now.
“Unhappy me! What people have I
reached?
Are they unjust and wild, or hold
they shame
Before the gods? Do those young
voices rise
From nymphs who haunt the
mountains and the springs?
Or have I come among the speakers
of men?

I will go forth and see.”
He broke a bough with many leaves
and held
The leafy branch before his
nakedness.
Then, like a mountain lion, worn
thin by hunger,
He came from the wood, his hair and
beard salt-stiff,
His body dripping from the sea. The
girls
Fled scattering along the shore;
Nausicaa
Alone stood firm, for Athena put
courage
And strength within her heart, and
took away
The trembling fear that might have
turned her back.
Odysseus paused, and weighed his
words: should he
Embrace the maiden’s knees and beg
for clothing,
Or stand apart and ask her where the
town lay?
He chose to stand remote, and speak
with care:
“Are you a goddess, or a mortal
woman?
If one of those who dwell in heaven,
then most
You resemble Artemis, the daughter
Of great Zeus, in stature and in
beauty.
But if you are a mortal, threefold
blessed
Your father and your mother;
threefold blessed
Your brothers too, whose hearts
grow bright with joy

Whenever you go dancing. Yet
beyond
All others blessed is he whose gifts
have won
Your hand, and brings you home.
“I have endured much sorrow.
Yesterday
I came from the sea, after long
suffering;
The waves have driven me here. I
know no city,
No people, and no land. Give help,
princess:
Give me a rag to cover me, and show
The road that leads into your town.
May Zeus
Grant you the thing your heart
desires: a home,
A husband, and one mind within the
house.
There is no greater blessing than
when man
And wife, in harmony of heart and
thought,
Keep house together, to the grief of
those
Who hate them, and the joy of those
who love.”
Then Nausicaa, the white-armed,
answered him:
“Stranger, since you are neither
wicked nor
Without good sense, no man—nor
Zeus himself,
Who holds Olympus—gives alike to
all.
He gave you sorrow; bear it as you
must.
But now that you have reached our
land, you shall

Not lack for clothing or for any gift
That custom grants the desperate
wanderer.
I will show the city. Phaeacians are
we,
And this is Alcinous' realm, my
father's."
She called the maidens: "Stand, and
do not flee.
Why fear a man? No enemy could
come
Against us here; the deathless gods
protect
Our island. This man comes in
misery,
And strangers, beggars, travelers are
sent
By Zeus; a little gift is welcome. Give
The stranger food and drink, and
wash him where
The river's bank is sheltered from the
wind."
They came again, gave food and wine
to him,
And laid fresh clothing near him. He
withdrew
Apart, and washed the salt from
back and shoulders,
For he was shy before the lovely
maids.
Athena made him broader and more
fair;
His hair fell thick in curls, like
hyacinth.
Then Nausicaa, seeing him, said to
them:
"Would that a man like this might be
called mine,
And live among us here. Give him
more food."

He ate and drank, for long the sea
had kept
All nourishment from him. The
maidens folded
The garments, laid them in the
polished wagon,
And yoked the mules. The princess
spoke again:
"Rise now, stranger. We must go
toward the town.
I will instruct you how to reach my
father's house.
Beyond the fields, beside the road,
there grows
A grove of poplars sacred to Athena;
There is a spring, and meadows
round it lie.
Wait there, and rest until we have
gone in.
When you judge that we are within
the town,
Then enter, and inquire for Alcinous'
house.
"It is not hard to know: a child could
lead you.
No other house among the
Phaeacians
Is so bright as the palace of the king.
When you have crossed the
threshold, go directly
Into the hall, and clasp my mother's
knees.
If she receives you kindly, hope to see
Your friends again, and reach your
distant home."
"But do not follow near the wagon.
People talk.
They might say, 'Who is this stranger
walking here

Beside Nausicaa? Where did she find him?

I would be shamed by such a tale. My brothers,

Who are quick-tempered, would resent it too.

Let us be seen apart until I reach The town; then follow after us."

Godlike Odysseus answered: "I will do

As you command, princess. I would not have you

Hear one unkind word because of me. May Artemis

Grant you a husband who delights your heart;

May your father and mother, and your brothers,

Rejoice whenever you return in peace."

The sun went down. They came to the sacred grove,

And he sat beneath the olive trees, and prayed:

"Hear me, daughter of Zeus who bears the aegis,

Unwearyed one. Before, when I was broken,

You did not heed me, as Poseidon scattered

My ship and drove me over the barren sea.

Now let the Phaeacians receive me kindly;

Let their king's heart pity me."

He prayed; and Pallas heard him. Yet she did not

Appear before him openly, for she feared

Her father's brother, who still burned with anger

Against godlike Odysseus, and would not cease

Until the hero reached his native land.

Nausicaa's mules then bore the bright garments

Into the palace. She went in, and her brothers,

Like deathless gods, unyoked the mules and raised

The clothing. She entered her chamber, where

Her nurse, Eurymedusa, kind and old,

Lit fire beside her bed.

When Nausicaa and her maidens had gone,

Odysseus rose, and wrapped the cloak around him.

Athena shed a mist about him, lest Some insolent Phaeacian, meeting him,

Should mock or question him along the road.

She came to him in the likeness of a girl,

Bearing a water jar, and he addressed her:

"My child, can you show me the house of the king,

Alcinous? I am a stranger, driven here

From far away, across the sea. I know No one among the people, nor the roads."

The bright-eyed goddess answered: "I will show

The palace, stranger. It stands near
my own house.
Follow in silence; speak to no one on
The road, and do not question them.
These men
Are wary of a stranger. The
Phaeacians
Love the sea's mist and dwell apart;
no man
Is welcomed here as he might be
elsewhere.
"Poseidon gave them ships swift as a
thought,
And oars; their harbor is secure,
their sea
Roads open. They have no desire to
speak
With any distant people."
She led him swiftly on, unseen by all,
And showed the shining palace.
Bronze walls enclosed
Its threshold; golden doors were
raised within,
With silver doorposts set on bronze,
and gold
The handles. Dogs of gold and silver
stood
At either side, fashioned by the skill
of Hephaestus,
Immortal, deathless, guardians of the
house.
Within, along the walls, the benches
held
The chiefs, with woven cloths spread
over them.
Young servants stood in ordered
rows, bearing
Bright torches through the darkness
of the hall.

Outside, the orchards bore their
fruit all year:
Pomegranate, apple, fig, and olive,
pear
And grape; the vines were never
without fruit.
One wind would ripen, and another
begin
The new fruit; the west wind would
swell the grapes,
And the sun's rays complete them.
There the pear
Followed the pear, the apple apple,
grape
Upon the grape, and fig on fig.
"Enter," she said. "But first clasp
firmly both
The knees of the queen, Arete, whom
the people
Honor as they honor one of the gods.
She has a wise mind, and all hope of
return
Will rest upon her favor."
So speaking, she went away through
the dark mist
Back to Olympus, to her father's
house.
Odysseus entered the palace. He
stood
Before the hearth, where Arete sat
beside
The fire, and clasped her knees, and
prayed:
"Queen, after many sufferings I have
come
To you. May the gods grant you
happiness,
Children, and concord in your house.
Give me

A passage home; for long I have been
absent
From my country, suffering beyond
words."

He sat among the ashes by the fire.
The hall grew still. At last Echeneus,
The oldest of the Phaeacians, spoke:
"Alcinous, it is not fitting that a
guest
Should sit upon the ashes. Raise him
up,
And set him in a chair with silver
nails,
So that our heralds may mix wine for
him."

Then the king rose, took Odysseus
by the hand,
And seated him in the chair from
which his son,
Laodamas, had risen. A herald
poured
Water upon his hands; a servant set
Bread and rich meat before him.
Alcinous
Addressed the Phaeacians:
"Tomorrow let us launch a dark ship,
and choose
The young men who will row it. We
will prepare
A feast, and send our guest away in
peace.
Let no delay hold back a man whom
the gods
Have sent to us, though he comes
from far away."
But Arete recognized the shining
clothes
That Odysseus wore, for she herself
had woven

Them with her maidens. "Stranger,"
she asked,
"Who gave you these garments? Did
you come
Across the sea as you are now, or did
Someone clothe you?"
Odysseus answered: "I will tell the
truth.
The nymph Calypso held me on her
island,
And Zeus commanded that she
release me.
I built a raft; Poseidon broke it
under me.
I swam, until I reached the shore.
Your daughter
Was washing garments there beside
the river,
With all her maidens. She gave me
this cloak,
And told me to clasp your knees."
Then Alcinous replied: "My daughter
did not
Act with the prudence that she
should have shown.
She ought to have brought you with
her companions.
Yet you shall not lack help. I will give
you
A ship, and men, and send you to
your home."
The king promised that the
Phaeacians would take
The stranger's return into their care.
Then
Odysseus slept beneath the echoing
portico;
And Arete and Alcinous went to
rest,

While the sea moved beneath the
stars.

Source range: Book 6. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 7

First-pass working translation

So there the much-enduring, godlike
man

Prayed in the grove; and Nausicaa
drove

The mules toward the city. When she
reached

Her father's famous house, she
stopped before

The doors; her brothers, like
immortal gods,

Stood round the wagon, loosed the
patient mules,

And carried in the garments. She
herself

Went to her chamber; there the old
nurse lit

The fire, Eurymedusa, who had once
Been brought from Apeira by the
curved ships,

And given as a royal gift to serve
Alcinous, whose people heard his
word

As they might hear a god. She had
raised

Nausicaa in the palace, and for her
Lit fire and set the evening meal
within.

Then Odysseus rose and went
toward the town.

Athena, favoring him, poured a mist
Around him, lest some proud
Phaeacian,

Meeting him first, should mock him
with harsh words

Or ask his name. As he approached
the lovely

City, the bright-eyed goddess met
him there,

In the likeness of a young girl,
bearing

A water-jar. "My child," he said, "will
you conduct me to the house
Of King Alcinous, who rules these
people?"

I am a stranger, long afflicted, come
From far away across the sea. I know
No one who holds this city and this
land."

The goddess answered: "Stranger,
father-like,

I will show you the house you ask to
see.

It stands near my own father's
honored home.

Follow in silence; I will lead the way.
Look toward no man, and ask no
question on

The road. This people does not
gladly bear

The stranger, nor receive with open
love

The man who comes from elsewhere.
They trust the ships

That cross the mighty sea, swift as a
wing

Or as a thought; Earth-Shaker gave
them that.

Their vessels are the fastest in the
world."

She spoke, and went before him
quickly; he

Kept close behind the goddess'
unseen steps.

The famous sailors did not see them
pass

Among the streets; Athena, beautiful

And terrible, had cast a sacred mist
About him in the kindness of her
heart.
Odysseus marveled at their harbor,
ships,
And meeting-place, and at the long,
high wall
Built firmly with sharp stakes, a
wonder to behold.
When they had reached the king's
renowned abode,
The goddess spoke: "This is the
house, stranger,
That you asked me for. You will find
the god-fed
Kings within, at supper. Enter; let no
fear
Possess your heart. First you will find
the queen,
Arete, daughter of Rhexenor.
Poseidon
Begot Nausithous with Periboea,
Youngest daughter of the proud
Eurymedon,
Who ruled the Giants, ruined his
people, and died.
Nausithous fathered Rhexenor and
Alcinous;
Apollo struck Rhexenor down, newly
wed,
And left one daughter, Arete.
Alcinous
Made her his wife, and honors her
beyond
All women dwelling under mortal
men.
She is most honored by her children,
him,
The king, and by the people, who
look up to her

As to a god. Her good sense fails her
nowhere;
With wise counsel she dissolves
men's quarrels.
If she receives you kindly in her
heart,
You may hope to see your friends,
and reach
The land that gave you birth."
So spoke Athena, and departed over
The sea that never tires. She left fair
Scheria,
And came to Marathon and broad
Athens, then
Entered Erechtheus' strong house.
But he,
Odysseus, went toward the palace,
deeply
Considering, before he crossed the
bronze
Threshold. The house shone like the
sun or moon.
The bronze walls ran from threshold
into shadow;
A dark-blue cornice crowned them.
Golden doors
Held fast the inner house; the
doorposts stood
In silver set upon a bronze threshold,
And silver was the lintel, gold the
handle.
On either side stood golden dogs and
silver,
Crafted by Hephaestus' knowing
mind to guard
Alcinous' great house—deathless,
ageless,
Forever young. Along the walls were
thrones,

From threshold through the hall, and
on them lay
Fine woven cloths, the work of
women's hands.
The leaders of the Phaeacians sat
there,
Eating and drinking; theirs was an
unfailing feast.
Golden youths upon well-built
pedestals held torches
In their hands, to shine through
night upon the banqueters.
The king's house had fifty serving
women: some ground grain,
Some sat at looms and twisted
shining thread.
Outside the courtyard, close beside
the doors,
Was a great garden, four-square,
enclosed on both
Its sides. Tall trees grew there, in
flower and fruit:
Pear trees and pomegranates, apple
trees,
Sweet figs, and olives in their full
abundance.
Their fruit does not decay or fail in
winter,
Nor in the heat of summer, but
endures
Through every season. The west
wind brings one fruit
To birth and ripens another; pear on
pear,
Apple on apple, grape upon the
grape,
And fig upon the fig. One part lies
open,
Dried by the sun; elsewhere they
gather grapes,

And elsewhere tread them; before
the bunches, some
Are green and shedding blossom,
others darken.
At the far edge, arranged beds of
every kind
Shine all the year. Two springs run
there: one spreads
Throughout the garden; the other
passes under
The courtyard threshold toward the
lofty house,
And from it all the citizens drew
water.
Such were the bright gifts of the gods
within
The house of King Alcinous.
Odysseus stood
And gazed, long-suffering, at all
these things;
Then crossed the threshold swiftly.
He found the leaders
Pouring wine in honor of Hermes,
guide of men,
Whose final cup they offered
whenever they prepared
For sleep.
He passed through the hall beneath
the mist
Athena had poured round him, until
he reached
Arete and the king. Around the
queen
Odysseus cast his hands, and at that
moment
The sacred mist fell back. The people
there
Were silent, seeing a man within the
house;

They marveled. Then he prayed:
“Arete, daughter
Of godlike Rhexenor, to your knees
and your husband’s
I have come, after great suffering,
and to these guests.
May the gods grant them life and
happiness,
And may each leave his treasures to
his sons,
And all the honors given by the
people.
But send me swiftly to my native
land;
For long I have been tormented far
away
From those I love.”
So speaking, he sat down beside the
hearth,
In the ashes. All the people held their
peace.
At last old Echeneus, a hero, spoke,
the oldest
Of the Phaeacians, skilled in speech
and rich
In knowledge of the past: “Alcinous,
this is neither
Fair nor right: the stranger sits upon
the ash beside
The hearth, while all these people
wait in silence
For your command. Rise, raise the
stranger up,
And seat him on a silver-studded
chair;
Tell the heralds to mix the wine, that
we may pour
For Zeus, delighting in the thunder,
who follows

Reverent suppliants; and tell the
steward to set
Supper before the guest, from what
is in the house.”
When sacred Alcinous heard, he
took
The much-devising hero by the hand,
Raised him from beside the hearth,
and seated him
In the bright chair from which his
dear son rose,
Laodamas. A maid brought water in
a beautiful
Gold jug above a silver basin, so that
he might wash
His hands; she drew a polished table
near him.
The honored steward brought him
bread and many dishes,
Giving freely from the stores at hand.
Odysseus drank and ate.
Then Alcinous spoke to the herald:
“Pontonooos,
Mix the bowl, and deal the wine to
all within the house,
That we may pour to Zeus the
thunderer, who follows close
Upon the reverent suppliant.”
Pontonooos mixed
The honey-sweetened wine and
served it, beginning
With the first cup. When they had
poured and drunk,
Alcinous addressed the leaders: “At
dawn we will call
The elders, entertain our guest, make
offerings to the gods,
And think of his conveyance, that he
may reach his native land

Without distress or pain, escorted by
us, however far away.

Thereafter he will suffer what the
thread of fate fixed for him.

If he is some god from heaven, the
gods themselves are shaping
Something new; they have always
appeared among us openly.”

But wise Odysseus answered: “Let
such thoughts be far from you,
Alcinous. I am not like the
immortals who possess the wide sky;
I am mortal, like the men you know
who bear the heaviest grief.

I could tell greater sorrows still, all
those I suffered by heaven’s will.

But let me eat, though grief is in me.
Nothing is more shameless
Than the hateful belly, which
commands a man to remember food,
However worn down and sorrowful
he may be. So I have sorrow in my
heart,

Yet it commands that I should eat
and drink, and makes me forget
The things I suffered. At sunrise urge
your men, that I, unhappy,
May set foot again upon my native
land; and when I see my possessions,
Servants, and high-roofed house, let
death come then.”

All praised his words. After they
poured and drank their fill,
The people went to their homes;
Odysseus stayed within the hall,
With Arete and the king, while
servants cleared away the feast.

Arete, white-armed, began the
questioning, for she knew the shirt

And cloak upon him—beautiful
garments she herself had made:

“Stranger, who are you, and from
what land? Who gave you these
garments?

Did you not say that you wandered
here across the sea?”

Odysseus answered: “Queen, it is
difficult to tell the whole of sorrow;
The gods have given me too much.
Yet I will tell the thing you ask.

Far out upon the sea lies Ogygia,
where Calypso lives, the cunning
daughter

Of great Atlas, dread and beautiful.
A spirit brought me to her hearth,
After Zeus struck my ship apart with
a white thunderbolt in the wine-dark
sea.

All my good comrades died; I clung
to the keel of the curved ship,
And drifted nine full days. On the
tenth dark night the gods brought
me

To Ogygia, where Calypso took me
in, loved me, fed me, and promised
I should live immortal and unaging
forever. Yet she never persuaded my
heart.

“For seven years I stayed there, and
soaked with tears the deathless
garments

She had given me. When the eighth
year came, she urged me to depart,
Whether Zeus compelled her or her
mind had turned. She sent me on a
raft

Bound fast with many ropes; she gave
me bread, sweet wine, immortal
clothes,

And a gentle wind. For seventeen
days I crossed the sea; on the
eighteenth
Appeared the shadowed mountains
of your land. Poseidon stirred the
winds,
And the storm broke the raft apart. I
swam until wind and water carried
me
To your land. A wave drove me
against the rocks, but I drew back
and swam again
Until I came upon a river, where the
place seemed best: smooth from the
stones,
And sheltered from the wind. I fell
exhausted; night came on, and I
climbed
Beyond the river, slept in the thicket,
and drew the leaves around me.
There I slept all night and through
the dawn, into middle day. Then I
saw
Your daughter's maids playing upon
the shore, and she among them like a
goddess.
I begged her help. She gave me food
and wine, washed me in the river,
And gave me these clothes. Though I
grieve, I have told you the truth."
Alcinous answered: "Stranger, my
daughter did not show all the
judgment
She should have shown, for she did
not lead you to our house with her
maids."
But Odysseus answered: "Do not
blame your blameless child. She told
me to follow;
I would not, for I feared you might
grow angry seeing us together."

Then Alcinous answered: "My heart
is not one that grows angry without
cause.
May Zeus, Athena, and Apollo grant
that you, being as you are and
thinking as I do,
Might take my daughter's hand and
be my son by marriage, staying here.
I would provide
A house and wealth if you stayed by
choice; no Phaeacian would compel
you.
Tomorrow I will make certain of
your passage, so that while you sleep
the men may row
You in a calm sea until you reach
your land and house, wherever it
lies—even beyond
Euboea, which our men call farthest
of all lands. They once conveyed
Rhadamanthys
There to see Tityus, earth-born; they
went and came home the selfsame
day.
You will learn how swift my ships
and young men are upon the sea."
Odysseus rejoiced, and prayed:
"Father Zeus, may every word
Alcinous has spoken
Be brought to pass. Then my fame on
the fruitful earth would never die,
And I would reach my home."
Arete ordered the women to set a
bed beneath the portico, and lay fine
purple
Blankets over it, with rugs above and
woolen cloaks to cover him. The
women went out
Bearing torches. When they had
made the close-woven bed, they
called him:

“Rise now, stranger; your bed is ready.” It seemed a welcome thing to sleep.

The much-enduring Odysseus lay beneath the roof, upon the pierced bed beneath the echoing hall.

Alcinous slept within the house’s heart, and the queen prepared the bed and resting-place.

Source range: Book 7. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 8

First-pass working translation

When early Dawn appeared, rose
Alcinous,
The sacred strength of kings, and
godlike too
Rose great Odysseus, sacker of cities.
The king led him to the Phaeacian
assembly,
Which stood beside the ships.
Athena went
Before them, wearing the herald's
form,
And, planning still Odysseus'
homeward road,
Stood by each man and urged him:
"Come, Phaeacian leaders, go into
the place
Of council, that you may hear about
the guest
Who newly came to King Alcinous'
house,
Driven over the sea, and like the gods
In body."
She stirred their hearts; the
meeting-place and seats
Were quickly filled. Many looked
with wonder
Upon Laertes' son; and Athena
poured
Divine grace over head and
shoulders, making
Him taller, broader, and more dear
to all,
Formidable and reverent, so that he
Might win the contests that the
Phaeacians

Would set before him. When they
had assembled,
Alcinous spoke:
"Hear me, Phaeacian leaders. This
unknown
Stranger has come, a wanderer, to
my house—
From eastern or from western
peoples, I know not—
And asks for escort, begging that it
stand.
As we have done before, let us
prepare
His passage. No guest remains here
lamenting
For long because his escort is
delayed.
Draw down a black ship, one that has
not sailed,
And choose fifty-two young men, the
best
Among the people. Bind the oars
well fast
Within their thongs, then come and
make a feast
Within my house; I will provide for
all.
This is my charge to the young men.
You, the kings
And sceptered rulers, come into my
house,
That we may welcome our guest. Let
no one
Refuse. Call also the divine singer,
Demodocus, for the god gave him
song
To please the heart whenever he is
moved
To sing."

He led the sceptered rulers to his house;
The herald went to fetch the honored singer.
The chosen young men drew the black ship down,
Set mast and sail upon her, bound the oars
Within the leather loops, and spread the white
Sail high. They moored her in deep water, then
Returned. The halls, courtyards, and men's rooms filled
With old and young. Alcinous sacrificed
Twelve sheep, eight tusked boars, and two slow-footed oxen;
They flayed them and prepared a lovely feast.
The herald brought Demodocus, beloved
By the Muse, who gave both good and evil:
She took his eyes, but gave him singing sweet.
Pontonous set him in the midst of all,
Against a tall pillar, hung his clear lyre
Above his head, and showed him how to reach it;
Beside him placed a basket, table, cup,
That he might drink whenever his heart desired.
They put their hands upon the ready food.
When thirst and hunger had been put away,

The Muse moved the singer to declare the fame
Of men, a song whose glory reached the sky:
The quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles,
How once at a rich feast they fought with words,
And Agamemnon rejoiced within,
For Phoebus Apollo had foretold that this
Would be the beginning of calamity
For Trojans and Danaans, by the will Of Zeus. The singer sang. Odysseus drew
His purple cloak above his head and hid
His face, ashamed to let the Phaeacians
See the tears flowing beneath his brows.
Whenever the renowned singer ceased, he wiped
His tears, and lifted the two-handled cup
To pour for the gods. Whenever the best
Phaeacians asked him to begin again,
He covered his head, and wept. From all the rest
Those tears were hidden, but Alcinous alone
Observed them, and heard his heavy sighing.
Then Alcinous addressed the oar-loving people:
"We have had our fill of food, and of the lyre,
Companion of the splendid feast.
Come out,

And test yourselves in every kind of
contest,
So that our guest may tell his friends
at home
How much we surpass other men in
boxing,
Wrestling, jumping, running, and
the ships.”
He spoke, and led them out. The
herald took
The lyre from its peg and led
Demodocus;
The other Phaeacians followed, in
their thousands,
To the assembly-place. The young
men rose:
Acroneus, Ocyalus, Elatreus,
Nauteus, Pymneus, Anchialus,
Eretmeus,
Ponteus, Proreus, Thoon,
Anabesineus,
Amphialus, and Euryalus, equal
To murderous Ares, son of
Naubolus,
Best of all in form and stature after
Laodamas. The three blameless sons
of
Alcinous rose: Laodamas, Halius,
And Clytoneus, godlike among men.
First they tested speed. From the
starting-line
They raced across the dust; and
Clytoneus
Was best of all, as far as when a
mule-team
Runs through the furrows, so he
passed the crowd
And reached the turn. They tried the
painful wrestling;

Euryalus excelled them all.
Amphialus
Was first in jumping; Elatreus threw
The discus farthest; in the
boxing-match
Laodamas, Alcinous’ fine son,
prevailed.
When all had taken pleasure in the
games,
Laodamas spoke: “Friends, let us ask
the guest
If he has learned some contest. He is
not
Ill-made: his thighs, his shins, and
hands above,
His strong neck and great vigor show
themselves.
Youth does not fail him, though he
has been broken
By many troubles; nothing, I believe,
Confounds a man like the disordered
sea,
However strong he may have been
before.”
Euryalus answered: “You have spoken
well.
Go now yourself, invite him, and
declare
The words.” Laodamas went into the
midst:
“Come, father-like stranger, try a
contest,
If you have learned one. Surely you
know games;
There is no greater glory while a man
lives
Than what his feet and hands can
accomplish.
Come, try; cast sorrow from your
heart. Your voyage

Is not far off: ship and companions wait.”
Odysseus answered: “Why do you urge me thus,
Mocking me? Sorrows fill my heart, more than
The games. I have suffered and endured much;
Now I sit in your assembly, begging the king
And all the people for a homeward passage.”
Euryalus faced him and spoke in scorn:
“Stranger, I do not liken you to one
Who knows the games men practice. You resemble
A merchant, rather, one who sails in a ship
With many oars, a master of the crew,
Remembering his freight, and watching after
The cargo and the profit. You are not
Like any athlete.”
Odysseus looked beneath his brows and answered:
“Friend, you have not spoken well; you seem a man
Without restraint. The gods do not give every
Good gift to every man—neither beauty, mind,
Nor speech. One man is weaker in his looks,
But God crowns his speech with grace, and people gaze
Upon him gladly; he speaks without fear,

With gentle reverence, and walks through the city
Like a god. Another looks like the immortals,
But no charm crowns his words. So your appearance
Is bright, but your mind is poor; and what you said
Has stirred my heart. I am not ignorant
Of games, as you declare. I think I stood
Among the foremost while youth and hands were mine.
Now I am held by misery and pain,
For I have borne the wars of men and crossed
The bitter waters. Yet I will try the games;
Your word has bitten me, and called me forth.”
He sprang up, seized a discus, greater, thicker,
And heavier than those the Phaeacians used.
He whirled it once and sent it from his hand.
The stone roared; the long-oared sea-men crouched
Upon the ground beneath its flight. It passed
The marks of every throw. Athena set
The boundary, taking a man’s shape, and said:
“Even a blind man could distinguish this mark,
Stranger, for it is not mixed among the others;
It lies far before them. Be confident:

No Phaeacian will reach or pass this throw.”
The much-enduring hero rejoiced to see
His knowledgeable companion in the contest.
He spoke more lightly to the Phaeacians:
“Young men, come reach this throw.
Soon, I believe,
I will cast another as far, or farther.
Let any other whose heart and spirit move him
Try now, in boxing, wrestling, or the foot-race;
I hold back no one, except Laodamas,
For he is my host—who would fight with a friend?
He is my guest-friend; a man must be foolish,
Worthless, to bring a contest against his host
In a foreign land, and so cut off his own
Welcome. I challenge no one else; I wish
To see and test each man face to face.
I am
Not last in every contest men perform.
I know how to bend a polished bow; the first
I would strike among hostile men, although
Companions stood near and shot with me. Only
Philoctetes surpassed me with the bow
Among the Trojan people, when we Achaeans

Shot together. I claim to be far better
Than all other living men who eat the grain.
I would not challenge men who lived before us—
Not Heracles, nor Eurytus of Oechalia,
Who dared to rival even the immortals
In archery. Therefore Eurytus died young;
Apollo killed him, angered that he called
The god to shoot. With the spear I throw as far
As no man sends an arrow. In the foot-race
I fear one Phaeacian may pass me, for
The sea has broken me with wave on wave;
There was no steady food aboard the raft,
And so my limbs are loosened.”
The Phaeacians fell silent. Alcinous
Answered alone: “Stranger, your words are not
Unwelcome; you have shown the excellence
That follows you, angered that this man beside
You in the contest mocked you, hoping no one
Would lessen your worth. Hear me, that you may tell
Another hero, when you feast at home
With wife and children,
remembering our skill
And what Zeus has granted us from ancient days.

We are not perfect boxers or
wrestlers;
But we run swiftly, and excel at sea.
The feast is dear to us, the lyre, the
dance,
Fresh garments, warm baths, and the
soft bed.
Come, then, best dancers of the
Phaeacians,
Dance, so the guest may tell his
friends at home
How far we surpass all in sailing,
feet,
And dancing, and in song. Let
someone bring
Demodocus' clear lyre from the
house."
Nine chosen leaders rose, men of the
people
Who managed each affair in the
contests.
They leveled the dancing-floor and
widened it.
The herald brought the clear lyre to
Demodocus;
The young men skilled in dance
stood round him, striking
The sacred floor with their feet.
Odysseus
Watched the flashing movement,
marvelling.
The singer began a lovely song of
Ares
And Aphrodite crowned with
flowers: how first
They joined in secret within
Hephaestus' house,
And shamed his bed. The Sun, who
saw them joined,

Went to the craftsman and reported
all.
Hephaestus heard the painful tale
and went
To his forge, devising evil in his
heart.
He set the great anvil, fashioned
bonds that none
Could break or loose, and spread
them round the bed,
Many above the ceiling, fine as
spiders'
Threads, invisible even to the blessed
gods.
When all the snare was laid, he went
away
To Lemnos, the city he loved beyond
all lands.
Ares, the golden-reined, was not
unwatchful.
He saw the famous craftsman leave,
and went
To the house, eager for the love of
Cytherea.
She had just returned from Zeus her
mighty father,
And Ares took her hand: "Come,
dear one, let us
Lie down together. Hephaestus is not
here;
He has gone to Lemnos, among the
harsh-voiced Sintians."
She gladly went with him to bed.
Around
Them spread the cunning bonds of
Hephaestus;
They could not move a limb or rise.
Then they
Knew there was no escape. The
famous lame god

Came near again, before he reached
the land
Of Lemnos—for the Sun had
watched and told him.
He stood in the doorway, consumed
by anger,
And cried to all the gods:
“Father Zeus, and you blessed
immortals, come,
That you may see this shameful,
laughable deed:
How Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus,
forever
Dishonors me, the lame one, and
loves
The destructive Ares, handsome and
straight,
While I was made weak. My parents
are to blame;
Would they had never borne me.
Come and look:
The two lie sleeping in my bed of
love.
I will not think they will lie there
long,
However much they love each other.
The snare
And bonds will hold them until my
father gives me back
All the bride-gifts I bestowed for his
shameless
Daughter, beautiful but without
restraint.”
He spoke; the gods gathered at the
bronze-floored house.
Poseidon came, and Hermes, giver of
good,
And Apollo, lord of the far-reaching
bow.

The goddesses remained at home, in
modesty.
The gods stood in the doorway,
givers of good;
Unquenchable laughter rose among
the blessed
As they looked upon the craftsman’s
device.
One said to another: “Evil work does
not
Escape its master; the slow catches
the swift.
Hephaestus, though slow, has caught
Ares, swiftest
Of the gods who hold Olympus, lame
though he is;
His craft has won the adulterer’s
price.”
Apollo asked Hermes: “Messenger,
son of Zeus,
Would you be willing, bound in
bonds this strong,
To sleep beside golden Aphrodite?”
Hermes replied: “Would that this
might come to pass,
Lord Archer! Bonds three times as
many might
Surround me, and all you gods and
goddesses
Look on, if I could sleep beside the
golden
Aphrodite.” The immortals laughed
aloud.
Poseidon did not laugh; he begged
Hephaestus
To release Ares, promising to pay
Whatever was fitting among the
deathless gods.
Hephaestus answered that such a
promise could

Not be trusted, if Ares escaped his debt.
Poseidon pledged again; Hephaestus then
Loosed the bonds. The two sprang up: Ares fled
To Thrace, and Aphrodite came to Cyprus,
To Paphos, where her fragrant altar stands.
The Graces bathed and anointed her with
Immortal oil, and dressed her in delights.
Thus sang the famous singer.
Odysseus
And all the oar-loving Phaeacians took
Joy in the song. Alcinous commanded
Halius and Laodamas to dance alone,
Since none could rival them. They took a lovely
Purple ball, made by wise Polybus.
One
Threw it toward the shadowed clouds, bending back;
The other leaped from earth and caught it easily
Before his feet returned. Then, dancing opposite,
They tested it; the young men beat time around
Them, and a great clamor rose.
Odysseus spoke to Alcinous: "Most famous
Among your people, you promised that your men
Excel in dancing; and I see it now.

Wonder has taken me." The king rejoiced,
And spoke among the oar-loving people:
"Hear me. Our guest seems a thoughtful man.
Let us give him the customary gift.
Twelve
Renowned kings rule among the people, and I
Am thirteenth. Bring each a washed cloak, shirt,
And talent of precious gold; bring everything
Together now, that he may hold it in his hands
And go to supper with a glad heart.
Let
Euryalus atone with words and gift, Since he did not speak fittingly."
All praised the speech and sent their gifts. Euryalus
Gave a sword of bronze, with silver hilt,
And a new-sawn ivory scabbard, saying:
"Hail, father-like stranger. If some harsh word
Was spoken, let the storm-winds carry it away.
May the gods grant you a wife, and let you see
Your native land, for you have suffered long
Far from your friends."
Odysseus answered: "Friend, may you rejoice,
And may the gods give you all good.
May no

Need for the sword you gave me
come upon you.”
He hung the silver-hilted sword
around him.
The sun went down, and the
splendid gifts were there.
The heralds carried them to
Alcinous’ house;
The king’s blameless sons received
them and placed
Them beside their honored mother.
Alcinous
Led them to high seats; then he said
to Arete:
“Bring out the finest chest, my wife,
and place
Within it a washed cloak and shirt.
Set bronze
Upon the fire, and warm the water,
so that
Our guest may bathe, inspect the
gifts the blameless
Phaeacians have brought, enjoy the
feast, and hear
The song. Give him this beautiful
cup of gold,
That, remembering me, he may pour
to Zeus
And the other gods throughout his
days.”
Arete ordered a great tripod set
Beside the fire. The women set it up,
Poured water in, and kindled wood
below.
The fire embraced its belly; the
water warmed.
Meanwhile Arete brought the
splendid chest
From her chamber and laid the
beautiful gifts

Within: clothing and gold. She added
cloak
And shirt, and told Odysseus to look
himself
At the lid, and quickly tie the cord,
lest anyone
Should harm him on the voyage
when sweet sleep
Came upon him in the black ship. He
tied
The carved fastening, learned long
ago from Circe.
The housekeeper told him to enter
the bath.
He gladly saw the warm bath, for
since he left
Calypso’s well-haired house he had
not often
Had such care. The women washed
him and anointed
Him with olive oil; they clothed him
in a cloak
And shirt. He came from the bath
among the men
Who drank wine. Nausicaa, whose
beauty came
From the gods, stood by the
well-built pillar,
And marvelled at him. She spoke:
“Farewell, stranger; when you are in
your own land,
Remember me, for first you owe me
life.”
Odysseus answered: “Daughter of
great-hearted
Alcinous, may Zeus, the
loud-thundering husband
Of Hera, bring me home and let me
see

The day of return. Then, even there,
I would
Pray to you as to a god through every
day,
For you, young woman, saved me.”
He sat upon the chair beside the
king.
They shared the portions and mixed
the wine.
The herald came, leading beloved
Demodocus,
And seated him amid the feasters,
against
A tall pillar. Then Odysseus
addressed him.
From the table he cut a piece of the
white-tusked
Boar, leaving most of the meat, and
said:
“Herald, take this meat to
Demodocus, that he
May eat; though sorrowing, I will
greet him.
Among all mortals singers share in
honor
And reverence, because the Muse has
taught them
Her songs and loved the singing
race.”
The herald brought the meat and
placed it in
The singer’s hands. Demodocus
received it gladly.
They reached for the food before
them. When thirst
And hunger were gone, Odysseus
said:
“Demodocus, I praise you beyond all
men.

Surely the Muse, child of Zeus,
taught you, or Apollo;
You sing the fate of the Achaeans in
order,
All they did and suffered, and all
they labored through,
As if you were there yourself, or
heard it from one
Who knows. Come now, change your
song, and sing the design
Of the wooden horse Epeius made
with Athena;
The one that godlike Odysseus
brought by stratagem
Into the citadel, filled with the men
who sacked
Ilium. If you tell this rightly, I will
say
Before all people that the god gave
you
The singer’s gift of song.”
The singer began where the god
directed him.
He sang how the Argives boarded
their well-benched
Ships, set them on fire, and sailed;
while Odysseus’
Glorious ambush sat in Troy’s
assembly-place,
Hidden within the hollow horse. The
Trojans
Themselves had hauled it to the
citadel.
Around it they sat and argued. Some
wanted to break
The hollow wood with pitiless
bronze; some drag
It to the highest rock and hurl it
down; and some

Said it should remain, a great charm
of the gods—
Which fate would bring to pass, for
Troy was destined
To perish when it received the great
wooden horse,
Holding the best of the Argives, who
carried
Death and fate within it.
He sang how the sons of Achaeans
poured out,
And sacked the steep city; how
Odysseus went
Like Ares with godlike Menelaus to
The house of Deiphobus, and
endured there
The most terrible fight, yet
conquered through
The heart of Athena. Thus he sang.
Odysseus
Melted; tears ran down his cheeks.
As a woman
Clings and cries around her husband,
fallen
Before her city and her people,
defending
The city and children from the
pitiless day,
And sees him dying, gasping, while
behind him
The enemy drive spears into his back
and shoulders
And drag him into slavery and
toil—so
Odysseus shed the most pitiful tears.
The tears escaped all others;
Alcinous alone
Saw and understood, sitting near
him, hearing

The heavy sigh. He spoke at once to
the
Oar-loving Phaeacians:
“Hear me. Let Demodocus stop the
clear lyre.
His song does not please all alike.
Since we began
The meal and the singer rose, our
guest has not
Stopped his grievous mourning.
Some heavy sorrow
Must have surrounded his mind. Let
the singer stop,
That host and guest may rejoice
alike; for all
This escort and these gifts are made
for the guest,
Who stands as brother and suppliant
to a man
With even a little understanding.
“Do not hide it with clever thoughts,
but tell us.
It is better that you speak. Tell the
name by which
Your mother and father called you,
and by which
Others in the city and around it
knew you.
No one is wholly nameless among
men, whether
Bad or good, when first he comes to
life; parents
Give a name to all. Tell me your
land, your people,
And your city, that our ships may
carry you home
With their understanding. The
Phaeacians have
No helmsmen, nor rudders such as
other ships possess;

The ships themselves understand the
minds of men,
And know every city and fertile field.
They cross
The sea most swiftly, hidden in mist
and cloud;
They have no fear of harm or loss.
Yet once I heard
My father Nausithous say Poseidon
was angry
With us, because we escort all men
without harm.
He said the god would someday
shatter a fine
Phaeacian ship returning from
escort, and cover
Our city with a great mountain. Let
the god fulfill
That—or leave it unfinished, as his
heart desires.
“But tell me plainly where you
wandered, and what lands
Of men you reached: their cities well
inhabited,
Those savage, unjust, and lawless,
and those who
Welcome strangers and fear the gods.
Tell me why
You grieve within your heart when
you hear the fate
Of the Argives and Danaans, and of
Ilium.
The gods shaped that fate and spun
destruction for men,
So that it might become a song for
generations.
Did some noble kinsman die before
Ilium—
A son-in-law, or father-in-law,
among those

Who are closest after one’s own
blood and family?
Or was it a beloved companion, wise
and brave?
For a good companion is no less dear
Than a brother, when the heart has
learned his worth.”

Source range: Book 8. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 9

First-pass working translation

Odysseus answered: “Alcinous, most renowned
Among the people, it is a lovely thing
To hear a singer such as this one is,
Whose voice is like the voice of the gods.
For I declare that nothing is more sweet
Than when gladness fills all the people, and guests
Within the house sit listening to the singer,
While tables stand beside them full of bread
And meat, and from the mixing-bowl the steward
Draws wine and pours it through the cups. This seems
To me the fairest thing beneath the sun.
“But you have turned my heart toward mourning. Why
Should I begin to tell you all my grief?
The gods who dwell in heaven have given me
Too many. Yet I will tell my name, that you
May know it, and may be my friend hereafter,
Though far away I live. I am Odysseus,
Laertes’ son, whom men have learned to praise
For every kind of craft; my fame reaches

The sky. My home is Ithaca, beneath
Neriton’s shaking leaves, a mountain seen

From every side. Around it lie many islands—

Same, Dulichium, and wooded Zacynthus.

Ithaca lies low toward the west, while these

Lean toward the dawn and sun. It is rough, but good,

And nurses men; no land is dearer to me.

“Calypso held me, brilliant among goddesses,

In hollow caverns, desiring me for husband;

Circe kept me in her house on Aeaea, Desiring me for husband. Neither could

Persuade the heart within me. For there is nothing

Sweeter than one’s own land and parents, though

A man may live in a rich house far away,

Among a people strange and distant from his.”

“Hear now the griefs I suffered on my way

Homeward from Troy, by the will of Zeus.

The Cicones dwelt near Ismarus. I sacked

Their town, killed the men, and brought the women out

With much spoil; we divided everything,

That none among us should go without his share.

I told the others: 'Leave now, while we can.'
But they, in foolishness, refused to hear.
They drank much wine beside the shore, and killed
The sheep and oxen on the beach.
The Cicones
Called other Cicones, their neighbors inland,
More numerous and stronger, skilled at fighting
From chariots and on foot, as many as
The leaves and flowers that rise in spring.
"Then Dawn appeared, and they came upon us. We
Stood fast beside the ships, and fought; at last
The Cicones drove us back. Six men from every
Ship were killed; the rest escaped with life.
We sailed, though grieving for the men we lost.
Yet Zeus would not permit us to depart
Before we had raised each man's threefold cry,
Calling his name, who fell upon the plain.
"The Thunderer sent a North Wind against our ships,
A storm that shrieked and covered sea and land
With clouds. The dark night came down from the sky.
We dragged the ships ashore, and lowered every sail;

Two days we lay beside the water, enduring
Our sorrow and our hunger. On the third day,
When Dawn with shining hair appeared, we raised
The masts, spread sail, and took our seats. The wind
And helmsmen carried us; I thought we would escape.
But when we rounded Malea, the currents
And North Wind drove us beyond Cythera.
For nine days we were carried over the sea;
On the tenth we reached the land of men
Who eat the lotus."
"There we went ashore, drew water, and beside
The ships prepared a meal. When we had eaten,
I sent some companions to discover who
The people were. They met the Lotus-Eaters,
Who did not wish to harm our friends, but gave them
The lotus, honey-sweet to eat.
Whoever
Tasted the fruit forgot the homeward road,
And wished to remain among the Lotus-Eaters,
Feeding on lotus, and forgot the day
Of return. I dragged them back by force, and bound
Them underneath the benches in the ships.

Then I commanded all the other
friends
To climb aboard at once, lest any
taste
The lotus and forget the road. They
quickly
Took their places, struck the gray sea
with the oars,
And rowed in sorrow.”
“From there we sailed to the land of
the Cyclopes,
A proud and lawless people. They
put their trust
In the immortal gods, and do not
plant
With hands, nor plow; but all things
grow for them
Without the seed or plow: wheat,
barley, vines,
And clusters heavy with the grapes
that Zeus’
Rain nourishes. They have no
assemblies
For counsel, and no fixed laws; each
one within
His cave upon the mountain gives
the rule
To wife and children, caring nothing
for
The rest.
“Opposite their land lies an island
flat
And wooded, neither near nor far
away.
Wild goats beyond counting live
there; no man
Hunts them, and they are not
disturbed by feet.
No shepherd drives them, nor do
plowed fields meet

The island’s edge; it is forever empty
Of men, yet it is not a poor land.
There
Are meadows moist beneath the gray
sea’s shore,
And vines that never fail. The earth
is level;
The harvest would be rich. There is a
harbor
Where ships can shelter, and no
cable need
Be thrown, nor anchor cast, nor
mooring-rope
Be fastened; a ship may wait until the
crew
Desires to leave.
“At the island’s head a clear spring
flows beneath
The cave, and poplars grow around
it. There
We came ashore. Some god guided us
through night.
We saw no light, and walked in
darkness; mist
Was thick around the ships. When
Dawn appeared,
We wandered through the island,
marvelling.
The nymphs, daughters of
aegis-bearing Zeus,
Drove the wild goats down toward
us, that our friends
Might eat. We brought the curved
bows and long spears
From the ships, divided into three
companies,
And hunted. A god granted us a
splendid catch:
Nine for each ship, and ten for mine
alone.

All day we sat and ate beside the ships,
And drank the sweet red wine we had taken
At Ismarus, since our supply was not yet gone.
“From the island we saw the smoke and heard
The voices of the Cyclopes and their sheep.
When the sun went down, we slept beside the shore.
At dawn I called my men together:
‘Remain here; I will go with my own ship
And crew to learn who lives upon the mainland,
Whether they are unjust and wild, or fear
The gods, and honor strangers.”
“I went aboard, commanded my companions
To follow, and loosed the ship’s ropes. We reached
The mainland quickly, and found near the sea
A cave high-vaulted, shadowed by the laurel.
Many sheep and goats lay there; a wide yard
Surrounded it, with pine and oak.
The master
Of that cave was a huge man, who pastured
His flocks alone, apart from all the others,
And knew no law. He was a wonder to behold,
Not like a man who eats the bread of men,

But like a wooded peak among the hills.
“I told the companions to remain beside
The ship, and guard it. I selected twelve,
The best among them, and went on. I carried
A skin of dark wine, sweet and strong, a gift
From Maron, son of Euanthes, priest Of Apollo who protects Ismarus.
When we sacked the city, I preserved him,
His wife and child, respecting the holy man.
He gave me seven talents of bright gold,
A silver mixing-bowl, and twelve wine-jars
Of dark, unmixed delight. No servant in
The house knew of it; only he and wife
And steward knew. One cup, when mixed with twenty
Of water, sent a fragrance through the room,
And no one could resist its sweetness.
“I filled a great skin with it, and took provisions.
My spirit told me I would meet a man
Who had great strength, wild, knowing nothing of law.
We reached the cave, but found the master absent,
Pasturing his rich flocks. We entered, lit

A fire, and ate the cheeses. We
waited there
Until he returned. My companions
urged me:
'Let us take cheeses and depart; drive
the lambs
And kids out of the cave; we could
get away
Swiftly across the water.' But I
refused.
I wished to see the man, and whether
he would
Offer a guest-gift. His appearance
was not
To bring my companions joy.
"He came at evening, bearing a great
load
Of dry wood, and threw it down
with a loud crash.
We hid in the cave. He drove inside
the sheep
He milked, and left the males
outside. Then he
Lifted a huge stone, and set it in the
doorway;
It was so great that no mortal force
could move it—
The mountain itself might be the
gate. He sat
And milked the ewes and bleating
goats in turn,
And placed a nursing lamb beneath
each dam.
Then, when his work was done, he
saw us, and asked:
"Strangers, who are you? From
where have you sailed
Across the sea? Do you come on
business, or

Do you wander like pirates, risking
death
Upon the waves, and bringing harm
to others?"
"Our hearts were broken by his
thundering voice
And monstrous form; but I replied:
'We are Achaeans, driven from Troy
by winds,
Across the great sea, along strange
roads. We seek
Your knees, and ask the guest-gift
strangers receive.
Honor the gods, for Zeus protects
the guest;
He is the avenger of every suppliant.'
"He answered: 'You are foolish,
stranger, or come
From far away, to tell me to fear the
gods.
We Cyclopes do not care for
aegis-bearing
Zeus, or the other gods; our own
strength is more.
I would not spare you or your
companions out
Of fear of Zeus, unless my spirit
urged me.
But tell me where you left your
well-benched ship.
Is it at the edge of this land, or
elsewhere?"
"He spoke to test me, but I knew his
mind.
I answered with a falsehood: 'Our
ship was wrecked
By Earth-Shaker Poseidon on the
shore,
Against the rocks at the edge of your
land.

Only we escaped the sea.’
“He gave no answer. He sprang,
seized two men,
And dashed them on the ground like
puppies. Their brains
Ran out, and earth was wet with
blood. He tore
Them limb from limb and made his
supper. He ate
Like a mountain lion, leaving
nothing—not
The entrails, bones, or flesh. We
raised our hands
To Zeus, but Zeus did not grant our
prayer.
The Cyclops filled his enormous
belly,
Drank the milk, and slept among his
sheep.
“Then I considered drawing my
sharp sword,
And stabbing him where the liver
lies beneath
The ribs, but another thought held
me back.
We could not move the stone from
the doorway;
We would all die there. So we
groaned, and waited
For bright Dawn.”
“When early Dawn appeared, he
kindled fire,
Milked the beautiful sheep, and did
his customary
Work. Then again he seized two men
and made
His meal. He drove the flocks from
the cave,
And easily moved the great stone;
then put it

Back, as a man might set a lid upon a
quiver.
He went whistling after his fat sheep;
we were
Left within, and began to plan his
death,
And our escape, if Athena gave the
way.
“There stood a green olive trunk, a
great club,
As thick as the mast of a broad black
ship,
With twenty oars, the kind used on
the sea
By a cargo ship that crosses the dark
water.
I cut a length from it, and gave the
men
The task of smoothing it. They stood
around me;
I sharpened one end, and hardened it
in fire.
Then I hid it beneath the dung that
lay
Throughout the cave. I chose four
men, the best;
The fifth would be myself. We cast
the lots,
And mine was chosen to be the one
who drove
The burning stake into his eye.
“At evening the shepherd came, with
woolly flocks.
He drove them into the cave; he did
not leave
A single ram outside, perhaps
suspecting harm.
He moved the stone, milked his
sheep and goats, and then

Seized two companions for his meal.
I went
Near him, holding the dark wine in a
bowl:
“Cyclops, drink this wine, since you
have eaten
The flesh of men. You will discover
soon
What kind of cargo our ship held,
hidden here.
We came to you as suppliants; but
your rage
Has made your house a place of
murder. No man
Will come here after this.’
“He drank, and the sweet liquor
pleased him greatly.
He asked for more: ‘Give me another
cup,
And tell me your name, that I may
give you a guest-gift.
The fruitful land provides the
Cyclopes
With wine too, but this is a stream of
nectar
And ambrosia.’
“I gave him three times, and three
times he drank.
Then, when the wine had clouded all
his mind,
I spoke with gentle words: ‘Cyclops,
you ask
My famous name. I will tell it; then
give me
The gift you promised. Nobody is my
name.
My father, mother, and companions
call me
Nobody.’
“He answered: ‘Nobody I will eat last,

And all the others first; this shall be
your gift.’
Then he fell backward, lay with his
neck twisted,
And all his neck and throat were full
of wine
And human flesh. We drove the
sharpened stake
Into the embers, until it glowed; I
spoke
To the men, to keep their courage,
lest they flee.
When it was near to burn, we drew it
out;
And stood around him. A god gave
us courage.
They lifted the stake, and drove its
heated point
Into his eye. I leaned upon it from
above,
And twisted it, as when a shipwright
turns
The auger in a beam. The blood ran
round
The burning stake; the heat scorched
brow and lashes;
The eye hissed, and its roots crackled
in the fire.
As when a smith plunges a great axe
into
Cold water, and it screams,
strengthening the iron—
So hissed his eye around the olive
stake.
“He gave a dreadful cry, and the cliffs
rang back.
We fled away; and other Cyclopes
heard him,
Those who dwelt in caves along the
windy heights.

They came round his cave and asked him:

“What has happened, Polyphemos?
Why do you cry

Through the immortal night and
wake us all?

Is some mortal stealing your sheep?
Is someone

By force attacking you?”

“From within the cave, great
Polyphemos shouted:

‘Nobody is killing me by deceit, not
force!’

They answered: ‘If no one attacks
you, then you are

Sick, and no escape from the great
Zeus is possible.

Pray to your father, lord Poseidon.’
They went away.

My heart laughed: my name and
flawless counsel

Had deceived him.”

“The Cyclops groaned, groped for
the stone, and moved it.

Then he sat at the doorway, hands
spread wide,

To catch whoever came out among
the sheep.

He thought me foolish; but I
searched for the best

Way to save my companions and
myself. All plans

Were turned within my mind, since
death was near.

At last this seemed the best: there
were great rams,

Well-fleeced, with thick and dark
wool. I tied them

Together, three by three, with the
withes that grew

Upon the ground. The middle ram
bore one man;

The other two went on either side, a
shield

For my companion. For myself, I
chose the largest,

Most splendid ram of all, and clung
beneath him,

Curled beneath his shaggy belly,
holding tight

To his rich fleece with both hands.

“So we waited, groaning, for bright
Dawn. When early

Dawn appeared, the rams rushed
toward the pasture;

The ewes remained within the cave,
unmilked,

Bleating with swollen udders. Their
master, sick

With pain, felt every ram’s back as it
passed,

But did not understand that men
were fastened

Below the woolly bellies. Last of all
the ram,

Heavy with fleece and me, came
toward the door.

Polyphemos touched him and said:

“Ram, why are you last today? You
never used

To trail behind the flock; first you
always went,

To crop the tender flowers of grass,
and first

To reach the streams and fold at
evening. Now

You are the last. Do you grieve for
your master’s eye,

Which some evil man destroyed,
together with

His miserable companions? If you
could speak,
You would tell me where he hides. I
would crush
His brains against the ground, and
my heart would rest
From the troubles Nobody, worthless
man, has caused.’
“So speaking, he let the ram go out.
When we
Were clear of cave and yard, I first
let go
The ram beneath me, and loosed the
others.
We drove the long-fleeced animals to
the ship,
Turning often to look behind, until
we reached
Our companions, who welcomed us
with tears.
Those who had died we mourned,
calling each man’s name;
But I would not let them cry aloud. I
ordered
Them to load the sheep, and climb
aboard, and sit
Upon the benches. They took their
places; then
They rowed the gray sea. When we
were twice as far
From shore as a man’s shout may
carry, I called back:
“Cyclops, no weak man’s
companions did you eat
Within your hollow cave. Your
cruelty has found
Its recompense. You would not
honor the guest
In your own house; therefore Zeus
has punished you.

I am Odysseus, son of Laertes, and
my home
Is Ithaca.’
“He tore the peak from a mountain
and threw it;
It fell before the ship, and the sea
rose high.
The wave came back, and drove us
toward the shore.
I seized a long pole and pushed us
from the land;
I urged the men with gestures to row
hard,
And they bent to the oars. Yet when
we had escaped,
My companions restrained me, each
in turn:
‘Do not provoke him; the stone he
throws may shatter
The ship and kill us all.’ But my heart
would not
Obey. I called again:
“Cyclops, if any mortal asks you who
blinded
Your eye, tell him that Odysseus,
sacker of cities,
Laertes’ son, whose home is Ithaca,
did it.’
“He groaned: ‘Then the ancient
prophecy has come.
Long ago a prophet, Telemus, son of
Eurymus,
Who surpassed all men in prophecy,
lived here
And grew old among the Cyclopes.
He foretold
That Odysseus would take my sight.
I always
Expected a great and beautiful man
to come;

But a small, worthless creature
blinded me,
After overcoming me with wine.
Come near,
That I may give you guest-gifts, and
ask the lord
Poseidon to grant you the escort
home.’
“I answered: ‘If only I could take your
life,
And send you down to Hades’ house,
as surely
As no god could heal your eye—not
even
Earth-Shaker Poseidon.’
“Then he prayed to lord Poseidon,
stretching
His hands toward the starry sky:
‘Hear me, dark-haired Earth-Shaker,
god of the sea;
If I am truly your son, and you call
me yours,
Grant that Odysseus, sacker of cities,
son
Of Laertes, may never reach his
home. But if
It is his fate to see his friends again,
And come to his well-built house
and native land,
Let him return late, in misery, after
losing
All companions, upon another man’s
ship;
And let him find trouble within his
house.’
“So he prayed; and the dark-haired
god heard him.
He lifted another stone, much larger,
whirled it,

And threw it behind the black ship.
A wave
Rose beneath it, and drove us back
toward the shore.
We reached the island, where the
other ships
Had gathered close together, waiting
for us.
We came ashore, divided the sheep,
and gave
An equal share to every man. My
companions
Gave me the great ram as my
portion. On shore
We sacrificed it to Zeus, who gathers
clouds,
Lord of the dark aegis, highest of the
gods.
But he did not accept the smoke, and
in his mind
He planned the destruction of our
ships and friends.”
“All day we ate the abundant flesh
and drank
The sweet wine. When the sun had
gone to rest,
We slept beside the breaking sea.
When rosy Dawn
Appeared, I called the companions,
ordered them
To climb aboard, and loose the
stern-ropes. They
Went quickly in, sat at the oarlocks,
and struck
The gray sea with the oars in ordered
rhythm.
From there we sailed onward, with
grieving hearts,
Glad to have escaped death, yet
having lost

Our beloved companions.”

Source range: Book 9. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Odysseus and his companions escape the Cyclops beneath the rams
Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 10

First-pass working translation

“We came to the Aeolian island,
where dwelt
Aeolus, son of Hippotas, dear to the
gods.
It floated on the sea; around it ran
An unbroken wall of bronze, while
smooth rock rose
Above. His twelve children lived
within the house,
Six daughters and six sons in their
first youth.
He gave the daughters to his sons in
marriage;
They feast continually beside their
father
And their gracious mother, with
every good thing
Before them. Through the day the
house is filled
With fragrance; through the night
the walls resound.
“For a month he questioned me in
turn: the fall
Of Ilium, the Argive fleet, and how
The army made its homeward way. I
told him all.
Then, when I asked to leave, he did
not refuse
But made my passage ready. From an
ox-hide
He stripped the hide of a
nine-year-old beast,
And bound within it every wind that
blows.
The son of Cronus made him keeper
of the winds:

He can still them or rouse them as he
wills.

He tied the sack beneath the hollow
ship’s

Benches, with a bright cord of silver,
lest

The least breath escape. For me he
sent the West Wind,

To bear our ships and us toward
home; but all

His plan was vain, for our own folly
ruined it.

“Nine days and nights we sailed. On
the tenth day

Our homeland came in sight; we
were so near

That we could see the men who
tended fires.

Then sleep, sweet and oppressive,
seized me. I had

Not held the rudder from my hands,
for I desired

To reach Ithaca sooner. My
companions

Began to murmur, and one spoke to
another:

“How this man is loved and honored
wherever

He goes! What wealth he brings from
Troy to Ithaca!

We, who have worked as hard, have
nothing. Come,

Let us see what lies in that great
hide; perhaps

It holds gold, silver, and precious
gifts.’

“They said this, and their counsel
overcame them.

They loosed the cord; the winds
rushed out at once.

A storm seized us, and carried us
away
From our own country. I awoke, and
weighed
The matter in my mind: should I fall
from the ship
And perish in the sea, or bear it
silently
And stay among the living? I
endured,
And lay there covered, while the
ships were driven
Back over the sea.”
“We reached the Aeolian island
again, and went
Ashore. We drew the ships up, then
fetched water
Quickly; and near the ships we ate
our meal.
When we had eaten and drunk, I
took a herald
And one companion, and went to
the house.
We found Aeolus feasting beside his
wife
And children. We stood at the
threshold, and they
Were struck with wonder. ‘How have
you come again,
Odysseus? What hostile god has
stopped you
On your homeward road? We sent
you forth with care,
That you might reach your country
and your house,
Wherever it lay.’
“I answered: ‘My companions ruined
us, and sleep
Overcame me, though you must help
us. Put this right.’

I spoke with gentle words, but they
held their peace.
At last the father answered:
“Away! It is not fitting that I help a
man
Whom the blessed gods so clearly
hate. You come here
Again because the gods pursue you.
Go;
It would be a sin for me to welcome
you
When heaven itself is hostile. Leave
at once.’
“So speaking, he sent me away. We
sailed in grief.
The companions’ labor wore them
down; our own
Folly denied us. For six days and
nights we rowed
Continuously. On the seventh we
reached
The city of Lamos, in the land
Of the Laestrygonians, whose
shepherd’s call
Can answer shepherd across the hills,
so near
Are day and night. There a man who
never sleeps
Could earn a double wage, herding
white sheep
By day and dark-eyed sheep by
night.”
“We entered a harbor ringed by
cliffs. The shore
Rose steeply on both sides, while two
headlands
Leaned toward one another and left
a narrow mouth.
All my companions drew their ships
inside,

And fastened them together; not one
ship remained
Outside, since the harbor had no
swell. I alone
Moored my ship beyond it, at the
end of the land,
And tied her to the rocks with
cables.
“Then we climbed to a high lookout.
No smoke
Rose from the land, nor sound of
human work.
I sent two men and a herald to
discover
What people lived there. They found
a road that led
From the ships into the city. A young
girl,
The daughter of Antiphates, met
them there;
She had come down for water at
Artacia’s spring.
They asked her who the lord of that
land might be.
She pointed toward her father’s
high-roofed house.
“They entered, and saw his wife as
tall as a mountain.
She called her husband from the
meeting-place;
He came, and seized one of my
companions, and made
His supper of him. The other two
fled back
Toward the ships. Antiphates raised
a shout;
The giant Laestrygonians gathered,
countless,
Not like men, but like the gods.
From the cliffs

They hurled enormous stones; and
from the ships
Came dreadful cries as men were
killed. They speared
The living like fish, and carried them
away.
“While they destroyed the ships
within the harbor,
I drew my sharp sword, cut the cable
of my own,
And ordered all the oarsmen to bend
hard.
They rowed from death. The others
could not escape;
The steep rocks enclosed them, and
the narrow harbor
Held them fast. Eleven ships were
lost; one alone,
Mine, remained. Thus we fled,
though grieving deeply.”
“We came to Aeaea, an island where
Circe
Lived, the well-haired goddess,
skilled in every spell,
The sister of the deadly-minded
Aeetes.
Both were born of Helios, who lights
the world,
And of Perse, daughter of Ocean.
For two days and two nights we lay
beside the shore,
Our hearts worn out, awaiting death.
When Dawn
With braided hair brought the third
day, I took
My spear and sword, and climbed
the island’s ridge,
That I might see what work the
people there performed.

I reached the summit, stood above
the smoke,
And saw it rising from Circe's house
among
The thick forest. I considered: should
I go
At once to learn who lived there, or
return
To the ship, call out the companions,
and send
Them to investigate? I chose to
return,
For it seemed better first to feed the
men.
“Near the ship some god showed me
a great-antlered
Stag. I struck him with my spear, and
the bronze
Went through him. He fell in the
dust. I bound
His feet with twisted osiers, cut from
the ground,
And carried him toward the ship,
leaning upon
My spear. I washed my hands, and
called the men:
“Friends, though afflicted, we will
not yet go down
To Hades. While food and wine
remain aboard,
Remember to eat; do not surrender
here
To hunger.’
“They obeyed. We sat beside the sea,
and ate
Until the sun went down. When
darkness came,
We slept along the shore. At early
Dawn

I called the men, and spoke among
them:
“You do not know where lies the
sunrise, nor
The place of sunset, nor where the
sun that gives
Light goes beneath the earth. Let us
consider
How we may discover it. I do not
think
There is another way; yet I climbed
the ridge
And saw this island lies encircled by
the sea,
A low land. Smoke rose from its
center.’
“The companions’ hearts failed them;
they remembered
The deeds of the Laestrygonians and
the Cyclops,
And wept aloud. Their mourning
could not help.
I divided the men into two
companies,
And gave each a leader: I
commanded one,
While the godlike Eurylochus
commanded
The other. We shook the lots within
a helmet;
Eurylochus’ lot leapt out.”
“Eurylochus went inland with twice
eleven men.
They found a polished house within
a clearing,
Built of cut stone, and on its height
wolves and lions
Moved as if tame; Circe had drugged
them, and they

Did not spring upon the men, but
rose and fawned
Around them, as dogs welcome their
master from
A meal, for he always brings them
pleasant scraps.
So wolves and lions fawned upon the
men; they feared
The beasts, and stood before the
shining doors.
“Within, they heard Circe singing
with a lovely
Voice, as a goddess works at her
great loom,
Moving the shuttle through its
shining web.
Polites, dearest to me and wise in
speech,
Spoke first: ‘A woman sings within,
and works
The great loom beautifully. Let us
call out.’
They called; and Circe opened the
bright doors,
And invited them inside. All
followed blindly;
Eurylochus alone remained, fearing
deceit.
“She brought them in, and seated
them on chairs;
Then mixed for them Pramnian wine
with cheese,
Meal, and dark honey. She cast a
drug into it,
That they should wholly forget their
native land.
When they had drunk, she struck
them with her wand,
And shut them in the sties. They had
the heads,

The voices, bristles, and the shape of
swine,
But their minds remained as they
had been before.
She threw acorns, beech-nuts, and
wild cornel fruit
Before them, such as swine eat in the
forest.
“Eurylochus ran back to the black
ship, to tell
The bitter news. He could not utter
one word,
Though he desired to speak; his eyes
were full
Of tears, and his heart foresaw
disaster. At last
We questioned him, and he told
everything.
I slung my silver-studded sword
around me,
Took up my bow, and ordered him
to lead me back.
He caught my knees, and begged:
“Do not take me by force. I will
remain here.
I know you will not return, nor bring
another
Companion back. Let us flee with
those who remain.’
“But I left him beside the ship, and
climbed
The sacred island. There, as I
approached
The house of Circe, I met Hermes of
the golden
Rod, in the form of a young man. He
took my hand,
And spoke:
“Why, wretched man, do you wander
here alone,

Knowing nothing of the island? Your
companions
Are shut within the sties, in the
shape of swine.
You came to rescue them; yet I think
you will
Not return yourself. Here is a saving
herb,
The moly; the gods find it difficult to
dig.
Its root is black, its flower white as
milk.
No mortal man can pluck it, but the
gods
Can do all things. I will tell you every
danger.
Circe will mix a drug and strike you
with her wand,
But her spells will not take hold. This
herb will stop
The spell. Then rush upon her with
your sword,
As though you meant to kill her; she
will seize
Your knees in fear. Make her swear
the great oath
That no further evil will be devised
against you,
Lest she strip you of your courage
when you lie
Beside her.”
“So Hermes gave me the herb, and
taught me all.
He went away through the wooded
island, back
Toward Olympus. I went on to
Circe’s house,
My heart full of dark foreknowledge.
At the doors

I stood, and called; the goddess heard
my voice.
She opened the shining doors,
invited me,
And I went in, not gladly, but
prepared.
She seated me upon a chair with
studs of silver,
Fine and elaborate; beneath my feet
she set
A footstool. Then she mixed the drug
within
A golden cup, and gave it me. I
drank,
But the charm did not take me. She
struck me
With her wand, and spoke:
“Go now to the sty, and lie there
with the others.’
“Then I drew my sharp sword,
rushed upon her, and
She cried aloud, caught my knees,
and said:
“Who are you? From what land?
Where is your city?
My drug has not enchanted you. No
mortal
Has resisted it before. You have a
mind
That cannot be bewitched. You must
be Odysseus,
The man of many turns, whom
golden-wanded Hermes
Always told me would come from
Troy upon his way
Homeward. Put away your sword; let
us become
Friends. I will give you all the
welcome due.’

“Then I answered: ‘Circe, how could
you ask me
To become gentle with you, when
you changed my men
Into swine? You have devised
another trap,
And call me to your bed, intending
to strip
My strength when I am naked. I will
not go
To your bed unless you swear the
great oath
That you will not devise another evil
against me.’
“She swore at once, as I required.
Then I went
Into her beautiful bed. Her four
maidens came,
Born from the springs and groves
and sacred rivers;
They prepared the shining house.
One spread purple
Cloths upon the chairs; one brought
silver tables;
The third mixed wine in a golden
cup; the fourth
Brought water and kindled a great
fire beneath
The tripod. When the water boiled,
she bathed me,
Poured warm water over my head
and shoulders,
And anointed me with oil. She
dressed me in a
Beautiful cloak and shirt, then led
me in
And seated me on a chair with silver
studs.
“A maid brought water in a golden
pitcher,

Over a silver basin, so I could wash;
Another drew a polished table near.
The honored
Stewardess brought bread and many
dishes, giving
Freely from what the house
contained. Circe sat
Before me and ordered food and
wine; but I had
No pleasure in them, for another
thought possessed me.
“When the goddess saw me sitting
without eating,
She asked: ‘Odysseus, why are you
silent? Do
You suspect some other deceit?
There is no reason
For fear; you made me swear the
great oath.’
“I answered: ‘What man who is just
and thoughtful
Could eat or drink before he saw his
friends,
Who are shut in your pens, in the
form of swine?
If you desire me to eat, release them
first;
Let me see them with my own eyes.’
“I spoke; Circe went out through the
doors, and held
Her wand; she opened the sties, and
drove the men
Out like fattened swine of nine years’
age.
They stood before her. She went
among them,
Anointed each with another drug;
the bristles
Fell from their limbs, and the men
became again

Younger and fairer, larger to behold.
They knew me, and each took my
hand; sweet grief
Seized them, and the house rang with
their lament.
Circe herself came near, and spoke:
“Godlike Odysseus, go now to the
ship,
And draw it up upon the shore, then
bring your
Goods and tackle into the sacred
house.’
“I went back to the ships and shore,
and found my
Companions weeping bitterly. When
they saw me,
They gathered round, and welcomed
me as calves
Around their mothers, once the
calves have grazed
The rich meadow and returned to
the fold.
So gladly they surrounded me; it
seemed to them
They had escaped the city and their
native land.
We all went back to Circe’s house,
and stayed.”
“For a full year we lived there, eating
flesh
And honey-sweet wine. When the
year was done,
And the seasons turned, my
companions called me aside:
“Unmindful man, remember your
native land,
If it is truly fixed in your heart to
live.
The time has come to seek the house
and land

Where you were born.’
“Their words persuaded my proud
heart. I said:
‘Do not keep me here longer against
my will;
Make ready the passage home.’ She
did not refuse.
She spoke:
“You must not remain here against
your will. But you
Do not know which road leads home.
You must first go
To the house of Hades and
Persephone,
To ask the Theban prophet Tiresias,
whose mind
The queen of the dead allowed to
keep its sense
Even in death. The other dead are
shadows.’
“My heart broke; I sat upon the bed,
and wept.
I no longer wished to live, nor see the
sunlight.
When I had taken pleasure in tears, I
answered:
“Who will guide us on that road? No
man has ever
Reached Hades in a black ship.’
“Circe answered: ‘Son of Laertes, do
not let
The lack of a guide trouble you.
Raise the mast,
Spread the white sail, and sit; the
North Wind will
Carry you. When you have crossed
Ocean’s stream,
And reached the low shore and
Persephone’s grove,

Where tall poplars and barren
willows grow,
Beach the ship beside deep-eddying
Ocean,
And go yourself to the house of
Hades.
“There is a rock, and near it two
rivers flow,
The river of fire and the river of
mourning;
Before them is a white stone. Dig a
trench
As long and broad as a cubit on each
side.
Pour offerings for all the dead: first
honey
And milk, then sweet wine, and
sprinkle white barley.
Pray to the empty heads of the dead,
and promise
That when you return to Ithaca you
will offer
A barren cow in your halls, the best
you own,
And fill the pyre with gifts for all the
dead.
“But to Tiresias alone bring a black
ram,
The best among your flocks. When
you have prayed
To the famous dead, sacrifice a black
sheep
And a dark ewe, turning their heads
toward Erebus.
You yourself must turn away, and
look toward
The river’s streams. Then the souls of
the dead
Will come to you in their thousands.

“Tell your companions to flay and
burn the sheep,
And pray to the gods, to Hades and
dread Persephone.
Draw your sword and sit, and do not
let the dead
Come near the blood until you have
questioned
Tiresias. The prophet will quickly
tell you
The road, the measure of it, and how
to return
Across the fish-filled sea.”
“She spoke; at once I returned to the
ship,
And roused the companions. They
climbed aboard;
They loosed the ropes, and followed
the black ship’s road.
Circe sent a favorable wind behind
us,
The fair-haired goddess, mighty and
easy to obey.
We raised the mast, spread the white
sail, and sat
Within the ship; the wind and
helmsman held the course.
“All day the sail was filled. When the
sun went down,
The shadows covered every road.
Our ship reached
The boundary of Ocean’s
deep-flowing stream.
There lie the Cimmerian people,
whose city
And country are covered in mist and
cloud;
The shining sun does not look down
upon them,

Neither when he climbs the starry
heaven, nor
When he turns back again from
heaven toward earth.
Deadly night is spread over those
miserable men.
“We drew the ship ashore, and
brought out the sheep.
We went beside Ocean’s stream until
we reached
The place Circe had named.
Perimedes and
Eurylochos held fast the victims. I
drew
My sharp sword, dug the trench, and
made the offerings:
Honey and milk to the dead, sweet
wine, and water;
I sprinkled white barley. Then I
prayed to the dead,
Promising that when I reached
Ithaca I would
Sacrifice a barren cow in my house,
the best
I owned, and fill the pyre with gifts;
and to
Tiresias alone I promised a black
ram,
The finest in the flocks of Ithaca.
“When I had prayed to the tribes of
the dead,
I took the sheep and cut their throats
above
The trench. The dark blood flowed.
The souls rose up,
Those dead who had died, and wives
and unwedded youth,
Old men worn out by age, and
tender girls whose hearts

Were newly touched by grief; and
many wounded men,
Pierced by bronze-tipped spears, still
wearing armor
Red with blood. They came in
crowds around the trench,
With an unearthly cry. Pale fear took
hold of me.
I told my companions to flay the
sheep and burn
Them as an offering to the gods, to
Hades
And Persephone. I sat with drawn
sword, and would
Not let the dead draw near the blood
until I asked
Tiresias what he knew.
“So we waited at the edge of Ocean,
in darkness,
Having reached the road by which
the dead assemble.”

Source range: Book 10. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK II

First-pass working translation

“When we had come down to the
ship and sea,
We drew her first into the sacred
water,
Set mast and sail, brought the sheep
aboard,
And climbed ourselves, grieving and
shedding tears.
Circe, the lovely-haired and mighty
goddess,
Sent a following wind behind the
dark ship.
We raised the mast, spread the white
sail, and sat;
The wind and helmsman kept the
course. All day
The ship moved swiftly. When the
sun went down,
The shadows covered every road. We
reached
The deep-flowing stream of Ocean.
There the Cimmerians
Have their city and their land,
wrapped in mist
And cloud; the shining sun does not
look down
Upon them, neither when he climbs
the starry sky,
Nor when he turns again from
heaven to earth.
Deadly night is spread forever over
them.
“We beached the ship, brought out
the sheep, and went
Along the stream until we reached
the place

Circe had named. Perimedes and
Eurylochus
Held fast the victims. I drew my
sword,
Dug a trench a cubit broad on every
side,
And poured libations to the dead:
first honey
And milk, then sweet wine, then
water; over all
I sprinkled white barley. I prayed to
the empty
Heads of the dead, promising that
when I reached
Ithaca I would sacrifice a barren
heifer,
The best I owned, in my halls, and
heap the pyre
With gifts for the dead; and to
Tiresias alone
I promised a black ram, the finest in
our flocks.
“When I had prayed to the tribes of
the dead,
I took the sheep and cut their throats
above
The trench. Dark blood ran, and the
souls came up
From Erebus: brides and youths,
long-suffering elders,
And tender girls whose hearts were
newly touched
By grief; many were wounded by
bronze spears,
Men fallen in battle, their armor red
with blood.
They gathered round the trench,
crying terribly;
Green fear took hold of me. I told my
friends

To flay the sheep, burn them as offerings to Hades
And dread Persephone, and pray; but I myself
Sat with the sharp sword drawn, and would not let
The unsubstantial dead draw near the blood
Until I had heard what Tiresias would say.”
“The first soul to approach was Elpenor’s,
My companion. He was not yet beneath
The earth’s wide roads; we had left his body in
Circe’s house, unwept and unburied, since
Another labor pressed upon us. I wept
When I saw him, and pitied him, and asked:
“Elpenor, how have you come beneath the misty
Darkness? Did you walk here, faster than I
Upon the black ship?”
“He groaned and answered: ‘Son of Laertes,
Much-devising Odysseus, an evil fate
And too much wine destroyed me. I lay asleep
In Circe’s house, and did not think to climb
Back down the long stairway; I fell headlong
From the roof. My neck was broken from the spine,
And my soul came down to Hades.

“Now I beg you, by those you left behind—
Your wife, your father, who raised you when you were
A child, and Telemachus, the only son
You left within your house—since I know that you
Will sail from here back toward Aeaea, where
Your well-built ship lies: remember me there.
Do not leave me unwept and unburied when
You sail away, lest I become the anger
Of the gods. Burn me with my armor, all
That belongs to me; raise a mound beside
The gray sea, for a man unhappy, so that
Those yet unborn may hear. Perform these things,
And fix my oar upon the tomb—the oar
With which I rowed beside my companions
When I was living.”
“I answered: ‘All these things, unhappy friend,
I will perform.’ We sat there, answering each
Other beside the trench, while I held back
My sword from the blood and he, a shadow, spoke.”
“The soul of Theban Tiresias came, bearing

His golden staff. He recognized me,
and said:
“Why have you left the light of the
sun, unlucky
Man, and come to see the dead and
this joyless
Place? Draw back from the trench,
keep your sword away,
That I may drink the blood and tell
you true.’
“I stepped back, sheathed the
silver-hilted sword.
When he had drunk the dark blood,
the blameless prophet
Spoke:
“You seek a honeyed homecoming,
famous man;
But a god will make it difficult. I do
not
Think Earth-Shaker will forget his
anger,
Because you blinded his dear son. Yet
you may
Still reach your home, though
suffering much, if you
Restrain your heart and that of your
companions
When first you draw near Thrinacia’s
island,
Escaping the violet sea. There you
will find
The cattle and rich sheep of the Sun,
who sees
And hears all things. If you leave
them unharmed,
And care for your return, you may
reach Ithaca,
Though suffering. But if you harm
them, I foretell

Destruction for your ship and
friends. Even if
You yourself escape, you will return
late,
In misery, having lost all your
companions,
Upon another man’s ship; and you
will find
Trouble within your house—men of
violence
Who consume your livelihood,
courting your
Godlike wife and offering wedding
gifts.
“When you have killed them, by
stealth or openly
With sharpened bronze, take up a
well-shaped oar
And go until you reach a people who
do not
Know the sea, nor eat food mixed
with sea-salt,
Nor know the red-cheeked ships or
well-shaped oars,
The wings of vessels. I will give you a
sign
So clear that it cannot escape you:
when
Another traveler meets you and says
you bear
A winnowing fan upon your shining
shoulder,
Plant your well-shaped oar in the
earth. Sacrifice
To lord Poseidon a ram, a bull, and a
boar,
And return home, making holy
hecatombs
To all the deathless gods who hold
the wide sky,

In order. From the sea itself death
will come
To you, a very gentle death, which
will take you
When rich old age has overcome you,
with your
People prosperous around you. All I
say
Is true.”
“So he spoke, and went back within
the house
Of Hades, when he had declared the
prophecy.
I remained where I was, until my
mother came,
And drank the dark blood. She knew
me at once.”
“She mourned, and called to me: ‘My
child, how have you
Come beneath the misty darkness,
living still?
It is hard for the living to see these
things.
Between us lie great rivers and
terrible streams,
Ocean first, which no one can cross
on foot,
Unless he has a well-built ship. Have
you now
Come wandering from Troy, after a
long time,
With ship and companions? Have
you not yet reached
Ithaca, nor seen your wife within
your house?’
“I answered: ‘Mother, necessity
brought me down
To Hades, to consult the Theban
Tiresias.

I have not yet drawn near the
Achaean land,
Nor set my foot upon it; I wander
still
In misery, since first I followed great
Agamemnon to horse-pastured
Ilium,
To fight the Trojans. But tell me
truly how
You died: a long disease, or did the
archer
Artemis strike you gently with her
arrows?
Tell me of father, and the son I left:
Do they still keep my honors, or does
another
Man possess them, while the
Achaeans say
I will not return? Tell me my wife’s
resolve:
Does she remain beside our son, and
keep
All things secure, or has some best
Achaean
Taken her?’
“My mother answered: ‘She remains
with patient heart
Within your house, her nights and
days consumed
By grief and tears. No man has taken
your honors;
Telemachus quietly manages your
estates,
And feasts as one should who judges
public suits.
Your father remains in the country,
and does not
Come to the city. He has no bed with
rugs,

Blankets, or shining coverlets; in
winter
He sleeps where the servants sleep,
upon the dust
Near the fire, wearing miserable
clothes.
But when summer and fruitful
autumn come,
Low beds of leaves are scattered
everywhere
Among the vineyard's sloping
ground; there he lies,
In grief, increasing the sorrow in his
heart,
Longing for your return, while
difficult old age
Comes upon him. I too died and met
my fate
Not by the archer's gentle arrows,
nor by
A wasting sickness that consumes
the limbs;
Your longing, your counsel, and your
gentle mind
Took the sweet life from me.'
"Three times I rushed to embrace my
mother's shade;
Three times it fluttered from my
hands like a shadow
Or dream, and the grief became
sharper within me.
I called: 'Mother, why do you not
remain,
So that, within Hades, we might
embrace and take
Our comfort in cold mourning? Has
great Persephone
Sent up this phantom, that I may
lament
Still more?"

"She answered: 'No; Persephone has
not deceived
You. Such is the law of mortals, when
they die.
The sinews no longer hold the flesh
and bones;
The fire's fierce strength destroys
them, once the spirit
Leaves the white bones; and the soul
flies away
Like a dream. Come quickly into the
light,
And remember all these things, so
that you may tell
Your wife when you return.'"
"While we spoke, the wives and
daughters of the best
Men came, summoned by
Persephone. I considered
How I might question each. The best
plan seemed
To draw the long sword from my
thigh, and not allow
Them all to drink the dark blood at
once. They came
In order, and each told me of her
birth; I asked
Every one.
"First I saw fair Tyro, who said she
was
The daughter of blameless
Salmoneus, and wife
Of Cretheus, son of Aeolus. She
loved
Enipeus, the most beautiful river; but
Poseidon, resembling the river, lay
with her
At its mouth, and a purple wave rose
around them.

He loosed her girdle, poured sleep
upon her, and said:
'Rejoice; bear splendid children, for
the beds
Of immortals are not fruitless. Raise
and rear them.
Now go home, and do not speak of
this. I am
Poseidon, Earth-Shaker.' She bore
Pelias and
Neleus, mighty servants of great
Zeus; Pelias
In broad Iolcus, rich in sheep, and
Neleus
In sandy Pylos. To Cretheus she bore
Aeson, Pheres, and horse-loving
Amythaon.
"After Tyro I saw Antiope, daughter
Of Asopus, who boasted that she had
slept
In Zeus' embrace; she bore Amphion
and Zethus,
Who first founded and towered
seven-gated Thebes.
Then Alcmene came, wife of
Amphitryon,
Who bore Heracles, lion-hearted,
after
Lying with great Zeus; and Megara,
daughter
Of mighty Creon, whom
Amphitryon's son
Took as his wife.
"Then I saw Epicaste, mother of
Oedipus,
Who in ignorance committed a great
deed:
She married her own son, who had
killed his father.

The gods soon made the truth
known among mankind.
He ruled in lovely Thebes through
grievous pain,
By the gods' dark counsels; but she
went to Hades,
Hanging herself from the high roof
in a noose,
Leaving her son the many griefs a
mother's
Furies bring.
"I saw Chloris, most beautiful, whom
Neleus
Married, paying countless bride-gifts
for her, the
Youngest daughter of Iasus' son
Amphion,
Who once ruled Orchomenus. She
ruled in Pylos,
And bore Nestor, Chromius, and
Periclymenus;
To them she bore Pero, a wonder
among men,
Whom all the neighbors sought, but
Neleus would not
Give her to any man who failed to
drive
The broad, twisting cattle from
Phylace—
The cattle hard to win, belonging to
Iphiclus.
Only the blameless seer Melampus
promised
To drive them; but a god's fate
bound him there,
With harsh bonds and rustic
herdsmen. When the months
And days completed the turning of
the year,

Strong Iphiclus released him, after he
had

Declared the prophecy; so Zeus' plan
was done.

"I saw Leda, wife of Tyndareus, who
bore

Castor, horse-tamer, and boxer
Polydeuces.

Though dead, the living earth holds
both; by Zeus' gift

They live one day and die the next,
and share

An honor equal to the gods. I saw
Iphimedeia,

Wife of Aloeus, who said she joined
Poseidon;

She bore Otus and famous Ephialtes,
Short-lived, the tallest and most
beautiful after

Orion. They were nine cubits broad,
nine fathoms

Tall, and threatened war against the
immortals.

They sought to pile Ossa on
Olympus, and

Pelion on Ossa, that they might
climb the sky;

They would have done it, had they
reached their youth's

Full measure, but the son of Leto
killed them both

Before their cheeks grew thick with
beard.

"I saw Phaedra and Procris, and
beautiful

Ariadne, daughter of Minos, whom
Theseus

Once led from Crete toward Athens;
but Artemis

Killed her in Dia, with Dionysus as
witness.

I saw Maera and Clymene, and
hateful

Eriphyle, who took the precious gold
For the life of her own husband. I
cannot

Name and tell every wife and
daughter I saw;

The immortal night would end
before I finished.

Now it is time to sleep, whether I
return

To the ship and companions, or
remain here.

Your escort and the gods will care
for the rest."

"So I spoke; and all the people
became silent,

Held by enchantment in the
shadowed hall.

White-armed Arete began among
them:

"Phaeacians, how does this man
appear to you,

In stature, beauty, and the mind
within?

He is my guest, and each of you has a
share

In his honor. Do not send him
hurriedly

Away, nor cut short the gifts he
needs; within

Your houses many treasures lie by
heaven's will.'

"Old Echeneus agreed, and said her
word

Was wise; Alcinous held both deed
and speech.

The king promised: 'So shall it be, if I

Remain alive to rule the oar-loving
people.
Let our guest bear his longing until
dawn,
Until I have completed every gift; the
escort
Will be the care of all, and most of
mine.'
"I answered: 'Alcinous, most
renowned,
Even if you commanded me to stay a
year,
Providing escort and giving splendid
gifts,
I would desire it; it would be better
far
To reach my native land with fuller
hands,
And I should be more honored when
I came
Before my people and my household.'
"The king answered that he did not
take me for
A deceiver or a thief, as many men
Scatter lies across the earth; my
words had form,
And a good mind was in them. I had
told my griefs
As carefully as a singer might tell
them.
'But tell me now,' he said, 'which of
your godlike
Companions did you see, those who
went with you
To Ilium and shared its fate? The
night is long;
There is no time for sleep. Tell your
wondrous deeds;
I could endure until the sacred dawn,

If you would tell the sorrows of your
friends,
Those who escaped the Trojan cry
yet later died
By the wicked will of a woman.'
"I answered: 'There is a season for
long speech,
And there is also a season for sleep. If
still
You wish to listen, I can tell more
grievous
Sorrows, the fate of friends who later
died.'
"When Persephone had scattered the
women's souls,
The soul of Agamemnon came,
grieving, with
The other men who died with him in
the house
Of Aegisthus. When he had drunk
the dark blood,
He knew me, wept loudly, stretched
his hands toward me;
But he no longer had the strength or
vigor
That once had filled his bent limbs. I
wept to see him,
And asked:
"Agamemnon, lord of men, what
death overcame
You? Did Poseidon kill you on the
ships,
Raising a storm of winds that cannot
be endured?
Or did hostile men destroy you on
the land,
While you were cutting oxen and
beautiful sheep,
Or fighting near a city for its
women?"

“He answered: ‘Son of Laertes, no
storm at sea
Destroyed me, nor did hostile men
upon
The land. Aegisthus made my death
and fate:
He called me home, gave me a feast,
and killed me
With my accursed wife, as one kills
an ox
Beside the manger. Thus I died most
pitifully;
My comrades died around me
without rest,
Like white-tusked swine slaughtered
at the feast
Of some rich, powerful man, for
marriage, banquet,
Or public celebration. You have seen
many
Men fall in battle, one by one, but
most
Your heart would pity the sight we
saw: around
The mixing-bowl and laden tables
we lay,
And all the floor ran red with blood.
Most pitiful
Of all I heard Cassandra’s cry,
Priam’s daughter,
Whom Clytemnestra killed beside
me. I reached
My hands from where I died, but the
dog-faced woman
Turned away and would not close my
eyes or mouth
As I descended to the house of
Hades.
“There is nothing more terrible and
shameless than

A woman who devises such a
deed—who makes
The murder of her wedded husband.
I had thought
I should be welcomed by my children
and servants
When I returned home; but she
poured shame upon
Herself and future women.’
“I answered: ‘How Zeus, whose sight
is wide, has hated
The house of Atreus through
women’s counsels!
For Helen’s sake many of us died,
and for
Your sake Clytemnestra wove deceit
afar.’
“He warned me never to be wholly
open with
My wife, but to speak some things
and hide the rest.
Yet he said no woman would kill me:
Penelope,
Daughter of Icarius, is wise and
deeply minded.
She was a young bride when we went
to war,
Leaving an infant son at her breast;
he now
Must sit among men. Her husband
will see him,
And the son embrace his father, as is
right.
But his wife did not allow him to see
his son
Or fill his eyes with joy before she
killed him.
“He asked me whether Orestes still
lived at Orchomenus,

Sandy Pylos, or broad Sparta. I did not know,
And said it was vain to speak what I could not tell.”
“We stood there grieving; then the soul of Peleus’ son
Achilles came, with Patroclus, blameless Antilochus,
And Ajax, finest in form and stature after
The great son of Peleus. Swift-footed Achilles
Recognized me, and asked:
“Son of Laertes, why have you dared a deed
Greater than this? How could you come to Hades,
Where the dead dwell without understanding,
Mere images of mortals who have finished?”
“I answered: ‘I came to ask Tiresias how
I might reach rocky Ithaca. I have not
Yet reached Achaea, nor set foot upon my land;
I have had trouble always. But no man, Achilles,
Was more blessed than you: while living, all the Argives
Honored you as a god; and now you rule
The dead. Do not grieve, even in death.’
“He answered: ‘Do not speak lightly of death,
Renowned Odysseus. I would rather serve

Another man, a poor one, with little wealth,
Than rule all the dead who have perished. Tell me
Of my noble son: did he go to war among
The foremost, or did he remain? Tell me of
Peleus: does he still hold honor among the
Myrmidons in Phthia, or do men dishonor him,
Since old age binds his hands and feet? I cannot
Help him beneath the sun as I once did in Troy,
When I killed the best of men in defense
Of Argos. If I could go for even a moment
To my father’s house, I would make those men
Fear my strength who deprive him of his honor.’
“I answered that I knew nothing of Peleus,
But would tell all I knew of his son Neoptolemus.
I myself brought him from Scyros in the hollow ship.
In council before Troy he was always first
To speak, and did not miss the mark; Nestor and I
Alone surpassed him. In battle he never stayed
Among the crowd, but ran far ahead, yielding
To no man, and killed many in the dreadful fight.

I cannot name all he killed, but he
struck down
Eurypylus, Telephus' son, the finest
man
I saw beside divine Memnon. When
we entered
The horse Epeius built, and I was
charged to set
The hidden company within, the
other leaders
Wiped tears and trembled; but I
never saw
Neoptolemus grow pale, wipe tears
from his cheeks,
Or beg to leave. He grasped his
sword and heavy spear,
Longing for harm to come to the
Trojans. When Troy
Was sacked, he went aboard with his
share and honor,
Unwounded, untouched by spear or
close combat."
"Achilles' soul strode joyfully away
Across the asphodel meadow, glad
that I had told
Him of his son. The other souls stood
grieving,
Asking each about their sorrows.
Ajax alone
Stood apart, still angered over the
arms of Achilles,
Which I won in judgment beside the
ships. The sons
Of the Trojans judged, and Athena.
Would that I
Had never won that contest for such
a head
The earth now held—Ajax, beyond
all the Danaans

In form and deeds after the son of
Peleus!
I spoke to him with gentle words:
"Ajax, son of blameless Telamon,
will you not
Forget your anger over those
accursed arms,
Which the gods made a grief to the
Argives? We grieve
For you as for Achilles; no one else is
to blame;
Zeus hated the spear-bearing host,
and placed upon
You a fate so bitter. Come, lord, hear
my words.'
"He would not answer; he went
among the other
Souls. There he might have spoken,
or I to him,
But my heart still desired to see
other dead."
"I saw Minos, glorious son of Zeus,
holding
A golden scepter, giving judgments
to the dead.
They stood or sat around him in the
wide gates
Of Hades, asking justice from the
king. Then I
Saw huge Orion driving the beasts he
killed
Across the asphodel meadow,
holding a club
Of bronze that never breaks. I saw
Tityus,
Son of the glorious Earth, stretched
nine plethra wide;
Two vultures tore his liver, entering
deep beneath

The skin, and he could not drive
them off. He had
Dragged Leto, glorious consort of
Zeus, when she
Went toward Panopeus through its
lovely dancing-place.
“I saw Tantalus in terrible pain,
standing
In a lake whose water rose against his
chin.
He thirsted, but could not take a
drink: whenever
He bent toward the water, it
vanished, and black
Earth appeared around his feet. Tall
trees bent fruit
Above his head—pear, apple,
pomegranate, olive,
And sweet fig—but whenever the old
man stretched
His hands to seize them, a wind
threw them toward
The shadowed clouds. I saw
Sisyphus, enduring
The greatest labor, pushing a
monstrous stone
With both hands toward the hill.
When it was about
To pass the crest, its weight turned it
back; again
It rolled to the plain. Again he
strained, sweat
Running from his limbs, dust rising
from his head.
“After him came the phantom of
Heracles—his image;
The man himself delights among the
deathless gods
With Hebe, lovely-ankled daughter
of Zeus

And Hera of the golden sandals.
Around his shade
The dead cried like birds scattering
before a hawk.
He held his bow, an arrow fitted, and
gazed
Terribly, as one forever ready to
shoot.
His golden baldric bore wondrous
scenes: bears,
Wild boars, lions, battles, wars, and
killings,
Worked by a craftsman’s art no man
could match.
“He knew me, and spoke in sorrow:
‘Son of Laertes,
Are you too driven by some evil
destiny,
As I was beneath the sunlight? I was
Zeus’ son,
Yet suffered without measure, bound
to a man
Far worse than I, who gave me
painful tasks.
He sent me here to fetch the hound;
he thought
No harder labor could be set. I
brought the dog
Up from Hades, with Hermes and
bright-eyed Athena
As my guides.’
“He went back into Hades’ house. I
remained,
Hoping to see Theseus and
Peirithous, children
Of glorious gods. But before I could,
countless
Dead gathered with a supernatural
cry; green fear

Seized me, lest Persephone send the
Gorgon's head
Up from Hades. I returned to the
ship, ordered
My companions aboard, and told
them to loose
The stern-ropes. They climbed
quickly, sat at the oars,
And the current carried us down
Ocean: first by rowing,
Then with a fair following wind.”

Source range: Book 11. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 12

First-pass working translation

When the ship had left the stream of
Ocean

And came again to Aeaea, where the
Dawn

Is born, and where the Sun's bright
risings are,

We drew her up upon the sand, and
went

Ourselves along the surf. We took
ashore

The body of Elpenor. His
companions

Cut timber, and beside the furthest
beach

We burned him with his armor,
mourning him.

We raised a mound upon the
projecting shore,

And set his oar upon it, as he asked.

While we were there, Circe came
swiftly, bringing

The food and wine that mortals eat.
She stood

Among us and spoke:

"Unhappy men, who have gone living
beneath

The house of Hades, twice dead,
while other men

Die only once. Come, eat the food
before you,

And drink the wine through all this
day. At dawn

You will sail again across the salt
water.

I will tell you the road, and show
each danger,

That no hidden grief may come upon
you at sea

Or on the land."

We ate and drank beside the ship
until

The sun went down. When darkness
came, we slept

Beside the stern-ropes. At early
Dawn

The lovely-haired goddess drew me
aside,

And spoke, while all my companions
gathered near.

"You have come back from Hades,
though alive;

The others die once, but you have
died and seen

The dead. Hear now what waits
before you. First

The Sirens: they bewitch all mortal
men

Who come to them. Whoever draws
near, and hears

The Sirens' voice, has no welcome
from his wife

Or children when he returns; the
Sirens hold him

With their clear song upon the
meadow, and around

Them lie a heap of bones of human
men,

Their flesh already wasting from the
bones.

"Sail past them. Stop the ears of all
your men

With honey softened wax. Let no one
hear.

But if you wish to hear the song
yourself,

Have them bind you upright within
the mast,
With ropes fastened against it. Let
them bind
Your hands and feet; and if you beg
or order
Them to release you, let them bind
you tighter.
When they have passed beyond the
Sirens' shore,
Your men may loosen you and take
the wax away.
"I will not tell you which road you
should choose.
You must consider within your own
heart.
One road has the Wandering Rocks:
no ship escapes
Them, not even doves that carry
ambrosia
To Father Zeus; the smooth rocks
seize one bird,
And the father sends another to
replace it.
No ship has passed them, but one
only, Argo,
Known to all men, sailing from
Aeetes' shore;
And even her the waves would have
dashed against
The rocks, if Hera had not sent her
past in love
For Jason.
"On the other road are two cliffs.
One rises
Into the broad sky; a dark cloud
crowns its top
And never parts, even in summer. No
mortal

Could climb it, nor stand upon it,
though he had
Twenty hands and feet; it is smooth,
sheer, and hard.
Halfway up the rock is a shadowed
cave
Facing the west, toward Erebus. You
must steer
The ship past there. Even a young
archer could
Not shoot from the ship to reach
that hollow cave.
"Within it dwells Scylla, terribly
barking.
Her voice is small, like a newborn
puppy's cry,
Yet she is an evil monster, and no
one
Would look upon her gladly, not
even a god.
She has twelve feet, all hidden; six
long necks
Rise from her body, each with a
dreadful head,
And in each mouth are three rows of
teeth,
Many and close, full of black death.
Half her body
Is hidden in the cave; her heads
project
Beyond the fearful rock, and there
she fishes
Around the cliff, feeling for
dolphins, dogs,
And any greater beast the roaring sea
may bring.
No ship can pass her safely; each
head takes
One man from every ship, six men in
all.

“The other cliff lies lower; you will
see it,
Odysseus, as near as an arrow’s cast.
Within
Is Charybdis, who swallows the sea’s
dark water
Three times a day, and three times
sends it out
Again, terribly. When she swallows,
not even
Earth-Shaker could save you. Steer
Scylla’s side
And row beyond her swiftly; it is far
better
To lose six men from the ship than
all at once.”
“Beyond lies Thrinacia, the Sun’s
island.
There are his cattle, and his
strong-fleeced sheep,
Seven herds of cattle, seven flocks of
sheep,
Fifty in every herd and flock. They
do not breed,
Nor do they die; two goddesses care
for them,
Lampetia and Phaethusa, whom the
bright
Sun bore to Neaera. Their mother
reared
Them; then she sent them to
Thrinacia, far
Away, to guard their father’s sheep
and cattle.
“If you leave these herds unharmed,
and think
Of your return, you may yet reach
Ithaca,
Though suffering much. But if you
harm them, I

Foretell destruction for your ship
and friends.
If you yourself escape, you will
return late,
After losing all your companions,
and in a ship
That is not yours.”
So speaking, she went beneath the
island’s trees,
And I returned to where the ship
and friends
Were waiting. We made ready; she
sent a wind
That filled the sail and followed us.
We raised
The mast and sail, sat down, and let
the wind
And helmsman take the course. I
told the men:
“Friends, it is not right that one or
two alone
Should know the prophecies Circe
spoke to me.
I will tell all, so that we may know
the danger,
And either die together or escape it.
“First she warned us of the Sirens’
song. She said
Only Odysseus should hear it; the
rest
Must row past with stopped ears.
Bind me upright
Within the mast, and if I beg release,
Bind me with more and stronger
cords.”
I told them this, but did not speak of
Scylla,
Because Circe had said that no one
could avoid

The loss of six. Had I named that
grief, the men
Would have stopped rowing and
gone below the benches.
Then Circe's wind ceased. A
breathless calm came on;
The companions furled the sail,
lowered it into
The ship, and took the oars within
their hands.
I cut a great wheel of wax, and
kneaded it
Beneath the sun's fierce rays, until it
softened.
My men went in their turns; I
fastened wax
Within each ear. They bound me
hand and foot,
Upright against the mast, and tied
the ropes
To it. Then sitting in their order,
they struck
The gray sea with the oars.
When we were as far away as a man's
shout
Can carry, the swift ship did not
escape
The Sirens' sight; they raised their
clear song:
"Come here, much-praised Odysseus,
great glory
Of the Achaeans. Stop the ship, and
hear our voice.
No one has ever sailed this way in his
black ship
Before he heard the honeyed song
that comes
From our mouths; he rejoices, and
goes onward wiser.

We know all that the Argives and the
Trojans
Suffered in wide Troy by the gods'
will; we know
All things that happen upon the
fruitful earth."
They sang with a beautiful voice. My
heart wished
To hear them; I commanded my men
with my brows
To release me, but they bent harder
to the oars.
Perimedes and Eurylochos rose,
And bound me with more cords, as I
had ordered.
When we had gone beyond the
Sirens' hearing,
And their voice and song had faded,
my companions
Removed the wax and loosened all
my bonds.
When we had left that island, smoke
and a great
Sea-roar came toward us. The men
lost their oars;
The oars fell from their hands, and
the ship stood still.
I went among them, urging every
man:
"Friends, we are not unacquainted
with disasters.
This danger is no greater than when
the Cyclops
Held us within his cave; we escaped
him through
My counsel and my mind. I think we
shall remember
Even this with gratitude. Row, as I
command.

Lean hard upon the oars, and Zeus
may grant us
Escape from death. Steersman,
remember what I say:
Keep the ship clear of smoke and
breakers; steer
Toward the cliff. Do not let the ship
drift there
And carry us into the greater
danger.”
I did not tell them of Scylla, the
misery
That no one could prevent, lest in
their fear
They stop rowing and hide beneath
the benches.
Then I forgot Circe’s strict
command, and armed
Myself in shining bronze, took two
long spears,
And stood upon the deck at the
prow, expecting
Scylla to show herself, who brought
my friends
Away from the ship. But I could not
see her;
My eyes grew tired from watching
the misty rock.
On one side Scylla, on the other
Charybdis,
Terribly sucked the sea’s salt water
down.
When she vomited it up, as a
cauldron boils
Over a great fire, the whole sea
seethed and roared;
The foam flew upward, and the rock
around
Was crowned with it. When she
swallowed back the sea,

The water boiled as if a cauldron
shook;
The rock groaned, and the earth
thundered beneath.
Pale fear took hold of the men.
Scylla seized six of my companions
from the ship,
The strongest and most capable
among them.
I saw their hands and feet already
lifted,
Struggling, calling me, calling me by
name,
For the last time, in anguish. No
more terrible
Sight have I seen in all my travels on
the sea.”
We escaped the rocks and the sea’s
dreadful mouth,
And soon reached the Sun’s beautiful
island.
There we heard the lowing of the
broad-faced cattle,
And the bleating sheep. Then I
remembered
The warning of Tiresias of Thebes,
and Circe
Of Aeaëa, who had charged me again
and again
To avoid the island of the Sun. I
spoke:
“Friends, though you are grieving,
listen. I will tell
What Tiresias and Circe prophesied:
We must sail past Thrinacia, the
Sun’s island,
And leave his beautiful herds alone.
If we harm
Them, I foretell evil for every man.”
Eurylochus answered, angry:

“You are hard, Odysseus; your strength never tires.
You yourself are made of iron, since you forbid
The men, wearied by rowing and by hunger,
To go ashore and sleep. The night will come;
It is not right to stay away from the ship
And wander on the sea. If the gods raise a storm,
Where shall we flee? Better to come ashore,
Prepare a meal, and pray beside the ship.
At dawn we will launch and cross the open water.
If the immortals destroy us, let it be at once;
Better than wasting slowly on the island,
Far from the ship, with hunger as our death.”
So he spoke; and all the companions agreed.
I knew that some god was planning evil for us.
I answered: “Since you force me, swear an oath:
If you find a herd of cattle or a flock
Of sheep, let no one kill an ox or sheep
In reckless hunger. Eat the food Circe gave us,
And leave the herds unharmed.”
They swore as I
Commanded, and moored the ship within a bay

Beside a fresh spring. They prepared a meal.
When hunger and thirst were satisfied, they mourned
The companions Scylla had taken from the ship.
At sunset they slept beside the breaking sea.
At dawn the gods sent winds that held us there;
The East and South Winds blew, then the West Wind,
And the South Wind rose again. For a month they kept
The ships from sailing. While the provisions lasted,
The men ate bread and wine from Circe's stores.
When these were gone, they hunted birds and fish
With hooks, driven by hunger, through the island.
I went inland, seeking a place of prayer,
That I might ask the gods to show a way out.
When I had gone beyond the companions' sight,
I washed my hands in a sheltered place and prayed;
But sweet sleep fell upon my eyes.
Eurylochus
Addressed the companions:
“Listen, though you suffer. Death is hateful in
Every form, but hunger is the most miserable.
Come, let us drive the finest cattle from the herd,

And sacrifice them to the gods who
hold the sky.
If we ever reach Ithaca, we will build
A temple to the Sun, and fill it with
gifts.
But if, angered over his cattle, he
decides
To wreck the ship, and the other
gods agree,
I would rather die once beneath the
wave
Than waste away upon this desolate
island.”
So spoke Eurylochus; and the men
drove out
The finest cattle nearest to them.
They stood
Around them, broad-faced and with
shining horns.
They prayed, using leaves of the tall
oak, for no
White barley remained beside the
ship. They cut
The throats of the cattle, flayed
them, and divided
The flesh. They covered the thighs in
fat, in folds,
And laid raw meat upon them. They
had no wine
For the libation, so they poured
water on
The shining offering. They roasted
all the inward
Parts, and set them on spits.
Then the sweet sleep left me, and I
went down
Toward the ship and shore. When I
came near the bay,
The sea’s broad shores, the sweet
smoke of the fat

Came toward me. I cried out, and
lifted my hands:
“Father Zeus, and all you blessed
deathless gods,
You have put sleep upon me in my
ruin,
That my companions might devise
this evil.
Now Lampetia, the Sun’s long-robed
daughter,
Went swiftly to her father and told
him:
‘They have killed your cattle, whom
you are always
Glad to see, whenever you climb the
starry sky,
And whenever you turn down again
from heaven.’
“The Sun spoke among the immortal
gods:
‘Father Zeus, and all you blessed
deathless gods,
Take vengeance on the companions
of Odysseus,
Laertes’ son. In reckless violence they
killed
My cattle, whose sight delighted me
whenever
I rose toward heaven or turned
toward earth again.
If they do not pay the fitting price, I
will
Go down to Hades and shine among
the dead.’
“Then Zeus, cloud-gatherer,
answered him:
‘Sun, shine among the deathless gods
and mortal men
Upon the fruitful earth. I will strike
their ship

With a bright thunderbolt in the
open sea.”
So I spoke, but the companions went
on with the feast.
For six days they ate the finest cattle
that had
Been driven out. On the seventh,
when hunger
Had loosened its hold, we went
aboard the ship,
Raised mast and sail, and sailed from
the island.
When Thrinacia was no longer near,
and no other
Land appeared, only sea and sky,
Zeus placed
A dark cloud above the hollow ship.
The sea grew
Black beneath it. We did not go far.
The West Wind
Came suddenly, and the ship’s
shrouds shrieked;
The mast snapped back, and its
tackle fell astern.
The mast struck the steersman,
crushed his skull,
And he fell like a diver from the
deck.
Then Zeus hurled thunder, lightning,
and the bolt;
It struck the ship, and she spun
around. Sulfur
Filled the air. All my companions fell
from the ship.
They looked like gulls around a black
ship, and a god
Denied them the return. I walked the
deck until
The ship broke apart; keel and mast
tore loose.

The mast, still joined to the keel, was
bound to it
By a rawhide thong. I sat astride
them both,
And the storm carried me.
“For a night and day I was carried; at
sunset
On the second day I reached the
rocks once more,
Scylla and Charybdis. She swallowed
the salt sea.
I was lifted by the wave and clung to
a fig tree
That grew above the whirlpool,
holding fast like
A bat. I could not plant my feet or
climb;
The roots were far below, and the
branches high
And broad, casting their shade over
Charybdis.
“I waited until she vomited the mast
and keel
Again; she threw them out like a
man who has eaten
And vomits food, while the timber
fell from above.
When they appeared, I dropped from
the tree, feet first,
And fell into the sea far from the
timbers.
I sat upon them, rowed with my
hands, and was
Carried away from the rocks. The
father of the gods
Did not allow Scylla to see me; I
could not
Have escaped the steep death.
“From there, for nine days, I drifted;
on the tenth

Night the gods carried me to Ogygia,
where
Calypso of the beautiful hair dwells,
a terrible
Goddess with a human voice. She
received me,
Loved and cared for me. Why tell
you these things?
Yesterday I told them in your house,
to you
And to your noble wife; I hate to
repeat
The tale so plainly, when once it has
been told.”

Source range: Book 12. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 13

First-pass working translation

When the great house had grown
still, and all the people
Sat silent, listening, Alcinous spoke:
“The garments, gold, and all the gifts
already
Lie in the polished chest; yet let us
add
A great tripod and a cauldron for the
stranger;
And we, in common, will repay the
cost. It is hard
For one man alone to bear so large a
burden.”
Thus he spoke; and the men brought
up the gifts,
And set them in the hall, beneath the
portico,
Where the strong servants of the
king might guard them.
All praised the counsel, and
approved the sending;
The gifts were counted, and the feast
prepared.
And all the house rejoiced.
Then each man went to sleep within
his house.
At dawn they went down to the sea,
and brought
The bronze aboard. The lord of the
Phaeacians
Placed all in the ship beneath the
benches,
That nothing should hinder the
oarsmen's work.
Then Alcinous held a feast.
Demodocus,

The heaven-taught singer, came
among them; and Odysseus,
Honored by all the people, sang
among the guests;
The roasted thighs burned sweetly
on the altar,
And every heart was gladdened by
the song.
Turning continually toward the
westerling light,
Longed for the sun to sink. As one
who waits
For supper waits for the oxen's
return from the plough,
So welcome was the darkness to his
heart.
At last he stood and said: “King
Alcinous,
Pour out the wine, and give me leave
to go.
You have sent me on my way with
gracious gifts;
May the gods make them a joy
within my house.
May I find there my wife and friends
unharméd;
And you, remaining here, delight
your wives
And children, with no sorrow
entering in.”
The king poured wine, and lifted up
the cup:
“Farewell, stranger; and when you
reach your country,
Remember us. You are not to forget
That we have sent you home.”
Before he crossed the threshold,
Odysseus gave
The two-handled cup into Arete's
hands:

“Farewell, O queen; may age and
death find you
In peace, as all things mortal must. I
go;
Remain in joy among your children,
people,
And Alcinous, your king.” Then
through the doors
He passed, and the herald went
before him,
To show the path toward the swift
ship and sea.
The herald then carried bread and
meat down to the ship;
A bed
Was spread for Odysseus beneath the
stern;
He climbed aboard, and the rowers
sat in order.
Alcinous poured dark wine, and
prayed to Zeus;
The oars dipped, and the ship went
out like a chariot
Running across a wide plain.
All night he lay in sleep, while the
ship flew onward,
Swift as a hawk, the swiftest of all
winged things.
No pilot held the helm; no steersman
watched;
The ship herself knew the road
appointed her.
The rowers leaned upon their oars in
order,
And sleep, most sweet, most like the
sleep of death,
Lay on the eyes of him who had
endured
So many wars of men and waves at
sea.

At the first light she reached Ithaca,
The harbor called Phorcys, ancient
lord of the sea.
Two headlands shelter it; their
broken shoulders
Run outward and receive the long
waves, and within
The great swells sleep. No ship,
unless moored,
Need fear the wind that rises from
the deep.
At the harbor's head a sacred olive
stands;
Near it a pleasant cave, the holy
place
Of nymphs called Naiads. There are
mixing-bowls
And jars of stone, and bees make
honey there.
Long stone looms stand in its
shadow, where
The nymphs weave robes of purple as
the sea.
Two doors descend into the cave: the
northern
Is open to mortals; the southern is
sacred,
And through it men may not pass.
The Phaeacians drew up the ship
upon the strand.
She ran half her length upon the
land,
So eagerly the rowers drove her keel
ashore.
They lifted sleeping Odysseus from
the stern
And laid him gently on the sand,
with all
The gifts which great-hearted
Athena had won for him

From the Phaeacian lords. They
placed them by
The olive's roots, a little beyond the
road,
Lest some wayfarer, before Odysseus
woke,
Should rob him. Then they turned
back toward home.
But Poseidon, shaker of the earth,
did not forget.
He came from Aegae to the halls of
Zeus and said:
"Father, shall I be held without
honor among gods,
When mortal men despise me? The
Phaeacians,
My own kindred, have no fear; they
carry everyone
Across the sea, though I have said
that Odysseus
Would return from Troy through
many sufferings.
Now they have brought him home,
and given him gifts,
And he has seen his country. They
will make
Their ships a road for all men, and
the sea
Will no longer be dark with awe."
Cloud-gathering Zeus answered:
"Strike when the ship
Comes near their land. Let all behold
the marvel:
Turn her to stone, there by the city,
so that they
May cease from escorting men. And
make a mountain
Stand before their harbor, if the old
prophecy
Is ever to be fulfilled."

Poseidon went down to Scheria.
There he waited;
When the swift ship drew near, he
struck it with his hand,
And it became a stone, rooted
beneath the water.
The stone grew from the keel, and
stood close by,
So that the Phaeacians saw it and
were afraid.
They gazed at one another, speaking
winged words:
"What power has checked our ship
upon the sea,
Though homeward bound she
hastened?" None of them
Knew yet what hand had wrought
the wonder there.
Alcinous remembered the word his
father once had spoken:
"The day will come when the
Earth-shaker shall hide
Our beautiful ship beneath a
mountain." He called
The people to assembly, and said:
"Let us sacrifice
Twelve bulls to Poseidon, lest he
cover our city
With stone." They brought the bulls
and offered them;
And from that day the Phaeacians no
longer sent
Ships forth to guide men over the
open sea.
Then Odysseus woke upon his native
ground.
But Athena had poured a mist
around him,
So that he could not know the land
he loved.

The goddess wished to counsel him
first, and keep
His wife and all the townsmen from
discovering him.
He rose and looked upon the shore.
“Alas!” he cried,
“What land is this? Where am I
carried? Have the men
Of Phaeacia deceived me? They
promised to send me home,
Yet here I stand in a strange country.
May Zeus
Punish them, if they have scattered
my possessions
And left me wandering! Let me
count the gifts.”
He counted the bronze, the gold, and
the woven garments;
Nothing was missing. Yet he
mourned beside the sea,
And walked along the beach,
thinking what to do.
He beat his thighs with both hands
and cried aloud:
“What men are these whose land has
taken me?
Are they unjust and savage, or kind
to strangers,
And reverent toward the gods?
Where shall I carry
These riches? Where shall I myself
wander now?
Would I had stayed among the
Phaeacians!
Some other generous king might
then have sent me
To my own country. Yet I cannot
leave
These treasures here, lest others
make them spoil.”

Athena came toward him, in the
likeness of a young man,
A shepherd, handsome and tall, his
cloak folded
Across his shoulders, his spear held
in his hand.
Odysseus saw him and went to meet
him:
“Friend, since you are the first I find
in this country,
Tell me its name. What people dwell
here? Is it
An island, or a mainland's shore? My
companions
Have set me down asleep, and I do
not know
Where I have come.”
Athena answered: “You are foolish,
stranger,
Or you have come from far away, not
to know Ithaca.
It is rough, and not fit for horses; but
it is not
Poor or without harvest. Wine grows
there in abundance;
Rain falls often, and the dew lies
heavy.
It is good for goats and cattle, and its
woods
Are watered by springs. Its fame has
reached as far
As Troy, though Troy lies beyond
the sea.”
Odysseus answered: “I knew Ithaca's
name;
I would not speak it, for I fled from
Crete
After I killed Orsilochus, the son
Of Idomeneus. He sought to take
from me

The Trojan spoil I had won with toil.
I hid among Phoenician sailors,
asking
To be carried to Pylos or to Elis.
They swore an oath, but storms
drove them beyond
Their course; and while I slept, they
left me here.
Beside me they laid gifts from Egypt,
Sidon,
And Phoenicia, then sailed away,
Leaving me without a meal.”
Athena smiled, and touched him.
Suddenly she was
No shepherd, but a tall and beautiful
woman,
Her eyes bright as a goddess' eyes.
“No other man,”
She said, “could be wiser in a time of
danger.
You would not end your cunning
even in your country.
I am Athena, who have stood beside
you always,
Who kept your strength alive at
Troy. I have hidden you
From the Phaeacians; and now I
come to plan
The end of all your troubles. You
must endure
In silence, and reveal yourself to no
one.”
No god or man could pass you in all
arts
Of guile; and even here, upon your
native soil,
You cannot lay your many tales
aside.
I could not leave you, though your
road was dark:

I made the Phaeacians love you and
receive you,
And now I weave our counsel for the
end.
“I did not wish to leave you long,” she
continued,
“But first I will show you Ithaca.” She
lifted
The mist. Odysseus knew the harbor,
the olive tree,
The cave, and Neriton's wooded
mountain. He fell
Upon his knees and prayed to the
Naiad nymphs:
“I did not think that I should see you
again.
Receive my prayer; for by the will of
Zeus
I have returned.”
Athena and Odysseus carried the
gifts into the cave:
Gold, bronze, and garments folded
in the dark.
Athena rolled a great stone before
the door,
Then spoke of the suitors. “They
consume your house;
For three years they have ruled it,
seeking Penelope.
She gives each man some hope,
though her heart rejects them;
She sends messages to all, and each
believes himself chosen.
You must think how they shall meet
their death.”
Odysseus answered: “I should have
fallen by their hands,
Had you not spoken. Stand beside
me as at Troy;

Then I could fight three hundred
men, if only
Your heart would help me.”
“But why,” he asked, “did you not tell
me sooner?
You knew all things. Was it that I
might wander,
And suffer on the barren sea, while
others fed
Upon my goods? I have not ceased to
hope
That I should yet come home, though
every comrade
Was lost. I feared Poseidon’s ancient
anger,
And therefore you withheld your
hand from me.
Yet now, if you will stand as once at
Troy,
I could withstand three hundred
men in battle.”
Athena said: “I will stand with you;
and when the hour
Comes, I shall not be hidden. But
first I must make
You unrecognizable to every mortal
eye.”
“Another man,” she said, “would
hurry first
To see his wife and children after
wandering;
But you desire to test her in the
house,
Who sits through nights and days in
grief and tears.
I knew you would return, though I
would not contend
With Poseidon, your father’s brother,
whose heart

Was angered when you blinded his
dear son.”
She touched him with her wand. His
skin shrank and withered;
The dark hair fell from his head. The
flesh grew old,
The eyes were circled deep with age.
She clothed him
In a torn, smoke-stained tunic, foul
with weather;
She cast around his shoulders a great
deer’s hide,
Worn thin and ragged. She gave him
a staff and a patched
And filthy bag, its strap twisted and
broken.
Thus he would seem a wretched
thing to all who saw him—
To the suitors, his wife, and the son
he left
Within the house—unlike the king
he was.
“Go first,” she said, “to the swineherd
Eumaeus.
He guards your swine and knows a
gentle heart;
He loves your son and prudent
Penelope.
He keeps the herd beside the Raven
Rock,
Near Arethusa’s spring, where acorns
grow
For the fat pigs, and black water
gives them drink—
A rich, dark pasture for the swine to
feed in.
Sit there, and ask him how the house
is faring.
I go to Lacedaemon, to summon your
son.

“Telemachus went there to ask
Menelaus
For tidings of your fame. He suffers
nothing:
He sits in peace within the house of
Atreus,
And countless treasures lie around
him there.
But young men lie in wait upon the
sea-road,
Desiring to kill him before he
reaches home.”
She touched him once again. The
change was complete:
Odysseus stood as an old beggar,
bent and weathered.
Then the goddess crossed the island,
and went on
To Lacedaemon, to bring the son of
Odysseus home.

Source range: Book 13. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Odysseus newly landed at Ithaca as Athena reveals the veiled harbor

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Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 14

First-pass working translation

From the harbor Odysseus climbed
the rough path,
Through the wood and over the
heights where Athena
Had shown him the faithful
swineherd's dwelling—
The man who most of all the
household servants
Kept watch for the wealth that
godlike Odysseus won.
There he found Eumaeus sitting in
the forecourt.
The yard was high and broad, in a
sheltered place;
The swineherd had built it while his
master wandered,
Far from the queen and old Laertes,
his father.
With stones he fenced it, and with
thornwood set
The outer stakes in close and
crowded rows.
Within he had made twelve sties,
side by side,
For the mother-sows, and in each
fifty lay,
While the boars slept outside. They
were fewer by far:
The godlike suitors ate them, always
ordering
The swineherd to send them the
fattest of all.
Three hundred sixty boars remained.
Beside them
Four dogs, like wild beasts, slept, and
Eumaeus,

Leader of men, was cutting leather
for his sandals.
Three servants had gone out with the
herds of swine;
The fourth had been driven toward
the city,
To bring a boar for the arrogant
suitors,
That they might sacrifice it and
satisfy their hunger.
The dogs saw Odysseus suddenly.
They barked
And rushed at him. The hero, skilled
in counsel,
Sat down, and let his staff fall from
his hand.
There, by the very pens, he might
have suffered shame;
But Eumaeus heard and ran from the
doorway.
The leather dropped. He shouted at
the dogs,
And scattered them with stones in
every direction.
“Old stranger,” he said, “the dogs
came near to tearing you.
You would have left me a reproach
before the gods.
And I have other grief enough. I sit
here mourning
My godlike master, and raise fat
swine for others,
While he, perhaps, wandering
hungry through strange lands,
Looks upon men and cities, asking
whether still
He lives beneath the light of the sun.
Come in,
And when you have eaten bread and
drunk your wine,

Tell me from where you came and
what sorrows you have borne.”
He led him into the hut and made
him sit.
He spread a thick bed of brushwood
beneath him,
And over it laid the hide of a wild
mountain-goat,
Large, shaggy, and warm. Odysseus
rejoiced
That such a welcome met him, and
spoke:
“May Zeus and all the deathless gods
give you
Whatever most you wish, since you
received me kindly.”
Eumaeus answered: “Stranger, it is
not lawful
For me to dishonor any guest,
though one poorer
Than you should come. Every
stranger and beggar
Is from Zeus; and our gift, though
small, is gladly given.
It is the portion of servants, always
afraid
When young masters hold the power
in their hands.
Had the gods bound my lord's
return, he would have given me
House, land, and wife—the gifts a
gracious master grants
To a servant who labors well, when
heaven makes the work prosper.
So might he have helped me, had he
grown old here.
But he is lost—would that Helen's
whole race
Had perished, since for her many
men's knees failed!

My lord went to Troy for
Agamemnon's honor,
To fight against the Trojans.”
Thus speaking, he fastened his tunic
with the belt,
And went among the sties where the
herds were penned.
From there he chose two young
boars, and sacrificed both;
He singed them, cut them up, and set
the pieces
Upon spits. When all was roasted, he
brought it,
Still hot upon the spits, before
Odysseus.
He sprinkled white barley over it,
and mixed
Sweet wine in a wooden cup. Then
he sat opposite
And urged his guest: “Eat now,
stranger, what the servants have—
Young pigs. The fat ones the suitors
eat, without
Reverence or pity in their hearts.
The blessed gods
Do not love outrageous works; they
honor justice
And what is fit among men. Even
hostile men,
When they invade another's land and
Zeus gives them spoil,
Fill their ships and carry their
plunder home,
Yet fear of heaven falls strongly on
their hearts.
These men have heard some divine
voice of their lord's death;
They will not seek him justly, nor
return to their own homes,

But sit at ease and consume his
wealth without measure.
For every day that comes from Zeus
they sacrifice
Not one beast, nor two, but many;
they draw out
The wine and drain it. His wealth
was without end—
No hero on the dark mainland, nor
Ithaca itself,
Had wealth so great. Not twenty
men together
Could equal it. I will count it for you:
Twelve herds of cattle on the
mainland, twelve flocks
Of sheep, twelve droves of swine,
twelve broad herds of goats,
All pastured by hired men and native
herdsmen.
Here at the edge are eleven herds of
goats,
And good men keep watch over
them; each day each herdsman
Brings the best goat as his offering. I
guard these swine,
And choose the finest boar to send
away.”
He spoke; and Odysseus ate the meat
and drank the wine,
Silently, with purpose growing in his
heart against the suitors.
When he had eaten, and his spirit
was strengthened,
He filled the stranger's cup with wine
and gave it him.
Odysseus received it gladly, and
asked:
“Friend, who bought you, so rich and
powerful,

As you describe him? You said he
perished
For Agamemnon's honor. Tell me, if
somewhere
I might recognize him, for Zeus and
the gods know
Whether I could carry news of him; I
have wandered far.”
The swineherd answered: “No
wandering man who came
With tidings could persuade the wife
or dear son
Of our lord. Men, pressed by hunger,
invent stories;
They do not wish to tell the truth.
Whoever reaches Ithaca
Goes first to my mistress and tells
her lying tales.
She receives him kindly, asks every
question,
And weeps, as a woman must, when
her husband has died abroad.
You too, old man, would quickly
shape a story,
If someone gave you a cloak and
tunic to wear.
But already dogs and birds of prey
are drawing
The skin from his bones, if he has
died on land;
Or the fish have eaten him in the sea,
and his bones lie
Wrapped in deep sand upon the
shore. His friends have grief
Behind them all, but for me most of
all: never again
Shall I find so gentle a master,
wherever I may go—
Not even if I return to the house of
my father and mother,

Where I was born and raised. I do
not grieve for them so much,
Though I long to see them in my
native land;
It is absent Odysseus who takes my
heart.”
Odysseus answered: “Since you deny
it wholly,
And your heart will not believe that
he shall return,
I will not speak idly, but with an
oath: Odysseus is coming.
And when he reaches this house, you
shall clothe me
In cloak and tunic—only then,
though I am in need.
Before that I would not receive them.
Let Zeus hear me first,
And this hospitable table, and the
hearth of noble Odysseus
To which I have come: all that I say
shall be fulfilled.
Before this year has run its course,
before the old moon wanes
And the new stands in the sky, he
will come home,
And punish whoever here dishonors
his wife and shining son.”
Eumaeus replied: “Old man, you will
not be paid
For this good news, nor will
Odysseus return.
Drink quietly, and let us speak of
other things;
Do not remind me. My heart aches
whenever anyone
Recalls my gracious master. As for
the oath, let it rest.
May Odysseus come as Penelope, old
Laertes,

And godlike Telemachus and I desire
him.
Now I mourn the boy as well,
Telemachus,
Whom Odysseus fathered. While he
was growing,
Like a young tree, I thought he
would become among men
No worse than his father, beautiful
in body and form.
But some immortal, or some mortal
man, has harmed his mind;
He went to Pylos to hear of his
father. The noble suitors
Lie in ambush for him as he comes
home, eager to destroy
The last seed of godlike Arcesius'
line. Let us leave him:
He may be taken, or he may escape
beneath Cronion's hand.
“But tell me, old man, your own
sorrow. Tell it truly,
That I may know: who are you, and
from where? Who were your parents?
Upon what ship did you arrive, and
how did the sailors bring you
To Ithaca? You did not come here on
foot.”
Odysseus answered: “If within this
hut
We had food and sweet wine for a
whole year,
While other men went on with all
their work,
I could not finish telling every grief
My spirit has endured by will of
gods.
Broad Crete I claim as my birthplace,
son

Of one whose wealth was great. His
lawful wife
Bore many sons and raised them in
the house;
My mother was a purchased
concubine.
Yet Castor, son of Hylax, honored
me
As much as those true-born—Castor,
whom Crete
Revered like a god for riches, goods,
and sons.
“The fates carried him to Hades.
Then
His proud sons divided all the wealth
by lot;
To me they gave a little and assigned
A narrow house. Yet I took to wife
the daughter
Of one whose fields were broad; I
was not worthless,
Nor one who fled from battle. All is
gone.
You see yourself the strength that
once was mine
Has faded. May no friend endure
such grief.
Once Ares and Athena gave me
courage;
When I led the best men into
ambush, death
Was not within my thought. I sprang
first with
The spear, and struck the foe my feet
could reach.
“I loved no household labor—not the
plough,
Nor ordered rooms—but ships and
war, the clash

Of battle, polished spear and singing
bow.
Other men shuddered; these were
dear to me.
Each heart finds joy in its appointed
task;
Mine found its joy in war.”
“Before Troy the Achaeans came, and
I
Led nine dark ships; they chose me
for their captain.
We sailed to Ilium, and I was there
Among the host. Yet now my name is
lost.
I heard that Troy had fallen, and
came home;
But the gods laid more suffering
upon me:
My three sons died, and a wasting
sickness
Carried my wife away from me.
“Still my heart was turned again
toward war.
I gathered men and ships, and sailed
for Egypt.
We moored beside the river’s
mouths, and told
Our men to keep the ships while
scouts went forth
To learn the country. But the men,
ruled by pride,
Went up at once and plundered all
the fields;
They drove away the cattle, carried
off
The women and the little children.
Their cry
Rose to the city. With the dawn the
Egyptians

Came in their chariots, horses filling
all

The plain, and Zeus put panic in our
hearts.

“No man could stand. They killed us
and took many

Alive. Then one who had been my
herald came,

Clasped my knees, and said: ‘Save
yourself, or die!

Remember Zeus, who hates the
works of evil.’

I cast away my helmet, shield, and
spear,

Ran to the king’s chariot, and knelt
down.

He spared me, led me weeping to his
house;

And when the Egyptians rushed
upon me, armed,

He held them back, fearing the anger
of Zeus,

Who most rebukes the wrong done
to a guest.

“Seven full years I stayed there,
gathering wealth;

The Egyptians gave me gifts. But in
the eighth

A Phoenician came, a deceitful
trader,

Greedy, and practiced in much harm
to men.

He won me over, and I went with
him

To Phoenicia, where his house and
possessions lay.

There I remained a year. When all
the days

Had run their course, he put me on a
ship,

Pretending that he sailed to Libya;
there

He meant to sell me with his goods. I
knew

His purpose, but necessity compelled
me.

“The ship ran swiftly before the
North Wind, past

The southern shore of Crete. But
Zeus, who bears

The thunderbolt, had marked them
for destruction.

When we were out at sea, he split the
mast;

It fell and struck the steersman, who
plunged down

Like a diver. Then Zeus hurled fire
into

The ship; she shook from end to end,
and all

The sailors fell like crows about the
wreck.

“I stayed upon the deck until the ship
Was broken. Wind tore mast and
keel apart,

Yet sail and yard were fastened to
the mast.

I bound myself to these, and through
the night

The storm drove me. At dawn I
reached the shore

Of Crete, where waves broke hard. I
swam around

The rocks, climbed under a rough
cliff, and turned

Inland, beyond the surf, through a
wooded valley.

There, hidden in the leaves, I lay; the
gods

Had led me to a place where I might live.

“All night I lay there. When the Dawn arose,

I looked toward the sea and saw a ship

Drawn up upon the shore. I crawled to the men,

Exhausted; they gave food, and took me aboard,

And brought me to Thesprotis. King Pheidon

Received me freely; his son, seeing me worn

With hunger, carried me into his father’s house.

They clothed me in a tunic and a cloak.

“There I heard of Odysseus. The king said

He had received him traveling toward his home,

And showed me all the treasure he had gathered—

Bronze, gold, and wrought iron—wealth enough to feed

Another household for ten generations.

He said Odysseus had gone to Dodona,

To hear from Zeus’s tall oak how he should come

To rich Ithaca, in the open or by stealth,

After so long an absence. Pouring wine,

He swore the ship was ready, and the men

Prepared to send him home.

“But first he sent me off. A

Thesprotian ship

Was sailing toward Dulichium, rich in grain;

He ordered them to take me to King Acastus.

They meant me harm, that I might sink still deeper

Into misfortune. When we were far from shore,

They stripped my cloak and tunic, threw these rags

About me, and at evening reached the coast

Of well-watered Ithaca. They bound me fast

Beneath the thwarts, then went ashore to eat.

But the gods loosed my bonds with little effort.

I covered up my head, slid down the smooth

Rudder, and entered the sea breast-first.

Swimming with both hands, I soon was hidden

From them. I climbed where a flowering wood

Stood thick, and crouched there.

They groaned and searched,

Then judged it useless, and returned aboard.

The gods concealed me easily, and brought me

To this hut of a man who knows his work;

My measure of living is not yet fulfilled.”

Eumaeus answered: “Poor stranger, you have stirred my heart,

Telling each sorrow and all the
wandering you endured.
Yet these things are not in order, and
you will not persuade me
By speaking of Odysseus. Why must
a man like you lie without need?
I know the return of my master: how
he was hated by all the gods,
Who did not strike him down among
the Trojans, nor in his friends' hands,
After he had worked through the
war. Then all the Achaeans
Would have raised him a mound, and
he would have won great fame
For his son. Now, nameless, the
Harpies have carried him away.
"I stay apart beside the swine, and do
not go into the city,
Unless wise Penelope calls me when
news comes from somewhere.
Then the people sit and question
me—those who grieve for the absent
king,
And those who rejoice while they
consume his substance without
payment.
I do not love to ask or question since
an Aetolian stranger deceived me:
He had killed a man, and after
wandering over many lands
Came to my house. I received him
warmly. He said he had seen
Odysseus
In Crete, with Idomeneus, repairing
ships shattered by storms;
He said Odysseus would come in
summer or autumn,
Bringing much wealth with his
godlike companions.

You too, old man full of grief, since a
god has led you here,
Do not flatter me with lies or charm
me. I will not honor you for that,
But will fear Zeus, the god of
strangers, and pity you."
Odysseus answered: "Your heart is
very hard;
Even with my oath I have not moved
you. Let us make a compact,
And afterward let the gods of
Olympus witness for us both:
If your master returns to this house
as I have said,
Give me a cloak and tunic, and send
me to Dulichium,
The land I love. But if your master
does not return,
Set your servants upon me and throw
me from the great cliff,
That another beggar may learn not
to deceive."
Eumaeus replied: "Then indeed my
fame and virtue among men
Would be great, if I welcomed you
into my hut, gave you a guest's gifts,
And afterward killed you. With a
free heart I might pray to Zeus.
But now it is supper-time. If only my
companions would come quickly,
So that we might prepare a pleasant
meal within the hut."
As they spoke, the swine and their
herdsmen drew near.
They penned the sows in their
accustomed places;
An immense clamoring rose from the
swine as they were shut in.
The swineherd called to his
companions:

“Bring the best boar, that I may
sacrifice it for this stranger
Who has come from far away. We
too shall have some benefit,
Who have long endured the toil of
raising white-tusked swine,
While others consume our labor
without payment.”
He split wood with the ruthless
bronze. The men brought in
A fat five-year-old boar and set it by
the altar.
Eumaeus did not forget the
immortals; his mind was just.
He cut bristles from the boar's head
and cast them into the fire,
Praying to all the gods that wise
Odysseus might return to his house.
Then, lifting a great oak billet, he
struck; the boar's life went out.
They slaughtered and singed him,
and Eumaeus divided the flesh.
He took the first pieces, dipped them
in barley meal, and cast them
Upon the fire. The rest he cut and
fixed upon spits;
They roasted it carefully, then drew
all the meat away,
And laid it in a heap. Eumaeus,
knowing what was right,
Divided the portions into seven
shares. One he set apart
For the nymphs and Hermes, Maia's
son, with prayer;
The others he distributed among the
men.
He honored Odysseus with the long
cuts from the white-tusked boar,
And gladdened the heart of his
master.

Odysseus said: “May you be as dear
to Father Zeus,
Eumaeus, as you are to me, since you
honor me so greatly,
Though I come in this poverty.”
Eumaeus answered: “Eat, stranger,
and enjoy what is here.
The god will give one thing and deny
another,
Whatever his heart wills; for he can
do all things.”
He sacrificed the first portions to the
everlasting gods,
Poured sparkling wine into
Odysseus' hands, and gave him his
place.
Mesaulius, whom the swineherd had
bought with his own goods
While the master was away,
distributed bread among them.
They reached for the food set before
them.
When hunger and thirst had left
them, they made ready for sleep.
Dark night came on; Zeus rained
through all the hours,
And a great, wet West Wind blew
without ceasing.
Odysseus tested the swineherd,
asking whether he might remove
His cloak, or urge one of the
companions to give him another,
Since Eumaeus cared for him greatly:
“Listen, Eumaeus, and all you others.
Wine makes a man foolish;
It loosens the tongue, raises laughter,
and gives the feet to dancing;
It lets a word escape which should
have remained hidden.

But since I have begun, I will not
conceal it.
Would that I were young again, and
had my strength as then,
When we lay in ambush beneath
Troy! Odysseus and Menelaus
Led us, and I was third, for they
themselves commanded.
When we reached the city and its
steep wall, we lay around it
In the dense brush and marsh,
crouched beneath our armor.
A hard North Wind rose in the evil
night; snow fell above it,
Cold and thick as hoarfrost, and ice
formed around our shields.
All the others had cloaks and tunics,
and slept easily,
Their shoulders covered by their
shields. I had left my cloak
With my companions, foolishly
thinking I would not be cold;
I came with only my shining shield
and belt.
“When the night was three parts
spent, and the stars had crossed the
sky,
I nudged Odysseus, who lay close
beside me, with my elbow.
He listened at once. ‘God-born son
of Laertes, resourceful Odysseus,
I shall not remain among the living;
the cold is killing me.
I have no cloak. Some god deceived
me into coming without one;
Now there is no escape.’
“He thought quickly, as he had been
accustomed to think and fight.
In a low voice he answered: ‘Silence,
lest another Achaean hear you.’

Then he rested his head upon his
elbow and spoke:
‘Friends, a divine dream came to me.
We are too far from the ships;
Let someone tell Agamemnon,
shepherd of the people,
To send more men from the vessels.’
“Thoas, son of Andraemon, sprang
up at once,
Laid down his red cloak, and ran
toward the ships.
I gladly lay in his garment, and
golden-throned Dawn appeared.
“Would that I were young again, and
had my strength!
Some swineherd here, out of
kindness and respect for a man,
Would give me a cloak. But now they
dishonor me,
Because I wear these miserable rags.”
Eumaeus answered: “The tale you
told is excellent;
You have spoken no useless word.
You shall not lack clothing tonight,
Nor anything else a suffering
suppliant should receive.
But at dawn you must put on your
own rags again;
We have no spare cloaks or tunics
here—one garment for each man.
When the dear son of Odysseus
comes, he himself will give you
Cloak and tunic, and send you
wherever your heart desires.”
So he rose and made a bed near the
fire, laying down
Sheep and goat skins. Odysseus lay
there, and Eumaeus cast over him
A great thick cloak kept for changes
when a hard winter came.

The young men slept beside him;
Eumaeus did not wish to sleep
Inside the hut, away from the swine.
He went out and armed himself:
First he slung his sharp sword across
his broad shoulders,
Then wrapped on a thick cloak
against the wind, took the hide
Of a great well-fed goat, and grasped
a sharp spear,
The guard of dogs and men. He went
to sleep where the white-tusked
swine
Lay beneath the hollow rock,
sheltered from the North Wind.

Source range: Book 14. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 15

First-pass working translation

Pallas Athena went to broad
Lacedaemon,
To remind the glorious son of great
Odysseus
Of his return, and urge him toward
his home.
She found Telemachus and Nestor's
shining son
Sleeping before the house of
Menelaus.
Peisistratus lay sunk in gentle sleep;
But Telemachus was not held by
sleep. Through the ambrosial night
His father's troubles woke him in his
heart.
Athena stood near him and spoke:
"Telemachus,
It is no longer fitting that you
wander far
From home, leaving your wealth and
such men in your halls;
They will divide and consume it all,
while you
Return empty-handed. Urge
Menelaus now
To send you home, that you may find
your blameless mother
Still there. Her father and brothers
press her to marry
Eurymachus, who outdoes the other
suitors with gifts
And enlarges the bride-price. Take
care lest some treasure
Be carried from your house against
your will. You know

How a woman's heart is stirred when
she marries again:
She remembers neither the first
children nor the husband
Who is dead, but wishes to increase
the house of the new man.
"Return yourself, and entrust each
possession
To the handmaid who seems best to
you, until the gods
Show you a noble wife. I have
another word:
The suitors' best men lie in wait for
you
In the strait between Ithaca and
rugged Samos,
Desiring to kill you before you reach
your native land.
I do not think they shall prevail; the
earth will hold
Some one of those men who consume
your wealth.
Keep your ship far from the islands,
and sail by night;
The immortal who watches and
protects you will send
The fair wind after you. When first
you reach Ithaca,
Send ship and companions to the
city, but go first
To the swineherd who keeps your
pigs and knows your house's grief.
Spend the night with him. Send him
to the city at dawn
To tell prudent Penelope that you
are safe
And have returned from Pylos."
She spoke and went to high
Olympus. Telemachus

Woke Nestor's son by touching him
with his heel:

"Rise, Peisistratus; yoke the
single-hoofed horses,

And bring the chariot. Let us be on
our way."

Peisistratus answered: "Though we
hasten, we cannot

Drive through the dark night. Dawn
will soon appear.

Wait until Menelaus, son of Atreus,
brings

The gifts to the chariot, and
dismisses us with gentle words.

The guest remembers every day the
host who gives affection;

Let him who loves the stranger send
him gladly on his way."

Golden-throned Dawn appeared,
and Menelaus came near,

Rising from his bed beside
fair-haired Helen.

When the dear son of Odysseus saw
him, he swiftly put on

His shining tunic, cast a great cloak
across his shoulders,

And stood outside the door:

"Son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured lord
of men,

Send me now to my beloved country.
My heart

Longs already to return. I left no
keeper behind

To watch my possessions while I
searched for my godlike father;

Let me not perish myself, nor lose
some precious treasure

From the chambers."

Menelaus answered: "I will not keep
you long,

Since you desire to return. I should
condemn another host

Who either urges a guest unwilling
to go,

Or holds him back when he is eager.

The proper way is equal:

To welcome the guest while he
remains, and send him

When his heart calls him home. Wait
until I place

The beautiful gifts in your chariot,
and tell the women

To prepare a meal in the hall from
what is already there.

It is both honor and profit to dine
before crossing

The wide earth. If you wish to travel
through Greece and Argos,

I will go with you, yoke the horses,
and lead you through the cities.

No one will send us away
empty-handed; they will give us

At least one thing to carry—a tripod,
a cauldron,

Or two mules, or a golden cup."

Telemachus answered: "I wish now to
go among my own people.

I left no guard behind my goods. I
fear that, seeking my father,

I may myself be lost, or that some
great treasure

May vanish from my halls."

Menelaus heard and ordered his wife
and servants

To prepare a meal from the food
within the house.

Eteoneus, son of Boethous, came
near; Menelaus told him

To light the fire and roast meat. He
did not disobey.

Menelaus descended to the fragrant
chamber of treasure;
Helen and Megapenthes went with
him. He took
A two-handled cup; he bade
Megapenthes carry
A silver mixing-bowl. Helen stood
beside the chests
Where lay the many-colored robes
she had made herself.
She lifted the largest and most
beautiful, shining
Like a star, and brought it to
Telemachus.
Menelaus said: "May Zeus bring
about your return,
As you desire it. Of all the treasures
in my house
I give you what is most beautiful and
honored:
A mixing-bowl, all silver, with gold
around its rim,
The work of Hephaestus, given to me
by Phaedimus,
King of the Sidonians, when his
house received me.
I give it to you."
Helen placed the robe in his hands: "I
too give you this,
Dear child—a remembrance of
Helen's hands, to be worn
By your bride when the longed-for
marriage comes.
Until then let it lie beside your
mother in her chamber.
May you reach your well-built house
and native land rejoicing."
Peisistratus received the gifts and
put them in the chest.

Menelaus led the guests into the hall.
They washed and ate;
Then Telemachus and Nestor's son
yoked the horses,
Mounted the painted chariot, and
drove from the porch.
Menelaus followed with sweet wine
in a golden cup,
To pour the farewell before they
went. He stood before the horses:
"Farewell, young men, and greet
Nestor, shepherd of the people.
He was gentle to me as a father while
we fought at Troy."
Telemachus answered: "We will tell
him all, if I return
To Ithaca and find Odysseus at
home. May I tell him
That I received every kindness from
you, and bring back
Many beautiful treasures."
As he spoke, a bird flew by on the
right: an eagle carrying
A great white goose snatched from
the household yard.
Men and women shouted as it passed
close before the horses.
Peisistratus asked Menelaus whether
the god had shown them
An omen, but Menelaus pondered
how to answer.
Helen spoke first: "Listen to me. I
will prophesy as the immortals
Put it in my heart, and as I think it
will be fulfilled.
As this eagle came from the
mountain where it was born
And seized the goose raised within
the house, so Odysseus,

After suffering and wandering long,
will return home
And punish all the suitors; perhaps
he is already there,
Sowing destruction for them all.”
Telemachus answered: “May Zeus,
loud-thundering husband of Hera,
Make your word come true. Then,
even there, I would pray to you
As to a god.” He touched the whip;
the horses flew
Across the plain, and all day they
shook the yoke.
The sun went down and the streets
grew dark.
They reached Pherae, the house of
Diocles,
Son of Orsilochus, whom the
Alpheus fathered.
There they spent the night; Diocles
gave them hospitality.
At dawn they yoked the horses and
mounted the painted car,
Drove from the porch, and the horses
flew willingly.
They soon reached the steep city of
Pylos.
Telemachus spoke to Nestor's son:
“How will you keep the promise
You made me? We claim friendship
from our fathers,
And are companions of the same age;
this road itself
Should strengthen our good
understanding. Do not drive me
Past my ship, prince nourished by
Zeus. Leave me there,
Lest the old man hold me unwilling
in his house,

Desiring to show affection. I must
reach my vessel quickly.”
Peisistratus considered what would
be fitting, and turned
The horses toward the swift ship and
the sea. From its stern
He took the beautiful gifts Menelaus
had given:
The clothing and the gold. He urged
Telemachus aboard:
“Go quickly, and tell all your
companions to embark
Before I reach home and tell my
father. I know his fierce heart:
He will not let you go, but will come
himself to summon you;
He will not return empty-handed,
for he will be angry.”
He drove back toward the city.
Telemachus called to his men:
“Put on your armor, companions,
and let us board the black ship.”
They heard and obeyed; they
climbed aboard and took the
benches.
Telemachus worked and prayed, and
sacrificed to Athena
Beside the stern. A distant man then
came near,
Fleeing Argos after killing one of his
own people.
He was a prophet, descended from
Melampus,
Who once dwelt in Pylos, rich in
sheep,
Then fled his native land and mighty
Neleus,
Who held his wealth from him
through all a year.

For Neleus' daughter and the
madness laid
Upon him by the dread Erinys, he
endured
Harsh bonds within the house of
Phylacus;
Then broke away, drove lowing
cattle home
From Phylace to Pylos, paid the debt
To godlike Neleus, and brought back
his brother's wife.
Afterward fate sent him to Argos,
where
He married, built a high-roofed
house, and fathered
Antiphates and Mantios. Antiphates
fathered Oicles; Oicles fathered
The people-leading Amphiaraus,
Beloved of Zeus and Phoebus, slain
at Thebes
For a woman's gifts. His sons were
Alcmaon
And Amphiloclus. Mantios fathered
Polyphides and Cleitus; Dawn bore
Cleitus
Away for beauty, that he might live
among
The immortals. When Amphiaraus
died,
Apollo made Polyphides the best
Of mortal seers. Angry with his
father,
He went to Hyperesia, and there
foretold
The future to all men. His son was
called
Theoclymenus.
The seer stood near Telemachus,
who was pouring a libation

And praying beside the black ship.
He spoke:
"Friend, I find you sacrificing here.
By these rites,
By your own head and by your
companions, tell me truly:
Who are you, and from what city and
parents? What is your ship,
And how has it brought you to
Ithaca? You did not come on foot."
Telemachus answered: "I will tell you
without concealment.
I am from Ithaca; Odysseus is my
father, if he ever was—
But now he has perished in a
miserable death. Therefore I came
With companions and a black ship to
learn of my father,
Long absent."
Theoclymenus replied: "So too I flee
my country, having killed
A man of my own people. Many
brothers and companions he has
In horse-feeding Argos, and they rule
the Achaeans.
Escaping death and the black fate, I
wander among men.
Take me aboard, since I come to you
as a suppliant;
Do not let them kill me—I think they
pursue me."
Telemachus answered: "I will not
thrust you from our balanced ship.
Come with us; there you shall share
whatever we possess."
He took the bronze spear, laid it
across the deck,
Boarded the sea-going ship, and
seated Theoclymenus beside him.

The companions loosed the stern
cables and raised the mast.
Athena sent them a favorable wind, a
fierce gust through the sky,
So that the ship might swiftly cross
the salt water.
They passed by the streams of Cruni
and fair-flowing Chalcis,
And when the sun went down came
by Phea and divine Elis,
Where the Epeians rule; from there
the ship ran among islands,
While Telemachus considered
whether he would escape death or be
taken.
In the hut Odysseus and the faithful
swineherd
Ate their supper; other men ate near
them.
When the meal was done, Odysseus
tested him:
“Would you still receive me here, or
send me down
Toward the city? At dawn I wish to
go
As a beggar, lest I burden you and
yours.
Lead me, and I will wander through
the streets,
Compelled to ask a cup, a piece of
bread.
Perhaps I may reach the house of
wise Penelope,
Tell her I bear news, and mingle with
the suitors.
They have abundant food; I might
serve them well.
By Hermes’ grace, who crowns the
work of men,

No mortal would surpass me at the
fire—
To split dry wood, to carve and roast
the meat,
Or pour the wine, the offices by
which
The lesser serve the greater.”
The swineherd groaned: “What
thought has entered your mind?
Do you desire utterly to die? If you
would enter the suitors’ crowd,
Their violence and iron pride reaches
the heavens. Their servants
Are not like you—young, well
dressed, with shining heads and
faces;
Their polished tables are always
heavy with bread, meat, and wine.
Stay here. No one troubles you,
neither I nor the companions.
When Telemachus, dear son of
Odysseus, comes,
He will clothe you and send you
where your heart commands.”
Odysseus said: “May Father Zeus
hold you dear,
Eumaeus, for you end my bitter
wandering.
Nothing is worse for mortals than
the road;
Yet for the belly’s sake we bear its
grief,
When pain and hunger drive us on.
Tell me:
Do the old parents of the king still
live,
Whom he left standing at the edge of
age,
Or have they gone beneath the sun to
Hades?”

Eumaeus answered: "I will tell the truth.
Laertes lives, and prays to Zeus each day
That life may leave his limbs within his house.
He mourns his son, and mourns his prudent wife,
Whose death brought harsh old age upon him; grief
For her great son consumed her. May no friend
Die such a death. While she was living, though
She sorrowed, it was sweet to speak with her;
She raised me with Ctimene, her youngest child.
We grew together, and she honored me
No less than her own daughter.
When the years
Of youth came on, they gave Ctimene to a man
In Same, taking countless bride-gifts; but
They clothed me in a tunic and a cloak,
Gave sandals to my feet, and sent me out
Among the fields. She loved me in her heart.
"That love is gone; yet still the blessed gods
Make prosperous the labor by which I live.
From it I eat and drink, and give to those
Who merit honor. But I hear no kindness

From my mistress since evil entered here—
The arrogant men. The servants long to speak
With her, ask what they desire, and eat and drink,
Then carry something home; such things warm
The heart of one who serves."
Odysseus answered: "How far you wandered, Eumaeus,
Though still a child, from your country and your parents!
Tell me truly: was your broad-streeted city sacked,
Where your father and honored mother lived? Or did enemies
Take you alone beside sheep or cattle, carry you on ships,
And sell you to this man's house for a worthy price?"
Eumaeus said: "Since you ask, stranger, listen in silence,
Drink your wine, and enjoy it. These nights are measureless:
There is time for sleep and time to hear a tale; do not lie down
Before the hour. Let any other man sleep outside if his heart desires;
At dawn he shall follow the master's swine after eating.
But we two, drinking and dining here, may take comfort
In one another's terrible griefs by remembering them;
For a man who has suffered and wandered much may find pleasure
Even in pain.
"There is an island called Syria, if you have heard of it,

Above Ortygia, where the sun turns.
It is not crowded,
But good—rich in cattle, sheep, wine,
and grain.
No hunger enters there, nor any
hateful sickness.
When the island's people grow old,
Apollo
And Artemis come with gentle
arrows, and strike
Them down. Two cities share the
island; all
Their wealth is divided between
them. My father,
Ctesius, son of Ormenus, ruled them
both,
Like an immortal among mortal
men.
“Phoenicians came there, sailors and
greedy traders,
Bringing many trinkets in a black
ship. In
My father's house there lived a
Phoenician woman,
Tall, beautiful, and skilled in shining
work.
As she washed garments near the
hollow ship,
They tempted her with love, and
asked her name
And country. She pointed toward my
father's house:
‘Sidon, rich in bronze, is my land; I
am
The daughter of wealthy Arybas.
Taphian pirates
Seized me from the fields, brought
me here, and sold
Me to this man, who paid a worthy
price.’

“The man who had secretly lain with
her asked:
‘Will you come with us, and see once
more the house
Of your father and your mother?
They must live,
And still be called wealthy.’ She
answered: ‘Sailors,
That might be so, if you would swear
to carry me
Home unharmed.’ They swore as she
commanded.
When the oath was finished, she said:
‘Be silent.
Let none of you address me in the
street or spring.
If someone tells the old man, he may
bind me fast
And plan your death. Hasten now
your trade.
When the ship is full, send a
messenger to me;
I will bring gold for whoever comes
beneath my hand,
And more besides. I raise the man's
own child,
Clever and eager to run outside; I
could
Carry him aboard, and he would
bring a price
Wherever you go among the foreign
peoples.’
“She returned into the beautiful
house. The Phoenicians
Stayed a full year, trading their
abundant cargo.
When the hollow ship was loaded,
they sent
A messenger. A skillful man came to
my father's house,

Bearing a golden necklace set with
amber.
The handmaids and my honored
mother touched
And examined it, and promised him
the price;
He nodded silently, then went back
to the ship.
She took my hand and led me out.
Within
The forecourt stood the cups and
tables used
By those who served my father; they
had gone
To assembly and public speech. She
hid
Three cups beneath her breast, and I
followed,
Foolish, unsuspecting. The sun went
down;
The streets grew dark. We hurried to
the harbor,
Where the Phoenician ship lay. They
climbed aboard,
And sailed the watery road; Zeus
sent a fair wind.
“For six days we sailed by night and
day. On the seventh,
Artemis the Archer struck the
woman down.
She fell into the bilge like a diving
sea-bird;
They threw her to the seals and fish.
I stayed,
Grieving in my heart. Wind and
water drove us
To Ithaca, where Laertes bought me
with
His own possessions. Thus my eyes
first saw

This country.”
Odysseus answered: “Eumaeus, you
have stirred my heart,
Telling all the griefs you suffered.
Yet Zeus placed something good
Beside your evil: after much pain you
came to the house of a gentle man
Who gives you food and drink, and
you live a good life. I, wandering
Through many cities of mortals, have
come at last to this place.”
They spoke thus and slept, but not
for long. Soon rosy-throned Dawn
came.
Telemachus' companions loosed the
sails upon the shore,
Lowered the mast quickly, and drew
the ship into the harbor with oars.
They cast out the anchors and tied
the stern-cables;
They went ashore upon the breakers,
prepared breakfast,
And mixed the sparkling wine.
When they had eaten and drunk,
Telemachus spoke wisely:
“Drive the black ship toward the city.
I will go through the farms
And see the herdsmen. At evening,
after I have inspected my affairs,
I will descend into the city; and at
dawn I will give you
A good road-meal of meat and sweet
wine.”
The godlike Theoclymenus asked:
“Where shall I go, dear child?
Whose house shall receive me among
the lords of rocky Ithaca?
Shall I go straight to your mother
and your house?”

Telemachus answered: "In other
 circumstances I would send you
 there;
 Our house lacks no guest-gifts. But it
 would be worse for you,
 Since I shall be away and my mother
 will not see you;
 She does not often appear before the
 suitors, but weaves upstairs.
 I will point out another man,
 Eurymachus, glorious son of wise
 Polybus,
 Whom the Ithacans now regard as a
 god. He desires above all
 To marry my mother and possess the
 honor of Odysseus.
 Olympian Zeus alone knows whether
 the evil day will come upon them
 Before the marriage."
 As he spoke, a bird flew by on the
 right: a hawk,
 Apollo's swift messenger, clutching a
 dove in its talons.
 It tore the feathers and let them fall
 between the ship
 And Telemachus. Theoclymenus
 called him away from the
 companions,
 Took his hand, and spoke:
 "Telemachus, this bird did not fly by
 the will of a god in vain.
 I knew it as an omen when I saw it.
 No other family in Ithaca
 Is more royal than yours; you shall
 always have the strength to rule."
 Telemachus answered: "May your
 word be fulfilled, stranger.
 Then you will quickly know my
 friendship and receive many gifts,

So that anyone who meets you may
 bless me."
 He called to Peiraeus, his faithful
 companion:
 "You above all obeyed me when we
 went together to Pylos.
 Take this stranger to your house,
 receive and honor him carefully,
 Until I come." Peiraeus answered: "If
 you remain long,
 I will care for him, and he shall lack
 no guest-gift."
 He boarded the ship and told the
 companions to embark and loose
 The stern-cables. They climbed
 aboard and sat at the oars.
 Telemachus bound beautiful sandals
 beneath his feet,
 Took a strong spear sharpened with
 bronze from the deck,
 And the companions released the
 cables. They rowed toward the city
 As Telemachus had ordered. He
 went swiftly ahead on foot,
 Until he reached the yard where the
 countless swine were kept,
 And where the excellent swineherd,
 gentle to his masters,
 Lived through the year.

Source range: Book 15. Full-book provisional
 draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 16

First-pass working translation

At dawn the swineherd and the
long-enduring king
Prepared their breakfast, having
kindled fire,
And sent the herdsmen out with all
the swine.
The dogs, who barked at every other
man,
Fawned on Telemachus and made no
sound.
Odysseus noticed, and heard the
tread of feet.
“Eumaeus,” he said, “some comrade
comes to you,
Or one you know; the dogs do not
bark but fawn,
And I hear footsteps.” He had not
ended when
His dear son stood within the
doorway. The swineherd,
Startled, let fall the vessels in which
he mixed
The dark wine. He ran to meet his
master’s son,
Kissed his head and both his eyes and
hands,
And shed a warm tear, as a father
welcomes home
An only son returned from distant
lands
After nine years, when he has
suffered much.
“You have come, Telemachus, sweet
light,” he cried.
“I did not think to see you again,
since you sailed

To Pylos. Come in, dear child, that I
may look
Upon you and rejoice; you seldom
visit field
Or herdsmen now, but dwell within
the town,
For so your heart desires—to see the
ruinous crowd
Of suitors.”
Telemachus answered: “So it shall be,
father;
For your sake I have come, that I may
see you
With my eyes and hear your words.
Tell me whether
My mother remains within the halls,
or whether
Some other Achaean has married
her, and the bed
Of Odysseus lies abandoned, full of
cobwebs.”
The swineherd answered: “She
remains in the house,
Enduring in her heart. Her nights
and days
Wear themselves away in tears.” He
gave his spear
To Telemachus, who crossed the
stone threshold.
Odysseus rose and yielded his seat.
Telemachus
Held him back: “Sit, stranger. We
shall find
Another place here; there is one who
will prepare it.”
Odysseus returned and sat. The
swineherd spread
Green brushwood and a fleece above
it; there

The dear son of Odysseus sat.
Eumaeus set before them
The roasted meat left from the day
before,
Bread in baskets, and sweet wine in a
wooden cup;
He sat opposite his godlike master,
and they ate.
When hunger and thirst were gone,
Telemachus asked:
“Father, from where has this stranger
come? How did sailors
Bring him to Ithaca? Who claimed
that they were his guides?
He could not, I think, have come
here on foot.”
Eumaeus answered: “I will tell you
truly, child.
He says that he was born in broad
Crete, and wandered
Through many cities of mortals by
the will of a god.
Now he has escaped from a
Thesprotian ship
And reached my hut; I place him in
your hands.
Do with him as you wish; he is your
suppliant.”
Telemachus answered: “Your words
wound me, Eumaeus.
How shall I receive him in my house?
I am young
And have not yet trusted my hands
to ward off a man
Who strikes first. My mother’s mind
is divided:
Shall she remain beside me, guarding
the house,
Respecting the bed of her husband
and the people’s voice,

Or follow whichever Achaean is best,
and brings
The greatest gifts? I will clothe this
stranger well—
A cloak and tunic, a double-edged
sword and sandals—
And send him where his heart
commands. If you wish,
Keep him here; I will send him food
and clothing,
So he will not wear you and your
companions down.
I will not let him go among the
suitors:
Their insolent hearts might mock
him, and my grief
Would be unbearable. It is hard for
one man
To fight a multitude; they are far
stronger.
“Stranger,” Odysseus replied, “since I
too may answer,
My heart is cut by hearing how the
suitors act
Against your will. Tell me: do you
yield willingly,
Or do the people hate you, obeying
some divine voice?
Do you reproach your brothers, on
whom a man relies
When strife grows great? Would that
I were young again,
Or born as the son of blameless
Odysseus!
Then might some foreign man cut
off my head at once,
If I did not become a plague to every
suitor,
Entering the house of Laertes’ son. If
they alone

Overpowered me, I would choose
death in my own halls
Rather than watch forever these
shameful acts:
Guests beaten, serving women
dragged disgracefully
Through the beautiful rooms, wine
spilled, and food consumed
In wasteful work that has no end.”
Telemachus answered: “I will tell you
truly.
No people hate me, nor do I
reproach brothers;
Cronion made our family a single
thread:
Arceus fathered only Laertes,
Laertes only
Odysseus, and Odysseus left me
alone in the house.
Now countless enemies are within it.
The best men
Of Dulichium, Same, wooded
Zacynthus, and rocky Ithaca
Court my mother and consume our
house. She neither
Rejects the hateful marriage nor can
bring it to completion;
They waste my livelihood and soon
will waste me too.
But these matters lie on the knees of
the gods.
Eumaeus, go quickly and tell wise
Penelope
That I am safe and have returned
from Pylos.
I will remain here; tell this alone, and
let no other Achaean
Know it, for many men are plotting
harm against me.”

Eumaeus said: “I understand. You
command wisely.
But tell me: shall I also go to
unfortunate Laertes?
He used to watch the work and eat
and drink among the servants,
Grieving greatly for Odysseus; but
since you sailed to Pylos,
They say he has not eaten or drunk,
nor gone to the fields.
He sits in lamentation, and his flesh
wastes upon his bones.”
Telemachus answered: “It is painful,
yet we must leave him.
If all things were given to mortals by
their own choice,
We would choose first the day my
father came home.
Tell my mother, and secretly bid the
nurse go to the old man;
She may carry the news to him. I will
remain here.”
The swineherd took his sandals and
went toward the city.
Athena did not fail to notice him.
She came near the hut
In the form of a tall and beautiful
woman, skilled in shining work.
She stood before the doorway and
revealed herself to Odysseus;
Telemachus did not see her, for the
gods do not appear clearly
To every mortal. The dogs saw her,
and Odysseus saw her;
They shrank away whining. Athena
nodded with her brows.
Odysseus left the hut and stood
before her beyond the wall.
“Son of Laertes,” she said, “tell your
son now;

Conceal nothing. Plan death and
doom for the suitors,
And go together to the famous city. I
will not remain
Far from you, eager for the battle.”
She touched him with her golden
wand. First she restored
His clean-washed cloak and tunic,
and increased his body
And youth. His skin grew dark again,
his cheeks filled,
And dark beard spread around his
chin. Having done this,
She departed. Odysseus went back
into the hut.
His son, startled, looked away in
fear: “You are changed,
Stranger; your clothing and your
skin are not the same.
You must be one of the gods who
hold the broad heaven.
Be gracious, and we will offer
pleasing sacrifices,
And fashioned gold. Spare us.”
Odysseus answered: “I am no god.
Why make me like
The immortals? I am your father, for
whose sake
You groan and suffer the violence of
men.”
He kissed his son, and let a tear fall
to the ground—
The tear he had held back
continually. But Telemachus
Still did not believe that this was his
father:
“You are not Odysseus, my father.
Some god deceives me,
To make me lament still more. No
mortal could devise

This change by his own mind,
becoming young or old
Unless a god came willingly to do it.
Just now
You were an old man in rags; now
you resemble a god.”
Odysseus answered: “It is not fitting,
when your father
Stands before you, to marvel beyond
measure. No other
Odysseus will come; I am he, after
suffering and wandering,
And in the twentieth year I have
reached my native land.
Athena, the driver of hosts, has made
me as she wishes;
At one time like a beggar, at another
like a young man
In beautiful clothing. It is easy for
the gods, who hold heaven,
To honor a mortal or bring him low.”
He sat; Telemachus threw his arms
around his excellent father,
And mourned him, shedding tears. A
desire for lament rose in both;
They cried sharply, more piercingly
than birds of prey cry
When peasants have taken their
unfledged young.
The tears fell beneath their brows.
The light of the sun
Would have gone down upon their
grief, had Telemachus not asked:
“By what ship did you come, dear
father? Who were the sailors?
You could not have crossed the sea
alone.”
Odysseus answered: “The Phaeacians
brought me here.

They carry other men as well,
whenever one reaches their shore.
They laid me sleeping upon Ithaca,
and gave me many gifts:
Bronze, gold, and woven garments,
stored in a cave
By the favor of the gods. I have come
here by Athena's counsel.
Let us plan how to bring death to the
suitors. Tell me their number,
So that I may know whether you and
I alone can face them,
Or whether we should seek help
from another quarter."
Telemachus answered: "I know your
strength in battle,
But two men could not overcome
such a crowd. There are fifty-two
From Dulichium, and six servants;
twenty-four
Come from Same, and twenty from
Zacynthus. Twelve are from Ithaca.
There is the herald Medon, the
singer, and two serving men.
If all these men stand against us,
consider whether someone
From Pylos or Sparta should come to
help, or whether we should
Call old Laertes and the faithful
swineherd."
Odysseus answered: "Those two high
gods, Athena and Zeus,
Will be enough. They sit in the
clouds and are stronger than all.
The battle will not keep us long
apart, when Ares' strength
Is judged between us and the suitors
in my halls.
At dawn go home and mingle with
the arrogant men.

Later the swineherd will lead me to
the city, like a wretched old beggar.
If they dishonor me in the house, let
your heart endure it,
Even if they drag me by the feet
through the doorway
Or strike me with their weapons.
Watch, and do not defend me
openly;
Urge them gently to stop their folly,
but they will not listen—
Their fated day is near.
"When Athena gives you the sign,
take all the weapons
Of war that lie in the halls, and carry
them to the inner chamber
At the top of the house. If a suitor
asks, deceive him gently:
Say that you stored them away from
the smoke, since they were no longer
Like the weapons Odysseus left when
he went to Troy;
The vapor of the fire has damaged
them. Add this stronger reason:
Lest, when wine has made the suitors
violent, they set quarrel among us,
Wound one another, and disgrace
the feast and the courtship;
Iron itself draws a man toward it.
Leave only two swords,
Two spears, and two shields for us to
take up when the hour comes.
Athena and thoughtful Zeus will
then enchant the suitors' minds.
"Keep this in your heart: if you truly
are my son and share my blood,
Let no one in the house hear that
Odysseus is here—not Laertes,
Nor the swineherd, nor any servant,
nor Penelope herself.

You and I alone will know the truth,
and we will test the servants:
Who honors us and fears us, and who
disregards and dishonors us.”
Telemachus answered: “You will
learn my heart in time;
It is not made for retreat. But I do
not think this plan
Will bring equal gain to both of us.
Consider it carefully:
You must spend a long while testing
each man by your labor,
While the suitors sit at ease
consuming our wealth.
I urge you to examine the women
first—the ones who dishonor you
And the ones who are blameless. I
would not yet test the men
At the pens; that work can wait, if
we receive a sign from Zeus.”
Meanwhile the well-built ship came
into the harbor,
And servants drew the black hull up
the shore.
They bore the weapons off, and with
the gifts
Menelaus had bestowed, sent a
herald forth
To tell the prudent queen her son
was safe,
And had commanded that the ship
come in,
So she would not be fearful or shed
tears.
The herald and the excellent
swineherd met,
Each bearing the same tidings. At the
house
The herald told the women: “Your
dear son lives.”

Eumaeus stood beside Penelope and
gave
The message Telemachus had
ordered him;
Then turned again among the swine.
The suitors heard, and grief and
shame seized them.
Eurymachus spoke: “A mighty work
is done.
We thought his journey would not
come to pass.
Draw the best ship into the sea;
gather oarsmen,
And send the word to those who
wait at home.”
He had not finished when
Amphinomus saw
The ship within the harbor, sails
struck down,
The rowers at their oars. He softly
laughed:
“Send no messenger; they are already
here.”
They hauled the ship ashore and bore
the arms away.
Then all the suitors went into the
assembly,
And kept both young and old apart.
Antinous cried:
“The gods have rescued him! By day
our watchers
Sat on the windy heights; at evening
in the ship
We waited through the night to seize
and kill him.
Now a god has brought him home.
While he is living,
Our work is unfinished; he has
counsel, and

The people do not favor us as once
they did.
Let us kill him in the fields or on the
road,
And divide his property; let his
mother's house
Belong to him who brings the
greatest gifts.
If this is not your will, and you
would have him
Live with his father's wealth, then let
us cease
To eat it without payment; let each
man send
His gifts from home, and let
Penelope marry
The man whose bride-price proves
the best."
The suitors fell silent. Amphinomus,
The glorious son of Nisus, answered
them:
"Friends, I would not kill
Telemachus. It is
A fearful thing to murder a king's
son.
First let us ask the gods. If Zeus
approves,
I will myself strike first and urge you
on;
If the gods turn us back, then let us
stop."
His counsel pleased them, and they
rose and went
Into Odysseus' house.
But Medon heard their plot and told
the queen.
She came below with handmaids,
standing by
The close-wrought roof-post, veil
before her cheeks,

And spoke to Antinous: "Men say
you excel
In counsel and in speech among the
Ithacans,
Yet you are mad. Why weave the
death of my son,
And disregard the suppliant, though
Zeus sees?
Remember when your father fled the
people's anger;
The Thesprotians wished to tear his
life away,
Until Odysseus held their violence
back.
Now you consume his house, pursue
his wife,
And plot his son's death. Stop, and
restrain the others."
Eurymachus answered: "Daughter of
Icarius,
Be confident. No man will lay hands
on him
While I behold the sunlight. I say it
now:
His dark blood would run upon my
spear. For once
Odysseus placed the roasted meat in
my hands,
And poured me red wine;
Telemachus is dear
Above all men to me." Yet even as he
spoke,
He planned the boy's destruction.
Penelope
Went weeping to her chamber, till
Athena sent
Sweet sleep upon her eyes.
At evening the excellent swineherd
came;
Odysseus and Telemachus prepared

Their supper, having sacrificed a
five-year-old boar.
Athena stood beside them, touched
Odysseus
Again with her golden wand, and
made him old,
Clothing him once more in miserable
rags,
Lest the swineherd recognize him,
turn back,
And tell Penelope, keeping the
knowledge there.
Telemachus spoke first: "You have
come, good Eumaeus.
What news is there within the city?
Are
The proud suitors already in the
house,
Or do they still lie waiting for me,
though I have returned?"
Eumaeus answered: "I did not stop to
ask
These things as I crossed the city; my
heart
Urged me to return quickly after
giving
The message. The swift herald went
with me,
And first told your mother. But I saw
another
Thing with my own eyes: beyond the
city,
Near Hermes' hill, a swift ship
entered our harbor.
Many men were aboard, and it bore a
weight
Of shields and spears. I thought they
might be those
You feared; I do not know."

Telemachus smiled, and looked
toward his father,
Avoiding the swineherd's eye. They
finished
Their labor and prepared the meal;
when hunger
And thirst were gone, they sought
their beds and took
The gift of sleep.

Source range: Book 16. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Telemachus recognizes Odysseus in the swineherd's hut

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 17

First-pass working translation

When early Dawn appeared,
Telemachus bound
His sandals beneath his feet, and
took the spear
That rested in his hand. He longed to
reach the city;
He spoke to the swineherd:
“Father, I go into the town, that my
mother may see me.
She will not cease from weeping and
grievous lament
Until she looks upon me. Take this
command:
Lead the unhappy stranger there, so
he may beg
His meal among the people; whoever
wishes will give
Bread and a cup. I cannot bear all
men’s burdens,
Though I carry grief within me. If
the stranger is angry,
It will be worse for him; but I love to
speak the truth.”
Odysseus answered: “I do not wish to
remain.
For a beggar it is better to seek a
meal in the city
Than in the fields; whoever wishes
may give me food.
I am no longer young enough to obey
every keeper’s sign.
Go on; this man whom you
command will lead me
When the fire has warmed me. These
garments are miserable;

The cold may master me, and you say
the city is far.”

Telemachus crossed the yard with
swift feet, planting harm
Deep in the hearts of the suitors.
When he reached
The well-built house, he set his spear
against a tall column
And entered over the stone
threshold. His nurse Eurycleia,
Who was folding the fleece upon
carved chairs, saw him first;
She wept and came directly to him.
The other servants
Of steadfast Odysseus gathered, and
kissed his head and shoulders.
Penelope came from her chamber
like Artemis or golden Aphrodite.
She threw both arms around her dear
son, kissed his head and eyes,
And spoke through tears: “You have
come, sweet light.
I thought I would never see you
again, since you sailed secretly
To Pylos, against my will, to seek
news of your father.
Tell me everything you saw.”
Telemachus answered: “Mother, do
not stir my grief,
Now that I have escaped a steep
death. Wash yourself,
Put on clean clothing, go upstairs
with the women,
And pray to all the gods that you will
offer complete hecatombs,
If Zeus fulfills his retaliating work. I
will go to the assembly
And bring a stranger who followed
me from Pylos.

I sent him ahead with my
companions; I told Peiraeus
To lead him home and honor him
until I returned.”
His word was not winged in vain.
Penelope washed,
Put on clean robes, and prayed to all
the gods
That Zeus would complete his
vengeance.
Telemachus crossed the hall, spear in
hand; two bright dogs
Followed him. Athena poured
marvelous grace around him,
And everyone who approached
looked upon him with wonder.
The suitors gathered, speaking
pleasant words in public,
But planning evil in the depth of
their minds.
Telemachus avoided their crowd,
and sat where Mentor,
Antiphus, and Halitherses sat—his
father’s old companions.
There he sat down; and each old
friend in turn kindly
Asked him what tidings he had
brought from overseas,
And what he knew of his long-absent
father.
Peiraeus came near, bringing the
stranger through the city.
“Telemachus,” he said, “send word
quickly to my house,
That I may bring here the gifts
Menelaus gave you.”
Telemachus answered: “We do not
know how this will end.
If the arrogant suitors kill me
secretly and divide

All my father’s possessions, I would
rather you keep the gifts,
Or give them to one of these men.
But if I plant death
Among them all, then bring them
joyfully to my house.”
He led the weary stranger to the
house. There they laid
Their cloaks upon chairs, bathed in
polished baths,
And the women washed and
anointed them with oil.
They put on warm cloaks and tunics,
and sat on chairs.
A maid brought water in a golden
pitcher,
And poured it over a silver basin for
their hands;
Then drew a polished table before
them.
The honored steward brought
abundant bread
And many dishes, gracious for the
guests.
Penelope sat opposite, leaning
against the doorpost,
Turning fine thread upon her
spindle.
After they had eaten and drunk, she
began:
“Telemachus, I will go upstairs to my
painful bed,
Always wet with tears since
Odysseus went with the sons
Of Atreus to Troy. You did not tell
me clearly
Before the suitors came whether you
had heard of your father.
Tell me now.”

Telemachus answered: "We went to
Pylos and to Nestor,
Shepherd of the people. He received
me in his high house
As a father welcomes a son who has
returned after long absence.
He cared for me with his famous
sons. But he said
He had heard nothing of Odysseus,
alive or dead.
He sent me by horses and a
close-built chariot
To Menelaus, famed for the spear.
"There I saw Argive Helen, for whose
sake the Argives
And Trojans suffered many labors by
the will of the gods.
Menelaus asked why I had come to
Lacedaemon;
I told him everything. He answered
with a great wish:
'Would that Odysseus might enter
among these suitors,
Even as he once stood in Lesbos and
threw Philomeleides
In the wrestling match, while all the
Achaeans rejoiced!
Then the suitors would meet a bitter
and early death.'
"He told me also what the truthful
Old Man of the Sea
Had said: that he saw my father
suffering great pains
On an island, in the halls of Calypso,
who holds him by force.
Odysseus cannot reach his native
land; he has no ships,
No oarsmen and no companions to
carry him across the sea.

So Menelaus spoke; and when I had
finished I returned.
The immortals gave me a fair wind
and brought me swiftly home."
Theoclymenus, godlike seer, spoke to
Penelope:
"Lady, wife of Laertes' son, hear me.
Menelaus did not know
Clearly; but I will tell you truly.
Zeus, the hospitable table,
And the hearth of blameless
Odysseus hear me: Odysseus is
already
In his native land, sitting or
creeping, learning these evil deeds,
And sowing destruction for all the
suitors. I read this omen
While I sat upon the well-benched
ship, and told it to your son."
Penelope answered: "May your word
be fulfilled, stranger.
Then you would quickly know my
friendship and receive gifts,
So that anyone meeting you might
call me blessed."
Penelope answered: "Stranger, may
this word be fulfilled!
Then you would quickly know my
friendship and receive
Many gifts from me, so that whoever
met you afterward
Would call me blessed."
Before the house the suitors amused
themselves with quoit and javelin,
Upon the ordered ground where they
had long practiced insolence.
When it was time for supper, Medon,
most welcome of heralds,
Called them: "Young men, come to
the house and prepare the meal.

There is no better thing in its season
than supper.”

They rose and obeyed. Within they
laid aside their cloaks,

Sacrificed great sheep, fat goats,
swine, and a herd-cow,

And made the feast.

Odysseus and the faithful swineherd
left the country.

Eumaeus spoke: “Since you desire to
go into the town today,

As my master commanded, I would
rather leave you here

To guard the pens. Yet I fear my
lord’s anger behind me;

The commands of kings are difficult.

Let us go; the day is far spent,

And soon the evening cold will be
worse.”

Odysseus answered: “I understand;
lead me straight on.

Give me a staff, if you have one cut,
that I may lean upon it;

You yourself said the road’s
threshold is dangerous.”

He threw the ragged, many-seamed
beggar’s bag around his shoulders;

Eumaeus gave him a stout stick, and
they went together.

The dogs and herdsmen remained
behind to guard the yard;

The swineherd led his master toward
the city,

Like a wretched old beggar leaning
on a staff.

When they came near the city by the
rough path,

They reached the clear spring made
by Ithacus,

Neritus, and Polycator. Around it
stood a circular grove

Of water-loving poplars; cold water
fell from the rock,

And above the spring an altar was
built for the nymphs,

Where every traveler offered prayer.

There Melanthius, son of Dolios, met
them,

Driving goats that surpassed all other
flocks as a feast

For the suitors. Two herdsmen
followed him.

When he saw the pair, he spoke
outrageously:

“Now a bad man leads a worse, as the
god always brings

Like to like. Where are you dragging
this glutton,

Worthless swineherd? He will stand
by many doors

And rub his shoulders against the
posts, begging scraps,

Not cauldrons or swords. If you gave
him to me,

He would clean the stalls, carry
manure, and gather

Dry leaves for the kids; he would
grow strong on whey.

But since he has learned evil work, he
will not touch labor;

He prefers to beg throughout the
town and feed his belly.

I tell you what will happen: if he
comes near Odysseus’ house,

Many footstools will fly against his
ribs, and his bones will be crushed.”

So he went on, and as he passed he
struck Odysseus on the hip.

The king did not move, but
considered whether to spring upon
him
And kill him, or endure and keep his
rage within.
Eumaeus lifted his hands and prayed:
“Nymphs of this spring,
If Odysseus ever burned thigh-pieces
for you, with wine poured over,
Grant my prayer: may he return, and
may some god lead him.
Then he would make this man
vanish—the man who abuses us.”
Melanthius answered: “Look at him!
He prays from far away,
While I go to the city to bring a feast.
May the gods destroy him.
He will never return.” He went
toward the city;
Eumaeus and his master followed.
Near the house and the gate they
found Argos, once the hound
Odysseus had raised before sailing to
Troy. In his youth
The hunters had admired his speed
and scent; but his master left,
And now he lay neglected upon a
heap of dung before the doors.
Ticks covered him. He had been
strong and beautiful,
But the servants, under the suitors’
rule, no longer cared for him.
Argos raised his head and pricked
both ears. He recognized Odysseus,
Whom he had not seen for twenty
years. He could not approach;
He had no strength left. He moved
his tail and lowered both ears.
Odysseus turned away and wiped the
tear that came easily,

Hiding it from Eumaeus. Then he
asked:
“It is strange, Eumaeus, that such a
dog should lie in dung.
Was he beautiful in body, or only
such as men keep for show?
Was he one of those dogs that attend
a table, or one that follows
Goats and cattle? In the mountains
such dogs keep wolves away.”
Eumaeus answered: “That dog
belonged to the man who died far
away.
If you saw him now, you would
marvel at his speed and strength.
When we left him, he was a puppy;
he had not yet hunted.
Women and servants said he would
outrun every hound.
Now he is broken. His master is lost,
and the women neglect him;
Servants do not work when their
lord is absent. Zeus takes away
Half a man’s virtue when slavery’s
day comes upon him.
Argos once tracked every beast
through the wooded hills.
Now he lies here, and the evil
sickness has come upon him.
When Odysseus left, the women did
not care for him.”
Before Eumaeus finished, death’s
darkness seized Argos;
He had seen Odysseus after twenty
years. Eumaeus entered the house,
And the dog’s fate was hidden
beneath the dark earth.
Inside, Eumaeus sat with
Telemachus. Odysseus remained

Beside the threshold, begging from
all the suitors.
Each gave him a little, moved by
shame or pity.
Antinous alone refused, saying: "Old
man, why do you stand here?
Do you think the suitors will give
you food? Go elsewhere.
You are shameless, coming to every
table."
Odysseus answered: "Antinous,
though you look like a king,
Your mind is not gentle. You have
not given me a morsel,
Though you sit beside another man's
table. I am not asking
For much. I too once lived in a
wealthy house and gave to
wanderers,
Whatever their need. I had countless
servants and all the things
Men call prosperity. But Zeus
destroyed it, and sent me wandering
With raiders toward Egypt. I moored
the ships at the river,
Told my companions to stay and
send scouts, but pride mastered
them.
They plundered fields, carried off
women and children, and killed men.
At dawn the Egyptians came with
horses and bronze; Zeus put flight
Into us. Many were killed, the rest
led away. I was given to a Cypriot,
And through him have come here,
suffering many things."
Antinous replied: "What god
brought this nuisance to spoil our
feast?

Stand away from my table, or you
may reach bitter Egypt and Cyprus.
You are bold and shameless, begging
from everyone; they give without
thought,
For each has plenty."
Odysseus withdrew: "You have
beauty, but no mind. You would not
give
Even salt from your own house to a
keeper, though you sit beside
another's.
You could not spare a crumb. Yet
there is abundance here."
Antinous grew angrier, seized a
footstool, and struck his right
shoulder.
Odysseus stood firm as a rock; the
blow did not move him.
He shook his head, holding evil in
the depth of his mind.
Then he went back to the threshold,
sat down, and spoke:
"Hear me, suitors of the famous
queen. There is no grief
When a man is struck while fighting
for his cattle or sheep;
But Antinous struck me for the sake
of my cursed belly,
Which brings mortals many evils. If
gods and avenging powers
Exist for beggars, may Antinous
meet death before his marriage."
Antinous answered: "Eat in silence,
stranger, or go elsewhere,
Lest the young men drag you
through the house by hand or foot
And strip you bare." The suitors
disapproved, saying:

“Antinous, it was not right to strike
this wretched wanderer;
Perhaps some god is in the likeness
of a stranger.
The gods take every shape and visit
cities to observe
Men’s insolence and lawfulness.”
Penelope heard the sound, and from
her room
Spoke to the women: “Would that
Artemis
Or far-darting Apollo struck the
man
Who raised his footstool against that
stranger here!”
Eurynome, her steward, answered
her:
“If all our prayers could find their
way to dawn,
Not one of these men would behold
the light.”
The queen replied: “They are all
enemies,
But Antinous is blackest of them all.
The stranger wanders through the
house and begs;
The others gave him food, but he
alone
Has answered hunger with a lifted
stool.”
Penelope called Eumaeus: “Go, tell
the stranger
To come. I would embrace him, ask
whether
He has heard or seen the
much-enduring king.
He looks like one who has wandered
far.”
Eumaeus answered: “Would that
these Achaeans

Were silent! His speech would charm
your heart.
Three nights and days I kept him; he
came to me
After escaping from a ship, and still
Has not completed all his tale of
sorrow.
As a singer, knowing words the gods
have taught,
Holds the whole hall enchanted, so
he charms me.
He says he is an ancient guest-friend
of
Odysseus, born where Minos once
held rule;
Through pain he came, and heard the
king still lived
In wealthy Thesprotis, bringing
treasures home.”
Penelope answered: “Go and call
him, that he may speak
With me face to face. Let these men
amuse themselves
By the doors or within the house.
Their own possessions—
Bread and sweet wine—lie
untouched; servants consume them,
While suitors come each day,
sacrifice our cattle,
Sheep, and fat goats, feast, and drink
our shining wine.
The wealth is wasting, for there is no
man like Odysseus
To guard it. If he came, he and his
son would quickly
Repay the violence of these men.”
As she spoke, Telemachus sneezed
loudly; the house rang terribly.
Penelope smiled, and said to
Eumaeus: “Go, call the stranger at

once.

Did you not hear my son's sneeze
beneath all these words?

May death overtake every suitor, and
may none escape it.

If I find that the stranger speaks
everything truly,

I will give him a beautiful cloak and
tunic."

The swineherd went and stood near
Odysseus:

"Stranger, wise Penelope calls you.
She wishes to ask you

About her husband, and about the
grief she has suffered.

If you tell her everything truly, she
will clothe you well;

And you will beg bread through the
people's town."

Odysseus answered: "I could tell
Icarius's prudent daughter

Everything about her husband, for
we shared sorrow together.

But I fear the crowd of harsh suitors,
whose insolence

Reaches the iron sky. Even now,
when I did no wrong,

One struck me as I walked through
the house, and Telemachus

Did not defend me. Tell Penelope to
wait until the sun goes down;

Then let her ask me about her
husband, sitting closer by the fire.

My clothing is wretched—you know
this, since I first came to you."

Eumaeus returned and told

Penelope. She said: "Why did the
wanderer

Not come? A poor man is timid, and
his shame is foolish."

Eumaeus answered: "He spoke
rightly. He avoids the insolence
Of the proud men. He bids you wait
until the sun has set;

That will be better for you, queen, to
speak with him alone."

Penelope answered: "The stranger is
not foolish; he understands.

There are no other mortals so
arrogant and reckless as these men."

Eumaeus went back among the
suitors and bent his head toward
Telemachus:

"I go to guard the swine and our
livelihood. Take care of yourself;

Many Achaeans plan harm. May
Zeus destroy them before they bring
Our sorrow upon us."

Telemachus answered: "So it shall be,
father. Go after sunset,

And return at dawn with beautiful
sacrificial beasts."

The swineherd sat again on the
polished stool, filled his heart
With food and drink, and went out
among the swine.

The feasters were already deep in
song and dancing;

The late afternoon had come.

Source range: Book 17. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 18

First-pass working translation

Then there came a public beggar,
known throughout the city,
Who begged in Ithaca, and had an
insatiable hunger
For food and drink. He had no
strength, no real power,
But was large in body to the eye. His
name was Arnaeus—
His mother gave him that name at
birth—but the young men called him
Irus,
Because he carried messages
whenever anyone commanded.
He came to drive Odysseus from his
own house:
“Old man, move from the porch, lest
they drag you out by the foot.
Do you not hear them all urging me?
I am ashamed to be held back.
Rise, before a quarrel comes to
blows.”
Odysseus looked darkly at him: “I do
you no harm,
Nor envy you the gifts you gather.
This threshold
Has room for both of us. Do not
begrudge what is not yours.
You seem a wanderer like me; the
gods may yet give wealth.
Do not provoke my hands, lest,
though I am old,
I stain your breast and lips with
blood. Tomorrow, I think,
You will not return a second time to
the house of Laertes’ son.”

Irus grew angry: “The glutton runs
on like an old woman
Beside the oven! I could strike him
with both hands,
Knock every tooth from his jaw like
a pig consuming grain.
Gird yourself, that all may see us
fight. How could you
Stand against a younger man?”
They bristled before the high,
polished doors. Antinous heard,
And laughed sweetly: “Friends, no
such entertainment has come here
before:
The stranger and Irus are challenging
one another to fight.
Let us quickly make them do it.” The
suitors sprang up laughing,
Gathering around the two ill-clad
beggars.
Antinous spoke: “Goat bellies, filled
with fat and blood,
Lie ready for supper. Let the victor
choose whichever he wishes;
Afterward he shall always share our
feast, and we will allow
No other beggar to enter here and
ask for food.”
Odysseus spoke with cunning: “It is
not right for a young man
To fight an old one, weak with
hunger. My evil belly
Urges me on, that blows may master
me. But all of you
Must swear a strong oath: no one
shall strike me with a heavy hand
To help Irus. Let him defeat me by
his own strength.”
They swore as he commanded.
Telemachus then spoke:

“Stranger, if your heart and fearless spirit urge you to ward off this man, Fear no other Achaeon. Whoever strikes you will fight Against more than one; I am your host, and the kings Antinous And Eurymachus, both wise, praise my welcome.”

Odysseus girded his rags around his loins. His great thighs, Beautiful and broad, appeared; broad shoulders and a powerful chest, Strong arms and legs. Athena stood beside him and enlarged The limbs of the shepherd of the people. The suitors were amazed. One said: “Irus will soon carry a heavy evil; look how the old man’s thigh Appears from beneath his rags.” Irus trembled; the servants forced him Into the middle, and his flesh shook upon his limbs.

Antinous rebuked him: “You should not exist if you fear this old man, Weak with age. If he defeats you, I will send you to the mainland, To King Echetus, destroyer of mortals, who will cut off your nose and ears, Draw out your genitals, and give them raw to the dogs.”

They raised their hands. Odysseus considered whether to strike him dead, Or give a lighter blow and stretch him on the ground. He chose the gentler, Lest the Achaeans recognize him. Irus struck his right shoulder;

Odysseus struck beneath the ear, crushing the bone. Dark blood rushed From his mouth; he fell in the dust, gnashing his teeth and kicking the earth.

The suitors laughed until they could scarcely stand.

Odysseus dragged him by the foot beyond the porch and set him Beside the courtyard fence. He put the staff into Irus’ hand:

“Sit here and keep the pigs and dogs away. Do not be lord Of strangers and beggars, wretch, lest a greater evil find you.”

Then he returned to the threshold, and the suitors came in laughing. Antinous placed before him a great goat’s belly filled with fat and blood. Amphinomus lifted two loaves from the basket and brought a golden cup:

“Hail, father stranger; may prosperity be yours hereafter, Though now you are held among many evils.”

Odysseus answered: “Amphinomus, you seem prudent, like your father Nisus Of Dulichium, whose good fame I have heard. Listen: nothing is weaker Than man among all that breathe and creep upon the earth.

While the gods give him strength and his knees move, he thinks no evil Will ever reach him. But when the blessed gods complete their grief, He bears it unwillingly, with an enduring heart; for a man’s mind is such

As the father of gods and men brings each day.

"I too once expected to be prosperous among men, and did much wrong,

Trusting my strength and my father and brothers. Let no man ever be lawless;

Let him quietly accept the gifts the gods bestow. I see the suitors here Cutting a man's possessions and dishonoring the wife of one Who will not long remain far from friends and native land.

May a god lead you home before you meet him; for I do not think

He and the suitors will part without blood once he enters this roof."

He poured and drank the sweet wine, and returned the cup to the herald.

Then he walked through the house, grieving, and his mind saw evil.

He could not escape his fate: Athena bound Irus to be subdued

By Telemachus's hands and spear.

Athena placed this thought in wise Penelope's mind:

To appear before the suitors, so their desire might grow,

And so she might be more honored in the eyes of husband and son.

She laughed falsely and said to her steward Eurynome:

"My heart wishes to appear before the suitors, hateful as they are.

I would speak to my son, and urge him not to keep company with all of them:

They speak kindly, but plan evil behind his back."

Eurynome answered: "You have spoken well. Go, tell your son, Wash your skin, anoint your cheeks, and do not go with your face

Always wet with tears; continual grief is not fitting.

Your son is now grown, the very child for whom you prayed to the immortals."

Penelope replied: "Do not persuade me to wash and anoint myself.

The gods destroyed my beauty when my husband sailed away.

Tell Autonoe and Hippodameia to come, that they may stand beside me In the hall. I would not go alone among the men; I am ashamed."

The old nurse went through the house to summon the women.

Athena then poured sweet sleep upon Penelope. She lay back,

And all her limbs relaxed. The goddess gave her immortal gifts:

She cleansed her lovely face with ambrosia, such as crowned Cytherea wears

When she joins the Graces' dance; she made her taller and fuller,

Whiter than sawn ivory. Having done this, she departed.

The white-armed women came with a sound of voices; sweet sleep released her.

She wiped her cheeks and said: "Ah, how deeply suffering has covered me! Would that pure Artemis now grant me a gentle death, so I might no longer

Waste my life lamenting, longing for
the excellence of my beloved
husband,

Who was preeminent among the
Achaean.”

She went down from her shining
chamber with two attendants.

When she reached the suitors, she
stood beside the roof-post,
Holding her shining veil before her
cheeks; one trusted maid stood on
either side.

The suitors’ knees gave way, and
desire enchanted every heart;
Each prayed to lie beside her.
She addressed Telemachus: “Your
mind and judgment are no longer
steady.

When you were a child, you thought
more wisely; now that you are
grown,

A stranger might say, seeing your
height and beauty, that you are the
son

Of a prosperous man, yet you have
no sound sense. What a deed has
happened

In this house, and you allowed the
stranger to be so abused!

If a guest should suffer such violence
while seated in our house,

It would be shame and reproach to
you among men.”

Telemachus answered: “I do not
blame you for anger, mother;

I know and understand what is good
and what is worse.

But I am still young, and men who sit
here strike me with evil thoughts;

I have no allies. The quarrel of Irus
and the stranger was not caused
By the suitors—he was simply
stronger. Would that Zeus, Athena,
and Apollo

Would make the suitors bend their
heads in our halls, some in the
courtyard,

Some within, their limbs loosened, as
Irus now sits by the doors,
Nodding like a drunk, unable to
stand or go home.”

Then Eurymachus addressed the
thoughtful queen:

“Daughter of Icarius, wise Penelope,
If all Achaeans saw you now in
Argos,

More suitors would dine here at the
dawn;

In beauty, stature, and inward
judgment,

You rise above the women of the
land.”

Penelope answered: “The immortal
gods

Destroyed my beauty when the
Argives sailed

For Troy, and my husband went with
them.

If he returned, and watched over my
life,

My fame and beauty would return
with him.

But now I suffer; some god brought
this grief.

“When he departed, taking my right
hand,

He said: ‘I do not think the
well-greaved Achaeans

Will all come home unharmed from
Troy. The Trojans
Are skilled with spear and bow, and
on the horse;
They turn the issue of a mighty war.
I do not know if some god will
release me,
Or whether I shall be taken there.
Meanwhile,
Care for the household. Remember
my father
And mother as you do now, or yet
more carefully.
And when our son has grown a
beard, then marry
Whom you desire, and leave this
house.' His words
Are all fulfilled. The hateful day
approaches;
Zeus has stripped away my
prosperity.
Yet this grief is bitter.'
"Nor is this how men court a worthy
woman,
Daughter of one whose wealth is
widely known.
The suitor brings cattle, strong
sheep, and gifts
For the marriage feast; no man eats
another's
Livelihood without a fitting
recompense."
Within his heart Odysseus rejoiced,
For she had drawn rich gifts from all
their hands,
And charmed them with her words,
though in her mind
She meant a very different thing.
Antinous

Then said: "Receive whatever gift an
Achaean
Brings here. To refuse a gift is not
right.
We will not go to field or workshop
till
You marry whomsoever is the best
among us."
They sent the heralds for the gifts.
Antinous
Brought a great many-colored robe,
twelve golden
Pins shining on it. Eurymachus
brought
A golden chain, with amber set
within,
That gleamed like sunlight. Two
attendants bore
Eurydamas' earrings, each with three
bright stones;
Pisander's servant brought a splendid
necklace.
Each Achaean brought another
offering.
Then to her chamber went the
queen, and all
The lovely gifts were carried after
her.
The suitors turned to dancing and to
song,
And waited for the darkness. When
it came,
They set three lamps within the hall,
and piled
Dry wood, long seasoned, newly split
with bronze;
Among it torches burned. The
patient servants
Kept watch beside the flames.
Odysseus spoke:

“Handmaids of one long absent, go
above
To your honored queen; sit beside
her, turn
The wool, or card it with your hands,
and give
Her pleasure. I will give these men
their light.
If they should wish to wait for
shining Dawn,
They shall not overcome me; I
endure.”
The women laughed, and looked
from one to one.
Then Melanthe, the daughter of
Dolios,
Whom Penelope had raised and
clothed like a child,
But who loved Eurymachus and slept
with him,
Rebuked the king: “Stranger, are you
mad? Why not
Go sleep within the smithy, or the
shelter
Of the assembly? Why speak so
boldly here
Among so many men? Has wine
possessed your mind,
Or were you always foolish? Do you
boast
Because you beat that beggar Irus?
Soon
Another, better than Irus, may arise
And break your head, and drive you
from the house,
Your garments red with blood.”
Odysseus looked upon her darkly: “I
will tell
Telemachus all these words, when I
go there;

He may cut you limb from limb
within this house.”
The women trembled at the threat,
and went
Through the hall, their knees grown
loose beneath them;
They thought he spoke the truth. He
stood beside
The lamps, visible to every eye, while
still
His heart bent toward the deeds not
yet complete.
Athena did not hold the suitors back
From stirring up his painful anger;
she desired
The grief to sink more deeply in the
heart
Of great Laertes’ son.
Eurymachus began to mock him:
“Listen, renowned suitors,
While I speak what my heart
commands. This man has not
Come to Odysseus’ house without a
god’s direction.
His head shines like a torch; there is
no hair upon it.
Stranger, would you work for me
upon the edge of my land?
I would give you wages enough,
repairing fences,
Planting tall trees; each year you
would have grain,
Clothing, and sandals. But you have
learned evil work:
You will not labor, but prefer to beg
among the people,
Only to feed your useless belly.”
Odysseus answered: “Would that a
contest of labor

Rose between us in spring, when the
days are long
And the green meadow opens. Give
me a curved sickle,
And take another; let us work fasting
until dark,
With grass before us. Or let there be
two tawny,
Well-fed oxen, equal in age and
strength, to draw
A four-acre fallow underneath the
plough; then you
Would see whether I could cut a
straight furrow.
If Zeus stirred war today, and I had
shield,
Two spears, and a bronze helmet,
you would see me
Among the foremost, and would not
mock my belly.
You are insolent and hard of mind,
and think yourself
Great because you keep company
with men no better.
If Odysseus returned, these wide
doors would grow
Narrow for you as you fled through
them.”
Eurymachus grew angry, seized a
footstool, and raised it to strike.
Odysseus, fearing him, sat at
Amphinomus’ knees. Eurymachus
struck
The cupbearer’s right hand; the
pitcher fell and rang, and the man
fell backward.
The suitors roared through the
shadowed hall.
Telemachus spoke: “You are mad;
you no longer hide your appetite or

drink.
Some god stirs you. Eat well, then lie
down at home when you wish;
I drive no one away.” The suitors bit
their lips in wonder at his bold
speech.
Amphinomus, glorious son of Nisus,
said: “Friends,
Let no one answer a just word with
hostile speech.
Do not strike the stranger, nor any
servant in
Odysseus’ house. Let the cupbearer
fill the cups;
Let us pour a libation and go home.
Leave the stranger
To Telemachus, for he came to his
door.”
His counsel pleased them. Mulius,
herald of Dulichium,
Servant of Amphinomus, mixed the
bowl and shared it.
They poured for the blessed gods,
drank as much
As their hearts desired, and went
away to sleep
Within their own houses.

Source range: Book 18. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 19

First-pass working translation

But in the hall alone remained the
steadfast king,
Debating with Athena how the
suitors should die.
He turned to his son: “Telemachus,
the weapons—
Take them from the hall and hide
them in the chamber.
If any man should ask us why, answer
him thus:
‘The smoke has eaten their bright
bronze; they are no longer
As when Odysseus sailed, but
dimmed beneath the rafters.’
Or say, ‘When wine has mastered
men, the iron in their hands
May turn against a brother; therefore
we have removed it.’
Leave us two swords, two spears, and
two round shields.”
“For wine may set a quarrel in their
breasts,
And brother strike at brother,
shaming all
The feast and marriage; iron draws a
man.”
Telemachus called the nurse,
Eurycleia: “Mother, keep
The women in the hall until I have
concealed
My father’s weapons in the chamber.
Smoke has dimmed
Their bronze, and I was still a child
when he went off;
But now I would place them safely
where no flame

Can stain them, and where the
suitors’ hands cannot reach.”
The nurse answered, “May you at last
take thought
For all your father’s house and guard
its wealth; but tell me,
Who will bring light to you, if you
forbid the women
To come and hold the lamps?”
Telemachus replied:
“This stranger will; I will not suffer
any idle man
To touch my stores, however far he
journeyed here.”
The nurse fell silent, and the doors
were barred.
Then he and his father bore away the
helmets, shields with bosses,
And spears that once had flashed
beneath his father’s hand.
Athena went before them, bearing a
golden lamp;
The walls shone round about as
though a fire were burning.
Telemachus marveled: “Father, what
a wonder! The walls,
The fair divisions, fir-beams, and tall
pillars shine
Before my eyes as though a fire were
blazing here.
Surely some god of the wide heaven
is within.”
Odysseus answered, “Silence, and
keep the thought within;
This is the custom of the gods who
hold Olympus.
Go now, and sleep. I shall remain,
To learn which women keep faith,
and which have grown insolent,

And hear what questions wise
Penelope will ask.”
Telemachus went into the chamber
where he slept
Whenever sweet sleep came over
him, and there he lay
Awaiting the bright dawn; Odysseus
stayed within,
Still weighing death for all the
suitors with Athena.
Then Penelope came down from her
bright upper chamber,
Like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite
when she walks
Among the deathless gods. Her chair,
inlaid with ivory,
And silver, carved with art, stood
near the fire;
Soft fleece was spread beneath it.
The white-armed women came,
And gathered up the grain and tables
and the cups
From which the arrogant men had
drunk; they threw the coals
From out the lamp-stands to the
floor, and laid on them
Much wood, that there might be
light and warmth together.
Melantho, shameless girl,
Again assailed the stranger: “Why sit
here in the darkness?
Go sleep among the benches, or beg
outside the doorway.”
Odysseus answered, “Girl, why do
you wound me so?
Necessity has clothed me in these
rags. Once I too
Was rich, and gave to beggars; now
the gods have broken me.

But take heed: the master of this
house may yet return,
Or this grown son may judge the
women’s conduct here.”
Penelope rebuked the girl: “How can
you insult a guest,
Who has come beneath our roof,
worn down by sorrow?
Eurynome, bring him a chair, and lay
a fleece upon it,
That he may sit and speak with me.”
The chair was brought;
The stranger sat, and she began: “Tell
me your lineage.
Who are you? From what country,
and what city, have you come?”
Odysseus answered first with praise:
“No mortal man
Could blame your beauty, grace, and
fame across the earth;
You are as when a blameless king,
who fears the gods,
Rules many strong peoples, and the
dark earth yields
Its wheat and barley, while the trees
bend under fruit,
The flocks are born in number, and
the sea gives fish,
Because his judgments are upright.
Ask me anything
Else in your house, but do not ask my
race or land;
That question would awaken grief
beyond my grief.
It is not seemly for a stranger,
weeping in
Another’s house, to sit and feed his
sorrow there,
Nor should the women murmur that
wine has overcome him.”

Then Penelope spoke: "Stranger, my heart is wasting.
The men who press upon me, here beneath this roof,
Consume the substance of my house. The noblest men
From Dulichium and Same,
From wooded Zacynthus, and from Ithaca,
Now court me against my will and waste my house.
I have no thought for stranger, suppliant,
Or herald who serves the people; longing for
Odysseus, my heart is wasting to the bone.
I told them I would marry when I had finished
Laertes' burial cloth, lest death should overtake the old man and the Achaeans blame me.
By day I wove the great web; at night, beside the torches,
I undid what the daylight had compelled my hands to make.
"For three full years I hid the matter from them all
And held the Achaeans by my words; but when the fourth year came,
A treacherous maid betrayed me. They entered and discovered
The work undone, and forced me to complete the shroud.
Now my parents urge me toward another marriage;
My son, once young and thoughtless, will not let me
Leave this house now; he is a man, and Zeus has given

Him honor. Yet he curses me to go, in grief
For the wealth the Achaeans consume, and knows
The care of his own house better than before."
Odysseus answered: "Lady, will you never cease
From asking of my lineage? You will give me
More grief than I possess. Yet I will speak,
Though justice bids a man who has been long
Away from his own country suffer much.
"There is a land called Crete, amid the wine-dark sea,
Beautiful, rich, and ringed with water; many
Are the men who dwell there, and ninety cities
Stand upon the land. Their tongues are mingled:
Achaeans live among the Cretans born of Crete,
The great-hearted Eteocretans, Cydonians,
Dorians of three tribes, and godlike Pelasgians.
In Crete is Cnossus, a great city, where
Minos, the nine-year king, held converse with
Great Zeus. Minos was the father of my father,
Great-hearted Deucalion; Deucalion begot
Me and the lord Idomeneus. But I was named

Aethon, younger born; Idomeneus,
older,
Was stronger. He sailed in the
hollow ships
To Ilium with the sons of Atreus.
“There I saw Odysseus, and gave him
gifts.
For the force of wind had driven him
to Crete,
When he was making for the land of
Troy,
And storms, after he rounded Malea,
held him
At Amnisus, where the cave of
Eileithyia
Opens beside the difficult harbor;
barely
Did he escape the storm. He climbed
to Cnossus,
To seek Idomeneus, and called
Odysseus
His guest and friend; but Idomeneus
had gone
Already with his ships to Ilium. He
was
The tenth or eleventh dawn away. I
led
Odysseus kindly to my house, and
loved him,
Though many treasures filled the
rooms. For him
And for his companions I brought up
meal and wine
From the people, and an ox to
sacrifice,
That they might fill their hearts.
Twelve days the bright
Achaeans stayed: the great North
Wind held them fast,

Nor let them stand upon the land;
some god
Had roused the bitter blast. On the
thirteenth
The wind fell, and they put out to
sea.”
He shaped the falsehoods, making
them resemble truth.
She heard him, and her tears ran
down; her skin
Melted like snow upon the mountain
peaks
When the East Wind thaws it, and
the West pours
Its warmer breath; the streams run
full below.
So her fair cheeks dissolved in tears
for the husband
Who sat beside her. Odysseus pitied
her,
Yet kept his eyes unmoving, as
though horns
Were fixed within his lids, or iron
held them;
By craft he hid the tears beneath his
eyes.
Then prudent Penelope tested the
tale again:
“Tell me the clothes he wore, and
how he looked;
Tell me his companions. I would
know the man.”
“His cloak was purple, double-folded,
soft as skin
Of a dried onion. Round the clasp of
gold
A hound held fast a dappled fawn
between
His forefeet, struggling, trembling,
though the dog

Held it and looked upon it. White as
driven snow
His tunic clung about him; in the sun
It shone. His dark hair curled like
hyacinth.
I gave him sword and cloak, and on
his body
The fringed tunic. With him went
Eurybates,
His herald, broad of chest and
rounded shoulder,
Dark of skin, and black-haired.”
She knew the clothes; they had been
made and given
By her own hands. Her knees grew
weak beneath her,
And tears fell down, dissolving all
her beauty.
Odysseus pitied her, yet hid his tears,
As one who hides a spring beneath
the stone.
Again he shaped the lie: “I heard of
him
Near Thesprotis, where Pheidon, its
king, received him.
Alive he was, and gathering gold and
bronze,
For he had lost his faithful friends
and ship
Upon Thrinacia, when the gods grew
angry
Because his men had slaughtered
Helios’ cattle.
The waves cast him upon the land of
men
Who live like gods, the Phaeacians;
they honored
His person as a god, and gave him
gifts,

And would themselves have sent him
safely home.
But he preferred to wander,
gathering wealth,
For no man understood the minds of
men
As well as that much-suffering
Odysseus.
Pheidon showed me the treasures he
had stored—
So much that ten generations might
be fed—
And swore beside his hearth that
ship and crew
Were ready to convey him to his
country.
But first he sent him to Dodona,
there to hear
From Zeus’s deep-leaved oak how he
should go,
Whether openly or hidden, after long
absence.
He lives, and soon will stand within
this land;
The waning month and the new
month shall not pass
Before he comes.”
Penelope answered: “May the word
be fulfilled!
Then you would quickly know my
love and gifts,
And every man who met you would
call you blessed.
Yet my heart tells me he will never
come,
Nor you receive a convoy from this
house;
For such as he was, welcoming every
guest,
No longer rule here among the men.”

Then she commanded the attendants
to wash him,
And spread a bed with blankets,
fleeces, and bright cloth,
That he might lie warm until the
golden dawn.
Odysseus said, "Let no young woman
wash my feet;
Only some old nurse, who has borne
her share of grief,
Should touch them." Penelope
answered him:
"Eurycleia nursed unhappy Odysseus
From his first hour. She knows the
ways of men."
She called the nurse, and ordered her
to wash him.
The old woman wept, and praised
the absent lord,
While cursing those who mocked the
ragged guest.
The nurse answered, "These
shameless women, all of them,
You do not let me wash you, though
the daughter
Of Icarius, wise Penelope, has
ordered it;
She whom I nursed, unhappy king,
from your first hour.
Many a stranger, worn with labor,
has come here,
But none so like in body, voice, and
feet."
The king replied:
"So all who have beheld us say the
same."
The nurse brought out a shining
bronze basin,
Poured cold water in it, and mingled
warm.

Odysseus sat beside the fire, turning
His face toward shadow, for he
feared her hands
Would find the scar and make his
name apparent.
She washed his feet; then touched
the ancient wound
That a white boar's tusk had made
above
His knee, on Parnassus, when he
hunted there
With Autolycus and all his sons.
The poem tells of Autolycus, most
famed
For theft and broken oaths, yet loved
by Hermes.
He came to Ithaca when Odysseus
Was newly born. Eurycleia placed
the child
Upon his knees, and asked him for a
name.
"Call him Odysseus," said the famous
man,
"The hated one; and when he comes
to Parnassus,
I will bestow my gifts upon him
there."
In later years they feasted on a bull,
Five years old; and at the dawn they
went
Up to the wooded mountain for the
hunt.
When Autolycus saw the child, his
sons embraced him
And spoke kind words; his mother
Amphithea, bending,
Kissed the child upon his head and
both bright eyes.
Then Autolycus called his glorious
sons to prepare

The meal. They led a five-year bull
indoors,
Skinned it, cut it skillfully, divided
it,
And set its portions on the spits to
roast.
They feasted through the whole day
until the sun
Went down, and lacked no share of
equal banquet;
When darkness came, they slept and
took the gift of sleep.
The dogs moved before them
through the thickets, and the sons
Of Autolycus came after them; the
morning sun
Struck the earth newly, rising out of
Ocean's stream.
They climbed the wind-beaten folds
of Parnassus,
And entered a deep thicket where no
wet wind passed,
No bright sun pierced, and leaves lay
thick beneath. A boar,
Great, white-tusked, sprang from the
brush and struck
The young man's knee; its tusk laid
open flesh,
But did not reach the bone. Odysseus
turned,
Drove his long spear, and felled it.
Then the sons
Bound up the wound, and with a
spoken charm
Stopped the dark blood. They healed
him well, and gave
Bright gifts, then sent him home
rejoicing to Ithaca,
Where his father and his
queen-mother asked him how

The wound was made; and he told all
the truth. So
He bore the scar he bears today.
Eurycleia had nursed him from his
first hour of life.
Laertes bought her with his wealth,
and honored her
Within the house as though she were
his wife,
Yet kept apart from her bed,
respecting his queen.
The old nurse knew the child before
he bore a name,
And now her hands, beneath the
rags, found the one mark
That years of wandering could not
disguise.
The nurse's fingers knew the scar.
The basin
Fell from her hands; the bronze rang,
and the water
Ran over the floor. Joy and pain
possessed her.
She touched his chin and cried, "You
are Odysseus,
My dear child!" Her eyes sought
Penelope;
But Athena turned the queen's mind
away.
Odysseus seized the nurse about the
throat:
"Be silent. I have come in the
twentieth year.
If Zeus and all the gods give me the
victory,
I will not spare the women who
dishonored us."
"I will be silent," said Eurycleia;
"Afterward, when some god has
brought the suitors down,

I shall tell you which women
dishonored you,
And which kept faith within these
halls.”
“I shall know them all,” Odysseus
replied.
She brought another basin; he hid
the scar
Beneath his rags, washed him with
oil, and drew his chair
Nearer the fire, where warmth might
reach his bones.
Then Penelope spoke of the sleepless
nights:
“By day I work, and watch the
women here;
But when the darkness comes, sharp
cares awake me.
My heart is like the green
nightingale’s,
The daughter of Pandareus, who
mourned Itylus;
It sings, yet grieves. Shall I remain
beside
My son, and guard the house that is
my own?
Or follow the best Achaeon, if he
brings
The richest gifts, and leaves me?”
She told the dream: “I saw twenty
geese come forth
From water, and eat wheat within
the house.
Then from the mountain came a
great-winged eagle;
He broke their necks, and rose into
the clear air.
The geese lay scattered. Then the
eagle spoke

With human voice: ‘This is no dream,
but waking truth.
The geese are those men; the eagle
was your husband,
Who has returned, and brings their
final doom.”
She woke within the dream
lamenting, and the women
Of Achaea gathered round her with
their braided hair;
Then the great bird returned and
settled on the roof,
And spoke again, so that her grieving
heart might hear.
When she awoke, she looked beside
the meal-trough
And saw the twenty geese still
feeding on the grain,
As they had done before; the eagle
had vanished.
Odysseus answered, “There is no
other meaning.”
But she replied, “Dreams have two
gates: one gate
Of ivory, and one of polished horn.
The dreams that pass through ivory
deceive;
Those that come through horn are
fulfilled. I fear
That this harsh dream has come by
ivory.”
“At dawn,” she said, “I will set out
twelve axes,
Like stakes, in one straight row.
Whoever strings
The bow of godlike Odysseus with
ease,
And sends an arrow through them
all, shall have me.

I will depart from this beautiful
house,
So wealthy, which I think I shall
remember
Even in dreams.” The king replied,
“Do not delay.
Before the suitors touch or string the
bow,
Odysseus will be home.”
Penelope answered, “If you wished to
sit beside me
And comfort me with speech, sweet
sleep would never fall
Upon my eyes; but mortals cannot
live without sleep.
The deathless gods have portioned
out a measure for
Each man upon the life-giving earth.
I go upstairs
To my still chamber and my bed,
forever wet
With tears since my Odysseus sailed
to Troy.”
“Sleep here, in this house, upon the
floor if you wish,
Or on the bedstead where the
women spread the fleeces.”
She said this, and climbed the stair
with her attendants
Toward her bed of tears. There she
lamented
Odysseus, till Athena, bright-eyed
goddess,
Poured sweet sleep upon her eyelids.

Source range: Book 19. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 20

First-pass working translation

Odysseus lay in the forecourt on an
ox-hide,
Unworked and brown, with many
fleeces heaped above him;
And over him Eurynome spread a
cloak.
The women who had joined the
suitors came forth,
Laughing together, careless in the
night.
His heart was stirred: should he
strike every one,
Or leave them yet to mingle with the
arrogant men?
Within his breast it growled, as a
bitch will growl
Beside her young when some strange
man draws near.
He struck his breast and spoke to his
own spirit:
“Endure, my heart. You endured a
worse thing once,
When the Cyclops ate your brave
companions there,
And craft brought you from the dark
cave, though you
Believed that you would die.” His
heart obeyed.
He turned from side to side, as one
beside a fire
Turns the great stomach of a sheep,
filled with blood
And fat, that it may roast on every
side;
So he revolved the thought of laying
hands

Upon the suitors, standing one man
against so many.
Then Athena came from heaven in a
woman’s likeness
And stood above his head. “This
house is yours,”
She said; “your wife is here, and your
son is such
As any man would pray to see beside
him.”
“All this is true,” Odysseus answered,
“goddess;
Yet how shall I confront these
shameless men,
Who gather here continually? And
when I have slain them,
If Zeus and you have granted me the
victory,
Where shall I flee? Consider this for
me.”
“You are a reckless man,” the goddess
said;
“A mortal trusts a comrade even
weaker than himself,
But I am a god, and I will guard you
through your labor.
If fifty companies of men should ring
us round,
All hungry for the battle, you would
drive them off,
And carry home their cattle and
their sheep.
Let sleep receive you; to keep watch
through the night
Is weariness itself.” She went again to
Olympus,
And sleep, the loosener of the limbs,
descended on him.
Penelope woke upon her soft bed
and wept.

When she had spent the whole of her
lament,
She prayed to Artemis: "Strike me
with your arrow;
Take my life now. Or let a storm
carry me
Through misty ways, and cast me at
the mouth
Of Ocean's backward-flowing
stream. Let the gods
Destroy me, or let Artemis release
her shaft,
Before I gladden any worse man's
heart
Than that of my Odysseus."
The song recalled the daughters of
Pandareus,
Whom Harpies bore away, when
both their parents died,
To serve the hateful Erinyes.
Aphrodite
Had fed them, while Hera, Artemis,
and Athena
Had granted beauty, wisdom, and
the skills
That women learn; yet still the
Harpies took them.
So Penelope desired a death that she
Might see Odysseus, and not become
the joy
Of some new husband. Even in death
there seemed
One comfort: after weeping through
the day,
Sleep makes the sufferer forget good
and evil.
But the god sent her a cruel dream,
in which
Odysseus stood beside her, as he
stood

When he marched forth with the
army. Her heart leapt,
And for a moment she rejoiced as if
the dream
Were waking truth.
Odysseus heard her weeping, and
within
His heart he wondered whether she
had known him.
He gathered cloak and fleeces from
the court,
And laid them on a chair within the
house;
The ox-hide he carried outside. Then
raised
His hands to Zeus: "Father, if by your
will
You brought me home, give me a
sign within;
And let another sign appear
without."
At once Zeus thundered from bright
Olympus,
Though not a cloud was seen across
the sky.
A mill-woman heard the omen.
Twelve there were
Who ground the barley and the
wheat for those
Who ate within the house; but she
alone,
The weakest, had not ceased from
labor. Then
She prayed: "You thunder from the
starry heaven,
Though no cloud walks above. Fulfill
this word:
Let this be the last meal the suitors
eat

In great Odysseus' house; their toil
has broken
My knees." The king rejoiced.
Telemachus rose,
Like an immortal, armed with sword
and spear,
His bright sandals upon his feet, and
stood
Upon the threshold.
Then asked Telemachus the nurse:
"Does the stranger
Still lie without, neglected of his bed,
And lacking food?" She answered:
"He drank his fill,
But said that hunger did not trouble
him.
When sleep came near, I offered him
a bed;
He chose the untanned hide and
fleeces in
The court, and the women spread a
cloak above him."
Then went Telemachus to the
assembly-place,
Two white dogs following at his
heels.
Penelope commanded Eurycleia
And all the women: "Spread the rugs
upon
The chairs well made; wipe every
table clean;
Wash out the mixing-bowls and
shining cups;
Draw water from the dark spring."
For soon
The suitors would return; it was a
feast day.
Some went to fetch the water; some
remained

Within. Then Eumaeus brought
three fat pigs.
Odysseus asked him: "Do they still
dishonor me?"
"May the gods avenge their violence,"
he replied.
"I weep when I remember your lost
lord;
Yet still I think he may return, and
scatter
The suitors. Had he perished, I
should long ago
Have gone to serve another king; but
still
I wait for him." "You are not foolish,"
said
Odysseus, "nor weak. By Zeus, by this
guest-table,
And by the hearth of great Odysseus,
I swear:
While you remain, the king shall
come again,
And with your eyes you shall behold
these men
Destroyed." The swineherd prayed
the word might stand.
Then Philoetius came, bringing a
barren cow
And fat goats; ferrymen had borne
them over.
He asked Eumaeus, "Who is this
stranger? He
Has the look of one who might have
ruled a house.
May fortune bring our lord home
again; I grieve
To think of brave Odysseus, for
when I was
Still young he set me over all his
cattle.

Now they are numberless; yet those
who eat
His goods command me, 'Bring the
beasts, that we
May feast on them.' They have no
fear of gods,
Nor any care for wise Telemachus;
already
They divide the absent master's
wealth. I would
Have fled to serve another king, but
still I hope
He will return and scatter all these
men."
Then, by the guest-table and the
hearth, Odysseus
Swore that the king would come, and
Philoetius
Would see the suitors fall. The
herdsman prayed
That this might be fulfilled.
Then Melanthius, the goatherd,
came, and brought
The finest goats among the herd for
slaughter.
He tethered them, and mocked the
beggar: "Why
Do you not leave? We shall not part
until
Our hands have tested you. You beg
without
Good order; there are other feasts
among
The Achaeans." Odysseus only shook
His head, and hid the evil in his
thought.
The suitors plotted death for
Telemachus,
When on their left an eagle swept
above,

And bore a trembling dove.
Amphinomus said:
"Friends, this design will not go
forward—the death
Of Telemachus. Let us remember the
feast."
Then he led them in.
They laid their cloaks upon the
chairs and benches,
Then sacrificed the sheep, the
fattened goats,
The pigs, the cow; they roasted all
the inward
Parts, mixed the wine in bowls, and
served the cups.
Philoetius apportioned bread in
handsome baskets,
While Melanthius poured the wine.
Telemachus
Set Odysseus within the well-built
hall, beside
The stone threshold, on a mean
stool, and placed
A little table there. He gave him
inward parts
And poured him wine in a golden
cup, then said:
"Sit here among the wine-drinkers. I
will ward
Their mockery and hands from you;
this house is not
Theirs, but my father's, which he
won for me.
Hold back your angry words and
hands, you suitors,
Lest quarrel rise." They bit their lips
and marveled
To hear the prince speak boldly.
Antinous answered:

“Though this is hard, Achaeans, still
we must endure
Telemachus; Zeus himself has made
him insolent.”
Yet no one stopped the feast, and no
one moved the king.
They marveled at the prince, though
no man softened toward him.
Heralds meanwhile led the sacred
hecatomb through the town,
And long-haired Achaeans gathered
beneath Apollo’s shade.
When the meat was roasted and
drawn from the spits,
They portioned out the splendid
feast; the men who labored
Set an equal share beside Odysseus,
as Telemachus
Had ordered. Athena would not let
the suitors cease
From their grievous insolence, that
the king’s heart might ache
The more, and gather wrath against
them in his breast.
Then Ctesippus of Same, trusting in
wealth
And desiring the wife of one long
gone,
Spoke: “It is wrong to rob a guest of
his share.”
“Let me too give him a guest-gift,
that he may not say
The bath-man or some other servant
gave more honor
Than I.” So speaking, he seized the
ox-foot from the basket
He took an ox’s foot from out the
basket
And hurled it. The king bent aside
his head

And smiled a dark and terrible smile;
The foot struck on the wall.
Telemachus
Rebuked him: “You have missed the
stranger. Had
You struck him, this spear would
have pierced your body,
And your own father would have
made your tomb,
Not prepared your wedding. Long
enough we bore
The slaughter of our sheep, the wine
they drank,
The dragging of our maids through
this our house.
Do not go on. If you desire my death,
Speak openly; I would far rather die
Than watch such deeds.”
Agelaus, son of Damastor, spoke:
“Friends, let no man
Answer a righteous word with
violence or anger;
Strike neither stranger nor servant in
this house.
And I would speak to Telemachus
and his mother,
If both could hear it kindly: while
your hearts still hoped
Odysseus would return, no blame
attached to you
For holding back the suitors. Better
so, if he came.
But now the truth is plain: he will
not reach his home.
Go, sit beside your mother, and
persuade her to marry
The best man, who will bring the
greatest gifts, that you
May feast and drink and keep your
father’s wealth,

While she goes to another's house."
Telemachus answered: "I do not hold
my mother back.
Let her marry whom she wishes; I
will give her gifts
Without number. But may no god
make me drive her,
Unwilling, from this house."
The suitors broke into unnatural
laughter; their minds
Were shaken. They ate bloody flesh,
and tears filled
Their eyes, while every heart
imagined mourning.
Then Theoclymenus, godlike in
form, spoke:
"What evil is this? Your heads, your
faces, and knees
Are wrapped in darkness. Cries burn
around you;
Your cheeks are wet with tears. The
walls and beautiful
Crossbeams drip blood. The porch
and courtyard swarm
With shades that rush toward
Erebus. The sun is gone,
And evil mist has covered all the
world."
Eurymachus called for the young
men to lead him out,
Since the seer spoke like night. "I
need no guide,"
Theoclymenus answered. "I have eyes
and ears, feet,
And a mind not contemptible. I go,
for I see
The evil coming upon you; no suitor
who devised
Outrage in Odysseus' house will
escape it."

He went to Peiraeus, who welcomed
him.
The suitors looked at one another,
mocking Telemachus,
And laughed at his guest. One
proposed putting the strangers
On a ship and sending them to Sicily.
Telemachus
Stayed silent, watching his father,
waiting for the hour
When he would lift his hands against
the shameless men.
Penelope, among the women, heard
every word.
Their feast had been sweet and
abundant; never would
Another be so hateful as the meal
that goddess
And strong man were preparing for
them, since first
They had devised such outrage.

Source range: Book 20. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 21

First-pass working translation

Athena breathed the thought into
Penelope's mind:
"Bring forth the bow, and with it
bring the axes—
The contest and the beginning of
death." She climbed
The stair to the chamber where the
treasures lay,
Gold, bronze, and iron fashioned by
the hands of men.
There, bent and polished, rested the
great bow,
And there the quiver held its arrows,
groaning softly.
Iphitus had given it, when Odysseus
met him
In Messenia, at the house of wise
Ortilochus.
Three hundred sheep and their
keepers had been stolen
By Messenian men from Ithaca, and
Odysseus,
Still young, had crossed the long
road to demand their return.
Iphitus sought twelve mares,
And the strong mules beneath them,
all of which had perished;
But Heracles, forgetting Zeus's
guest-right,
And the table where a guest is held
inviolable,
Killed him within his own house and
kept the horses.
Before that darkness fell, Iphitus
placed the bow

In Odysseus' hands. The king
returned a sword
And spear, the first beginning of
their friendship.
He left the bow at home, a faithful
token,
And never bore it with him to the
war at Troy.
Penelope's hand unlocked the
storeroom door;
The bronze key, with its ivory
handle, turned.
The doors cried out, as a
meadow-bull cries aloud
When he is loosed from grazing. She
stepped upon
The raised threshold, reached
upward, took the bow
Down from its peg, and with the
quiver sat,
Weeping, across her knees. When she
had spent
The whole measure of her lament,
she went
Among the suitors, carrying bow and
arrows;
Her maids bore forth the chest
where iron lay,
And bronze, the prizes of the coming
trial.
Beside the roof's supporting pillar
she stood,
The shining veil before her face, and
either side
A trusted maid attended her.
"You have consumed the house of
one long gone,"
She said, "and no other excuse can
hold you back.

So now this contest: whoever strings
the bow
Of godlike Odysseus with the
lightest hand,
And sends an arrow through the
twelve axes set,
Shall have me. I will leave this lovely
house,
Rich as it is, and think of it
hereafter,
Even in dreams, remembering what I
lost.”
Eumaeus took the bow in tears and
laid it down;
The cowherd, elsewhere, wept to see
the weapon
Of his old master. Antinous rebuked
them:
“Why trouble the woman with your
mourning? This bow
Will break the hearts of many
excellent men.”
Then wise Telemachus addressed the
suitors:
“What folly Zeus has planted in my
mind! My mother,
Though prudent, says she will depart
with another man;
I laugh, and take delight in my own
foolish heart.
Come, suitors, let us finish this
contest now.
There is no woman such as she in
Achaëa—
Not in holy Pylos, Argos, or
Mycenae,
Nor here in Ithaca or on the dark
mainland;
You know this yourselves, so why
should I praise her?

Do not delay the trial. I too will try
the bow.
If I can string it and send the arrow
through,
My grieving mother shall not leave
this house
To follow another, while I remain
alone,
Though I am grown and can take up
the prizes
My father won in contests before he
sailed.”
Telemachus sprang up, laid aside his
sword,
And dug one trench, long and
straight. He planted
The twelve axes in a row, and packed
the earth
About them. Standing on the
threshold, he tried.
Three times he strained the bow;
three times he let it go,
Already hoping to string it. On the
fourth
He would have drawn it, but
Odysseus nodded him back.
Then he told all the suitors to
attempt it in turn,
And set the arrow down beside the
polished boards.
Leodes, son of Oenops, who sat
nearest the mixing-bowl,
Took the bow first. He alone among
the suitors
Hated their lawless ways, and often
warned them;
Yet he could not bend the weapon.
Before his hands
Grew weary, he laid it down:
“Friends, this bow will grieve

Many among us. Better to die than
live here waiting,
Though some still hope to marry the
wife of Odysseus;
Let him try who can." Antinous
rebuked him,
Then ordered Melanthius: "Make a
fire within,
Set a great chair and fleeces near it,
bring us fat,
That the young men may warm and
oil the bow."
They kindled fire and rubbed the
bow, one after one,
Yet none possessed the strength.
Then the king went out
With cowherd and swineherd. "Am I
still hidden?"
He asked. "If Odysseus came
suddenly, would you fight
Beside your lord, or beside the
suitors? Speak."
Philoetius lifted both his hands to
Zeus:
"If you would fulfill this hope, let
that man return;
Then you would know my strength
and hands." The king
Answered them: "I am he. After
twenty years of pain
I have returned to my fatherland. I
know that I come
As welcome to you two alone among
the servants;
No other man has prayed to see me
home again.
If Zeus gives me the suitors, I will
bring you both
Wives, give you cattle and houses
near my own,

And you shall be companions to
Telemachus,
His brothers and his friends." Then
he showed the scar
The boar had made above his knee
on Parnassus.
They knew him, flung their arms
around their king,
Kissed head and shoulders, and wept
until the light
Would fail; but he restrained them:
"Stop your lament.
Someone may come out, and carry
word within.
Go in first, one by one; I will follow
after you."
He told Eumaeus: "When they refuse
the bow,
Bring it to me, with the quiver. Tell
the women
To bar the doors. If they hear groan
or clash,
Let none come running out; let each
remain at work."
To Philoetius: "Lock the courtyard
doors,
And fasten them with rope." They
went within,
And stood again beside their hidden
king.
Antinous could not bend the bow,
and urged
That they should leave the contest
for the feast.
Eurymachus had warmed it too, and
strained until
His heart groaned; then he said:
"This grief is not for marriage
Alone. There are other women in
Ithaca and elsewhere;

But shame will reach the sons of men
if we prove weaker

Than great Odysseus, whose bow no
hand can bend.”

Antinous answered: “The people
keep a holy feast

To the Archer today; no man should
string a bow now.

Set it aside. Let the cupbearer begin
the wine,

And tomorrow bid Melanthius bring
the finest goats,

That we may sacrifice to Apollo and
renew

The contest.” They poured water
over their hands

And crowned the bowls; after the
libation, then the stranger spoke:

“Let me attempt the polished bow
among you,

And learn if wandering and hunger
have not broken

The strength that once was mine.”
The suitors feared

The beggar might string it. Then
Antinous cried:

“You are drunk. Wine once drove
Eurytion mad

Among the Lapiths, at Pirithous’
feast;

His hosts dragged him from the
house and maimed him.

If you succeed, I’ll send you to King
Echetus,

The destroyer of men.”

Eurymachus answered: “Lady, we do
not believe

This man will take you from us; it is
not fitting.

But shame would reach the men and
women of Achaea

If, courting the wife of blameless
Odysseus,

We proved so much weaker than a
wandering beggar

That he could bend the bow and
drive an arrow through.”

Then wise Penelope defended the
guest:

“Eurymachus, what honor have you,
or what good name,

While you dishonor the house of the
best of men

And eat his wealth? A stranger who
comes beneath

Telemachus’s roof has a share by
right; it is not

Good or just to rob him. Let him try
the bow.

If Apollo grants him victory, I will
clothe him,

Give him a spear, a sword, and
shining sandals,

And send him where his heart
desires to go. I do not

Think he expects to lead me from
this house;

Nor should any suitor sit here
grieving for that.”

Telemachus replied: “No Achaeon
here

Has greater right than I to give or
keep

The bow—not even those who rule in
Ithaca,

Or over all the islands toward Elis.

Go to your chamber; take your loom
and spindle;

The bow belongs to men. Within this house
The power is mine." Penelope admired
The prudent word, and went upstairs with all
Her maids, weeping for Odysseus, till Athena
Sent sweet sleep down upon her.
The suitors mocked the prince and the beggar; one called
Telemachus the worst host, for keeping such a wanderer,
Starved for bread and wine, who knew no labor or strength.
Another urged him to send the strangers to Sicily,
That they might profit by them. They mocked Eumaeus too:
"Where are you carrying that curved bow, foolish swineherd?
Soon the dogs will eat you far from men, if Apollo
Will be gracious to us." The prince wished that
His strength were greater than the strength of all of them;
He threatened to drive the mockers from the court with stones,
And even to send one home in grief; if he were stronger
Than every suitor, he would quickly make one leave
This house, though they devised their evil here. They swallowed down
Their anger, laughing still. Then Eumaeus bore the bow
Toward Odysseus; within, Eurycleia barred the doors of the hall,

While loyal Philoetius locked the court
And bound the ship's hawser around the gate. He found
The old ship's rope beneath the portico, and fastened
The well-built doors, then returned to watch his lord.
The king turned over in his hands the bow,
And searched it everywhere, lest worms had eaten
The horns of him who once had borne it. Then
The suitors mocked: "Perhaps such bows lie waiting
At home; perhaps this stranger only longs
To handle what he cannot master." But as
A singer stretches easily the cord Around a lyre's peg, so the king strung it
Without an effort. With his right hand he plucked
The string; it sang as a swallow sings. Their skin
Changed color, and Zeus thundered from above.
Beside him lay one arrow, ready set. He drew it from the table, and let it fly;
It missed not one of all the axes, but passed
Through the whole row and sped beyond. "I have not
Missed or grown weary," he told Telemachus;
"My strength is firm, though these men have dishonored

Me with their scorn. Now is the hour
to make
The Achaeans' supper; after that,
more sport—
The song and lyre that crown a
feast.”

Telemachus understood the sign. He
girded on his sword,
And took his spear, then stood
beside his father,
Helmeted, bright bronze burning
near the throne.

Source range: Book 21. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 22

First-pass working translation

Odysseus cast the beggar's rags away
And sprang upon the threshold,
holding bow
And quiver. "The great contest now
is ended;
I shall attempt another mark, one no
man
Has struck before—if Apollo grant
me glory."
Antinous raised a golden cup, and
watched
The wine, not dreaming that, among
so many,
One man could bring black death
upon them all.
The bowstring sang. The arrow
struck his throat;
It passed clean through, and blood
came rushing out
From mouth and nostrils. From his
hands the cup fell;
His foot drove back the table, and
the food,
The roasted flesh, the vessels, rolled
in dust.
The suitors cried aloud and searched
the walls
For shields and spears, but no
weapons waited there.
Odysseus spoke: "You thought I
would not return.
You consumed my house, and forced
yourselves upon
The women while I lived, fearing no
god,

Nor any voice of men. Now death's
boundary
Stands over every one of you."
Then Eurymachus answered: "If
Antinous alone
Had lived, the evil might have ended
with him.
He plotted Telemachus's death, and
sought
To rule in Ithaca. We will repay you
all
The wine and food we consumed,
and add twentyfold
In bronze and gold; let that appease
your heart."
But the son of Laertes answered him:
"Not if you brought me all your
fathers' wealth,
Not if you added more from every
quarter,
Would I hold back my hands before
each man
Had paid the full price of his outrage
here.
There is no flight, no bargain. Fight,
or perish."
Eurymachus cried, "Draw your
swords! Use the tables
As shields, and rush together at the
bowman."
He seized a sharpened spear and
shouted aloud;
But Odysseus' arrow struck him in
the chest,
Beside the nipple, and was fixed
within
The liver. From his hand the sword
fell down;
He sank upon the table, scattering
food

And cups. Amphinomus came with
sword unsheathed;
Telemachus struck him from behind,
between
The shoulders. He left the spear in
him,
And ran for armor, fearing some
Achaean
Might wrench it free and turn it
back against him.
Telemachus returned and said:
“Father, I shall bring
A shield, two spears, and a bronze
helmet fitted
Close to the temples; I will arm
myself,
And give the herdsmen arms, for it is
better
To meet the danger fully.” Odysseus
said:
“Run, while my arrows last; they may
not drive us
From the doors while I stand here
alone.”
He brought four shields, eight spears,
four helmets,
For the king, for himself, and for
Eumaeus
And Philoetius. Odysseus laid aside
The bow and quiver, took a four-fold
shield,
Set on a horsehair-crested helmet,
and grasped
Two spears. At the far end of the hall
A narrow passage opened toward the
street.
“Guard this,” he said to Philoetius;
“one good man
May hold it against them all.”

Agelaus called, “Open the door, and
raise a cry
Throughout the town!” Melanthius
answered him:
“The courtyard doors are near, and
one good man
Could hold the passage; but the
armor lies
Within the chamber—go, and I will
bring it.”
Odysseus heard, and said: “One man
can hold
The passage. Bring the armor from
the storeroom;
Nowhere else did we conceal it.”
Melanthius climbed the secret way,
and brought
Twelve shields, twelve spears, and
twelve helmets down.
The knees of Odysseus failed beneath
him
When he saw the suitors arming at
the threshold.
Telemachus said, “I left the chamber
door ajar.
Send Eumaeus to learn whether a
woman did this,
Or Melanthius.” The two herdsmen
went,
And found him coming back with
armor once again.
They seized him, dragged him into
the chamber,
And bound his hands and feet
behind his back.
They hung him from a pillar beneath
the beams,
Leaving him living in his pain. Then
they returned

To stand beside the king, while
armed men gathered
Within the house and at the outer
threshold.
Athena came near in Mentor's form
and voice.
Odysseus rejoiced: "Why stand apart
from us,
When we are pressed?" Agelaus
warned the suitors:
"Mentor may now be friend to this
bowman. Let him
Fight at his side." The goddess made
no answer;
But stood apart, withholding her
divine sign.
Agelaus cried that Mentor's empty
promises
Had failed them; then the goddess
turned on him:
"Where is the strength you showed at
Troy, Odysseus?
Stand near me now, and see what aid
a friend
Can render friends amid their
enemies."
Yet still she tested both the king and
son,
Not giving victory at once.
"Cast now," Odysseus said. He struck
Demoptolemus;
Telemachus struck Euryades;
Eumaeus
Struck Elatus; and Philoetius struck
Peisander.
The suitors cast, but Athena made
their spears
Go wide—one against pillar, door,
and wall.

Amphimedon grazed the wrist of
young Telemachus;
Ctesippus struck Eumaeus above his
shield,
But the spear passed over him. Then
Odysseus
Struck Eurydamas; Telemachus
Amphimedon;
Eumaeus Polybus; and Philoetius
Struck Ctesippus: "Take this
guest-gift in return
For the ox's foot you cast at our
master."
Telemachus struck Leiocritus in the
belly.
Athena shook the deadly aegis above
the roof.
The suitors' minds gave way. They
fled the hall
Like cattle driven by a gadfly, while
the friends
Struck them from every side. Agelaus
cried,
"Escape through the passage! Raise
the town!" But then
Odysseus' arrow pierced him
through the throat.
The bodies lay in blood and dust,
like fish
Drawn from the gray sea and flung
upon the shore.
The king searched the house; not one
had fallen outside
His reckoning.
Then Leiodes clasped the knees of
the returning king.
"No guilt is mine," he cried, "in word
or deed;
No insolence have I devised or
wrought.

I sought to check the others when
they sinned,
And turned their hands from
outrage—but in vain.
Spare me, for I was never like the
rest.”
But stern Odysseus answered from
the blood:
“You poured the wine; you shared
their long-drawn feasts;
You sat among them while they
shamed my house.
No suitor here is clean of what was
done.”
He seized the sword still warm
within his hand,
And struck him down beside the
altar-stone.
Then Phemius, singer of the halls,
stood near
The doors, his lyre held trembling in
his grasp.
Two paths he weighed within his
troubled heart:
To flee and cling beneath the
thunderer’s altar,
Or clasp the knees of him who now
had come.
At last he laid his hollow lyre upon
The ground between the
mixing-bowl and throne,
And took the knees of great
Odysseus.
“I beg you, lord, have mercy on my
life.
Not of myself I filled their feasts
with song;
A god has planted every kind of lay
Within my breast, and these men
forced my voice

To praise their pleasure in this
ravaged house.
The song was mine; the feast and
crime were theirs.”
Telemachus answered swiftly:
“Father, spare him!
He is not guilty; he sang beneath
compulsion.
And Medon too—our herald, who,
when I was young,
Kept watch beside me—lies
concealed from death.”
For Medon crouched beneath a
newly flayed
Ox-hide, and there lay hidden from
the swords.
At once he rose and clasped
Telemachus’ knees.
Odysseus heard, and laid his anger
down.
“Let both sit here,” he said, “beneath
the altar;
The death that sought them shall not
find them here.”
So singer and faithful herald sat
apart,
Their faces pale, their hands upon
the stone,
And watched the death that had
passed over them.
Odysseus called for wise Eurycleia.
Telemachus opened the door and
brought her in.
She saw the dead men, the blood,
and the king
Spattered like a lion fresh from
feeding;
She would have cried aloud, but he
restrained her:

“Rejoice in silence. These men met
the doom
Their violence made. Now tell me
which of all
The women in this house have
scorned our name.”
The nurse replied: “Fifty serve within
these halls;
Twelve have forgotten shame, and
neither me
Nor Queen Penelope did they
respect.”
Odysseus told her not to wake the
queen,
But summon all the women who had
sinned.
Then to Telemachus, and to both the
herdsmen,
The king gave orders: “Wash the
chairs and tables;
With water and the sponges scour
the hall.
Scrape from the floor this black and
clotted shame,
And carry forth the bodies to the
door.
Bring in the women who have turned
against us;
Set them apart, between the dome
and fence.”
The women bore the dead men from
the house,
Supporting one another, weeping
low;
Then washed the chairs and tables,
while the men
Scraped from the floor the blood and
all its refuse.
When ordered stood again the
echoing hall,

They drove the faithless women to
the place
Between the courtyard wall and
rounded roof.
Telemachus spoke: “They poured
dishonor here
Upon my mother and upon myself;
They slept beside the men who
sought our ruin.”
Around the dome, from one great
pillar stretched,
He cast the cord, and lifted it so high
That no foot touched the earth
beneath the row.
There, in a line, the women hung;
their feet
Moved for a little, then were still as
dust.
And Melanthius they dragged from
his dark place.
His nose and ears they severed; hands
and feet
They cut away, and portioned him to
dogs—
A final feast for those whose feast
had turned
The house of the returning king to
death.
Then called Odysseus for sulfur and
fire,
That he might cleanse the house, the
hall, the court,
And told the nurse to summon forth
the queen
And all the women. But wise
Eurycleia
Answered him: “First put your
mantle on;
You stand in rags, not as a king
should stand.”

“Let fire be first,” he said; “the house
must breathe.”

She brought the sulfur and the living
flame;

He purified the hall, the house, the
court.

Then through the rooms she moved,
bearing the light,

And called the women. From their
chambers came

The faithful ones; around Odysseus
pressed,

And kissed his head, his shoulders,
and his hands.

Within him rose the sweet desire to
weep,

The longing for lament; for in his
heart

He knew them every one, and they
knew him.

Source range: Book 22. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Odysseus and Telemachus reclaim the hall

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 23

First-pass working translation

Eurycleia climbed the stair with joy,
and cried:

“Awake, dear child! Odysseus is here
at last.

He has destroyed the men who
consumed his house,
Who ate his substance and oppressed
your son.”

Penelope answered, “The gods have
made you mad.

Odysseus is dead; some deathless
power has slain
The suitors, since no mortal could
have done it.”

But the old nurse swore: “The
stranger whom they mocked—
That beggar whom they
dishonored—is your husband.”

“I do not deceive you, child,” the
nurse replied;

“I speak the truth: Odysseus is
within,

The stranger whom they scorned. I
knew him by the scar

The boar’s white tusk once drove
above his knee.

I saw it when I washed his feet, and
meant to tell you;

But he caught me by the breast and
held me silent,

Wise in his thoughts. If I have
spoken falsely,

Let me die the most pitiful death.”

Penelope answered: “Hard it is for
mortals

To hide the counsel of the gods,
though one be wise.

Yet come, old nurse; go with my son
and me,

That I may see the suitors dead, and
him

Who dealt their death.”

Telemachus had known the secret,
yet had held

His tongue until the vengeance was
complete.

He clasped the nurse and asked how
one man alone

Had overcome so many. “I did not
see the first,”

She said, “but heard the groaning of
the slain,

While we, the women, crouched
behind the doors.

Then you called me. I found him in
the hall,

Standing among the dead, while fire
and sulfur

Were cleansing all the house. Come
now; the wish

Of all three—yours, his, and mine—is
fulfilled.”

Penelope came down, uncertain in
her heart

Whether to question him from
where she sat,

Or run and kiss his head and both
his hands.

She crossed the threshold, and in the
firelight

Sat opposite, looking at him now and
then,

Yet silent, for his blood-stained
clothes concealed him.

Telemachus cried, "Mother, why do you remain
Apart from him? After twenty years of labor
He has returned, and you will not speak to him."
"My heart is struck with wonder," she replied.
"I cannot speak, nor look upon his face,
Nor ask him questions. But if truly he is he,
We shall know one another by the signs
That no one else has learned."
Odysseus smiled and said:
"Let your mother prove me as she will; perhaps
She holds me cheap because my garments cling
With filth and rags, and does not yet believe
I am the man I am. But we must find a way
To bring this matter to its wisest end.
We have destroyed the pillars of the town—
The men whom Ithaca called its greatest sons;
Consider now what answer we shall make."
But wise Telemachus replied: "You see it best.
Your counsel is the keenest among men;
We shall go with you, nor lack courage while
Our strength remains."

Then Odysseus answered: "First let us wash
And clothe ourselves; command the women too.
Let the divine singer lead a joyous dance,
That those outside may think a wedding fills
The house, and no swift rumor of the dead
Run through the town before we reach our fields."
They washed and dressed; Phemius took his lyre,
And stirred the longing for song and dance.
Outside, a passerby heard the sound and thought
The wife of a long-absent husband had at last
Chosen another man.
Eurynome washed and anointed Odysseus;
Athena poured beauty over his head and shoulders,
Made him larger and fairer to behold; his hair
Fell in curls like hyacinth. He sat before Penelope:
"The gods have given you a heart harder than stone.
Nurse, make up a bed outside the bedchamber,
With fleeces, cloaks, and shining coverlets."
Penelope told the nurse to move the steadfast bed.
Then from the king there broke a startled cry:
"No easy task is this, not even for

A craftsman skilled, unless a god has
come

To lend his hand. No mortal man
alive

Could shift it. I myself constructed
it:

Within the court there grew an olive
tree,

Its trunk a pillar, broad and
flowering still.

Around its rooted stem I raised the
chamber,

Fitted the doors, and polished all the
wood;

I shaped the bed from that living
sign,

And over it stretched shining
ox-hide thongs,

With gold and silver and bright
ivory.

Tell me: does that rooted bed still
stand,

Or has some other hand cut through
its base?"

Penelope knew the secret sign. She
ran to him,

Embraced his neck, and kissed his
head, saying

That she had been wary, for many
people planned deceit.

Even Helen, daughter of Zeus, would
not have shared

A foreign bed if she had known the
Achaean

Would bring her home. Only
Odysseus and Penelope,

And one maid, Actoris, knew how
the bed was made.

So he overcame her heart, hard
though it had been.

They wept like sailors who, when
Poseidon breaks

Their ship, set foot at last upon the
land; and still

Odysseus would not loose his arms
from her.

Dawn would have appeared while
they lamented, but Athena

Held the long night and checked the
sun's swift horses,

Lampus and Phaethon, from
bringing light to mortals.

Odysseus told Penelope their labors
were not finished;

The shade of Tiresias had foretold
another,

Measureless toil. Yet he said they
should go to bed

And take their pleasure in the gift of
sleep.

Penelope asked him to tell the labor
still ahead.

Odysseus answered: "Tiresias
commanded me

To carry a well-balanced oar inland,
until

A traveler, seeing it, should mistake
it for

A winnowing fan—proof that the
people there

Know neither sea nor ships nor
shaped oars. Then

I must set the oar within the earth,
and sacrifice

A ram, a bull, and a boar to
Poseidon;

Returning home, make holy
hecatombs

To all the deathless gods who hold
the sky.

At last a gentle death will come from
the sea,
In prosperous old age, with all my
people
Living in happiness.” Penelope
answered:
“If the gods grant such years, may
they also grant
Escape from all the evils pressing us.”
Then Eurynome and the nurse
prepared the bed
Beneath the lamps. The old Eurycleia
Returned into the house; Eurynome
led
The reunited pair toward the
marriage bed.
Telemachus, the herdsmen, and the
women
Let fall the dance and rested in the
shade.
Long did the husband and the wife
delight
Their hearts with speech. Penelope
recalled
The suitors’ slaughter of the cattle
and sheep,
The wine they drew from jars within
the house;
And he told all he had endured, and
all
He had made others suffer:
Lotus-Eaters,
The Cyclops, Aeolus, the storming
sons
Of Laestrygon, Circe and the dead,
The Sirens’ song, Scylla, Charybdis’
throat,
The Sun’s forbidden cattle, and the
bolt

Of Zeus, Calypso, and the
Phaeacians.
Thus each exchanged the burden of
the years,
Till sleep came softly and released
their cares.
At dawn the king addressed his
faithful wife:
“The news will spread with the
returning sun;
The suitors’ kindred will arise for
blood.
Remain above with all your women;
do not
Go forth, nor question those who
come and ask.”
Then he awoke Telemachus, and
called
The cowherd and the swineherd; all
were told
To arm themselves. They opened
wide the doors
And went forth, with Odysseus at
their head.
Athena wrapped them swiftly round
with night
As through the city they went out
toward
The orchard and old Laertes. Behind,
The false wedding song still guarded
their departure.

Source range: Book 23. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Penelope recognizes Odysseus beside the rooted olive bed

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 24

First-pass working translation

Hermes, the Guide, the Slayer of
Argus, summoned
The souls of all the suitors from the
house.
His golden wand could close the eyes
of men,
Or wake them, whomsoever he
desired;
With it he drove the shadows down
the dank roads;
The shades gave a thin, bat-like cry,
and followed,
As birds fly home when evening
folds the hills.
They passed the streams of Ocean,
the white rock,
The Gates of the Sun, and the people
of dreams,
And came at last to that asphodel
meadow
Where dwell the souls, the images of
the dead.
There they found Achilles, son of
Peleus,
Patroclus, Antilochus, and Ajax,
Fairest and strongest of the Danaans
all,
After the great Achilles.
The meadow held the images of men,
Not bodies, but the memory of their
breath;
And Hermes urged the newly dead
onward,
Past the pale landmarks of the
sunless world.

Then Agamemnon's shade drew near
to them,
And Achilles, seeing him, addressed
the king:
"Son of Atreus, we believed that
Zeus, who bears
The thunder, favored you above all
other men,
Because you ruled so many strong
Achaeans
Among the Trojans, where we
suffered grief.
Yet an evil fate was waiting for you
there,
The fate no mortal born beneath the
sun
Can flee. Would that you had fallen
at Troy,
Far from Argos, in the hour of battle!
Then all the Achaeans would have
raised your mound,
And you would have won great glory
for your son.
But now you were condemned to die
the most
Pitiful death."
Agamemnon answered: "Blessed son
of Peleus,
Godlike Achilles, who died at Troy,
far from
The land of Argos! The best of
Trojan men
And Achaean men fell round you,
fighting for you;
While you lay in the dust, your great
body
Forgotten among the dust and
chariot wheels.
All day we fought, and would not
cease at all,

Had Zeus not raised a tempest from the sky.
When we had carried you back to the ships,
We laid you on the bed and washed your flesh
With warm water and with fragrant oil. The Danaans
Poured hot tears over you and cut their hair.
Your mother came from the sea with immortal maidens;
Her cry rose terribly across the water,
And fear seized every Achaean in the camp.
Then Nestor, who had always known wise counsel,
Held us back and said: 'Stay, Argives; do not flee.
The mother of the dead man comes from the sea
With her companions, to behold her son.'
The daughters of the ancient sea-god stood
Around you, mourning, and clothed your body
In garments that no mortal hand had woven.
The nine Muses answered one another in song;
No Achaean could have watched them and remained
Without his tears. For seventeen days and nights
We mourned you, immortals and mortal men;
On the eighteenth we gave you to the fire,

Slaughtering many sheep and crooked-horned cattle.
You burned in the garments of the gods, in oil
And honey sweet; and many Achaean heroes,
On foot and mounted, circled the pyre in arms,
And the ground rang beneath them.
"When Hephaestus' flame had finished its work,
At dawn we gathered your white bones, Achilles,
Washed them with unmixed wine and shining oil,
And laid them in a golden urn your mother gave,
A gift of Dionysus, made by Hephaestus.
There your bones lie mingled with Patroclus,
But Antilochus rests apart, for you honored him
Above the rest of all your companions after
Patroclus died. Around your bones we raised
A great and splendid mound beside the shore,
On a headland above the broad Hellespont,
That men who live now, and those born afterward,
May see it from the sea. Your mother asked
The gods for beautiful prizes and set them forth
Before the noblest Achaeans. You have stood

Beside the tombs of many dead
heroic kings,
When young men girded themselves
for funeral games;
But never would you have seen games
such as those
Thetis, the silver-footed goddess,
gave for you.
You were beloved by the gods. Even
in death
Your name was not destroyed; your
glorious fame
Will live among mankind forever.
But what joy
Was mine, after so many wars? Zeus
planned my death
On my homeward road, at the hands
of Aegisthus
And my accursed wife.”
The two shades spoke thus together.
Then the suitors,
Led by Hermes, came near; and
Agamemnon knew
Amphimedon, the son of Melaneus,
His guest-friend from Ithaca. He
asked:
“Amphimedon, why have you all
come beneath
The dark earth, chosen men and all
of one age?
No city could have gathered finer
men.
Did Poseidon overcome you on your
ships,
Raising harsh winds and long waves?
Or did enemies
Destroy you on the land, while you
were cutting
Cattle and sheep, or fighting for a
city

And women? Tell me, for I claim to
be your friend.”
Amphimedon answered him, an
Ithacan guest-friend:
“These men found death within
Odysseus’ house.”
Agamemnon remembered: “I once
came there
To urge Odysseus, with Menelaus,
To sail beneath the war-wind bound
for Troy.”
Then Amphimedon told the whole
account.
“We wooed his wife. She neither said
outright
That she would marry, nor
completed the marriage;
Instead she thought of another
stratagem.
She set a great, fine web upon the
loom
And spoke among us: ‘Young
Achaean lords,
Though godlike Odysseus is dead,
wait still,
And do not hasten marriage, till my
hands
Have finished this great
winding-sheet for Laertes,
The hero’s father. Let me not be
blamed
Among the women, when death
takes him, if he lies
Unburied, lacking all the honors
due.’
“By day she wove it; when the torches
burned,
By night she loosened every thread
again.

Three years she hid the work and
held us fast;
But in the fourth a woman who knew
the secret
Betrayed it. Then she had to finish
the cloth.
At last a god brought Odysseus to
the farm,
Disguised as some poor, miserable
old beggar.
No man knew him. They mocked
him, struck him,
Until Zeus roused the purpose in his
heart.
With his son he concealed the
weapons; when
The bow was brought, he strung it,
sent the arrow
Through all the axes, and destroyed
us there.
We perished in the house, and our
dead bodies
Lay still unwashed.”
Then Agamemnon praised the son of
Laertes:
“Fortunate man, who won a wife so
wise!
How well Penelope remembered
him. Her fame
Shall never die; the immortals will
make song
For her among mankind. Not like the
daughter
Of Tyndareus, who slew her lawful
husband,
And earned a hateful song, bringing
hard fame
On all the women—even the good.”
They came to the well-built farm of
Laertes,

Bought long ago, when he was young
and strong.
There stood the house, the
cattle-yard, the servants;
A Sicilian woman kept the old man
there,
Far from the city. “Go,” Odysseus
said,
“Telemachus, and you two herdsmen,
choose
The best of all the pigs, and make
our meal.
I will go first and test the heart of my
father.”
He found him in the orchard,
digging round a tree.
His tunic was foul and patched; sewn
cowhide
Covered his legs; gloves guarded
either hand
Against the thorns; a goat-skin cap
was drawn
Upon his head. These rags increased
his grief.
Odysseus saw him, and his eyes grew
wet.
Should he embrace him now, and
name himself,
Or first inquire and prove the old
man’s mind?
He chose the test. “Old man,” he said,
“your orchard
Is tended well; no tree, no vine, no
fig
Is lacking. Yet the man who works it
seems
Wasted by age and sorrow. Whose
servant are you?
Whose land is this? Tell me if this is
Ithaca.”

Laertes answered, "Yes, the country
is Ithaca.
But I serve one whom men have told
me came
Home after many years. Would that
Odysseus
Had returned sooner, before the
suitors ate
His substance. Then this orchard and
his house
Would not have been devoured."
The king replied, "I am that son. I
have come
In the twentieth year. The men who
wronged me
Have paid their debt." Yet still the
old man doubted.
Then Odysseus showed the scar the
boar had made,
And named the trees his father gave
him once:
Thirteen pear trees, ten apple trees,
and forty
Fig trees; and fifty rows of vines,
promised
When every season brought its fruit
to ripeness.
Laertes' knees gave way; his heart
collapsed.
He clasped the earth and prayed
aloud to Zeus.
Odysseus ran to him, embraced and
kissed him:
"Father, I am your son; I have come
home,
And have destroyed the suitors." The
old man asked
For one more sign. The scar, the
counted trees,

The garments and the bronze that he
had taken
From the dead were shown. Laertes
stood erect,
Like one of the immortals. The
Sicilian woman
Washed him and clothed him;
Athena touched his head,
And made him larger, fairer to
behold.
The old man and his son went back
within the house.
Then Dolius and his sons came from
the orchard,
Wearied with labor. From the
threshold called
The Sicilian woman, and Laertes
spoke:
"Odysseus has returned." The old
man ran,
Embraced and kissed him; all his
sons drew near,
And gathered round the long-lost
lord of Ithaca.
Then spoke Odysseus: "If the
kinsmen rise
Of those we slew, and come against
this farm,
Will you stand fast beside us?" Dolius
answered:
"Where else should we go? We have
no refuge now
But this house and yourself." They
armed in bronze,
And stood together, waiting for the
storm.
The tidings flew throughout the
island. Kin
Of the dead suitors bore their bodies
forth,

And buried them with lamentation:
wives
And fathers cut their hair and raised
the cry.
Then
In the assembly-place they met, their
sons
And brothers mourned. Eupeithes
rose among them,
Antinous' father, grief burning in his
heart:
"He went to Troy," he cried, "and all
his friends
Were lost with him; yet now this son
of Laertes
Has killed the noblest youth of
Ithaca.
Come, let us follow, ere he reach his
ship
And flee beyond the sea. Let
vengeance rise!"
Then Medon came, and Phemius,
taught of song;
They stood before the people, and
the herald
Spoke: "I saw no mortal hand alone
at work.
A god stood by Odysseus—now in
Mentor's
Shape, now in another." Wise
Halitherses
Confirmed him: "These men brought
this evil on;
They would not cease from violence."
Some cried
For war; the rest sat silent, fearing
grief
That followed where Eupeithes led
the way.

The people listened. Medon told
them all
That he had seen: the doors made
fast, the bow
Bent by the stranger, and the first
man struck;
Then how the son stood beside his
father, how
They fought together, and how the
women died
Who had dishonored the returning
king.
Phemius, the singer, spoke of his own
escape:
He had been forced to sing before
the men,
Yet when the slaughter opened he
had knelt
Beside the herald, clutching the great
lyre,
And begged for mercy. They had
spared his life.
"No mortal strength alone," he said,
"could do
What I beheld. The gods themselves
were there."
Then old Halitherses rose, and raised
his voice:
"You know the truth. I warned the
suitors long
Ago, when first the omens showed
the man
Would come again. They mocked
me, and they filled
His house with feasting, while his
goods grew thin.
Let no man now pursue a further
grief.
The blood already poured will not
restore

The dead; but if you march, more
sons will fall,
And Ithaca will mourn them as it
mourns
The men who lie beneath Odysseus'
roof."
He spoke; but grief and anger closed
their ears.
The kinsmen lifted shields, and
Eupeithes
Called out that no man who had
suffered loss
Could sit at home while those who
did the deed
Went free. Some rose and followed
him; the rest
Remained, unwilling either to
forgive
Or join a quarrel that would empty
every
House of its men. Thus through the
town the cry
Of vengeance moved, while in the
distant fields
The house of Laertes made ready
arms.
So Eupeithes and his company
marched
Against the farm. Meanwhile within
the house
Of Zeus the immortals gathered.
Pallas asked:
"Shall this contention still endure, or
shall
There be an end?" And Zeus replied:
"Let him
Rule as before; but let the people
cast
The slaughter from their minds, and
love each other

As once they did. Let wealth and
peace return."
Then Athena, in the shape of
Mentor, went
Down to the earth.
Odysseus and his friends put on their
arms.
Laertes prayed to Pallas; through his
limbs
The goddess poured new strength
and youthful courage.
His knees, once slack with age, grew
firm beneath him;
His hands remembered spear and
shield. The two lines
Met before the farm. Eupeithes
Lifted his spear; but ere he cast it
forth,
Laertes struck him in the space
between
The eyes. The helmet rang; the old
man fell.
Then rushed Odysseus and his son
against
The fleeing ranks, with sword and
spear, resolved
To follow vengeance to its final
breath.
But Zeus cast down a smoking
thunderbolt
Before Athena's feet. The goddess
cried:
"Hold, son of Laertes; end this equal
war,
Lest wide-ruling Zeus be angered."
He obeyed.
The Ithacans let fall their arms and
fled
Toward the city, terrified; and Zeus

Thundered once more. Then Pallas,
wearing still

The form of Mentor, established on
both sides

The oaths of friendship. So the
immortal powers

Made peace among the people, and
Odysseus

Ruled once again in Ithaca.

Source range: Book 24. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.